

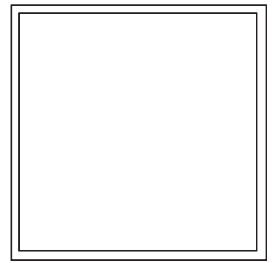
SELF-PACED Learning for a FAST-PACED World

Coaching for High Performance

VIVETTE PAYNE

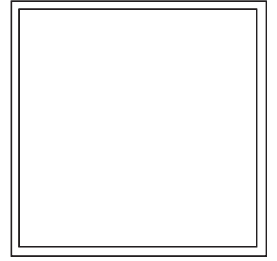


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Coaching for High Performance

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Vivette Payne

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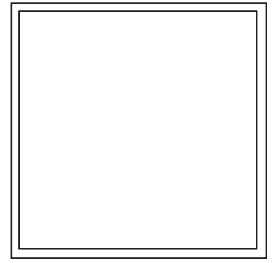
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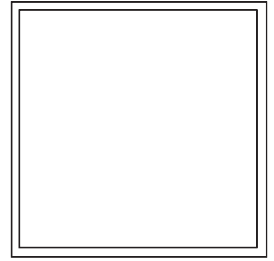
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About This Course

Coaching lies at the heart of management, and the greater the need for stronger business performance, the greater the need for managers and supervisors to be good coaches. *Coaching for High Performance* helps students understand the role, purpose, and key responsibilities of coaches in organizations. It clearly demonstrates the value of coaching and the ways in which effective coaching enables the enterprise to deliver strong results both in both the short and long term.

Athletes and those in the performing arts get coaching on a regular basis, enabling them to reach and maintain peak performance. In business, we know that those individuals who have a coach who understands their passion, goals, and aspirations are able to maximize their talents and deliver outstanding results.

Today, a strong commitment to coaching is a major factor in helping retain the best employees. Businesses are asking people to acquire new knowledge, master state-of-the-art skills, take risks, and try out unfamiliar behaviors. The support of a trusted coach helps individuals and organizations excel and meet competitive challenges with confidence.

Coaching for High Performance enables students to master this key management development tool. Following a seven-step coaching process, students learn how to communicate performance expectations, assess coachees' skills, establish the purpose of coaching, agree on a coaching contract, conduct coaching conversations, vary their coaching style, create the coaching plan, monitor performance, and learn what needs to be done in subsequent coaching sessions. Students master the techniques needed to handle difficult coaching conversations involving conflict or strained emotions. The text highlights strategies for handling special coaching situations, including how to coach various types of teams effectively, how to link motivation and coaching, and how to successfully coach each segment of a multigenerational workforce, from Baby Boomers to Gen Xers.

Coaching for High Performance features assessments, exercises, and scenarios that provide an interactive learning experience and enable students to

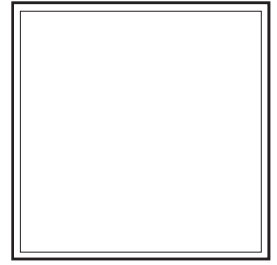
evaluate their own and others' skill levels, test new concepts, and measure their progress.

Vivette Payne is a consultant and writer who specializes in organization, team, and personal development. Her expertise includes leadership coaching, team building, the custom design and delivery of leadership and other skill development programs, and facilitating planning and strategy development.

Vivette also works with organizations to design human resource systems that enable greater competitiveness and organizational effectiveness. She partners with a network of associates to bring clients a depth and range of expertise in organization, team, and personal development.

Vivette is the author of *First-Level Leadership: Supervising in the New Workplace, Second Edition* (AMACOM). She is also the author of *The Team Building Workbook* (AMACOM).

She holds a bachelor's degree in psychology and master's degree in organization development.



How to Take This Course

This course consists of text material for you to read and three types of activities (the pre- and post-test, in-text exercises, and end-of-chapter review questions) for you to complete. These activities are designed to reinforce the concepts introduced in the text portion of the course and to enable you to evaluate your progress.

PRE- AND POST-TESTS*

Both a pre-test and post-test are included in this course. Take the pre-test before you study any of the course material to determine your existing knowledge of the subject matter. Submit one of the scannable answer forms enclosed with this course for grading. On return of the graded pre-test, complete the course material. Take the post-test after you have completed all the course material. By comparing results of the pre-test and the post-test, you can measure how effective the course has been for you.

To have your pre-test and post-test graded, please mail your answer forms to:

**Educational Services
American Management Association
P.O. Box 133
Florida, NY 10921**

All tests are reviewed thoroughly by our instructors and will be returned to you promptly.

*If you are viewing the course digitally, the scannable forms enclosed in the hard copy of AMA Self-Study titles are not available digitally. If you would like to take the course for credit, you will need to either purchase a hard copy of the course from www.amaselfstudy.org or you can purchase an online version of the course from www.flexstudy.com.

THE TEXT

The most important component of this course is the text, where the concepts and methods are presented. Reading each chapter twice will increase the likelihood of your understanding the text fully.

We recommend that you work on this course in a systematic way. Reading the text and working through the exercises at a regular and steady pace will help ensure that you get the most out of this course and retain what you have learned.

In your first reading, concentrate on getting an overview of the chapter content. Read the learning objectives at the beginning of the chapter first. They will act as guidelines to the major topics of the chapter and identify the skills you should master as you study the text. As you read the chapter, pay attention to the headings and subheadings. Find the general theme of each section and see how that theme relates to others. Don't let yourself get bogged down with details during the first reading; simply concentrate on understanding and remembering the major themes.

In your second reading, look for the details that underlie the themes. Read the entire chapter carefully and methodically, underlining key points, working out the details of examples, and making marginal notes as you go. Complete the activities.

ACTIVITIES

Interspersed with the text of each chapter you will find a series of activities. These can take a variety of forms, including essays, short-answer quizzes, or charts and questionnaires. Completing the activities will enable you to try out new ideas, practice and improve new skills, and test your understanding of the course content.

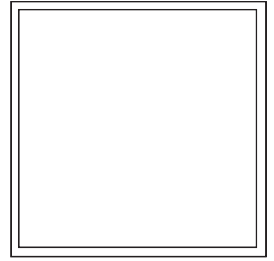
THE REVIEW QUESTIONS

After reading a chapter and before going on to the next chapter, work through the Review Questions. Answering the questions and comparing your answers to those given will help you to grasp the major ideas of that chapter. If you perform these self-check exercises consistently, you will develop a framework in which to place material presented in later chapters.

GRADING POLICY

The American Management Association will continue to grade examinations and tests for one year after the course's out-of-print date.

If you have questions regarding the tests, the grading, or the course itself, call Educational Services at 1-800-225-3215 or send an e-mail to ed_svc@amanet.org.



Pre-Test

Coaching for High Performance

Course Code 90052

INSTRUCTIONS: Record your answers on one of the scannable forms enclosed. Please follow the directions on the form carefully. Be sure to keep a copy of the completed answer form for your records. No photocopies will be graded. When completed, mail your answer form to:

**Educational Services
American Management Association
P.O. Box 133
Florida, NY 10921**

1. Coaching can be described as:
 - (a) an interactive process that helps another person learn, improve or learn.
 - (b) getting someone to listen and do what it appropriate.
 - (c) mentoring someone to take performance to the next level.
 - (d) teaching another person something they need to learn.
2. Coaching is more important than ever because:
 - (a) a customer retention strategy begins with coaching.
 - (b) coaches use strong communication skills to overcome resistance to change.
 - (c) coaching is a form of mentoring which is important to all employees in the workplace today.
 - (d) leading-edge organizations focus on coaching senior level employees.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
Call Educational Services at 1-800-225-3215, ext. 600,
or email at ed_svcs@amanet.org.

3. An attribute of an effective coach is:
 - (a) talking about his or her reservations about performing the coaching role.
 - (b) taking a results-oriented approach by tying coaching to goals for improvement or growth.
 - (c) getting involved in the coachee's personal life, as appropriate, to deal with special issues.
 - (d) waiting until the coachee asks for help before initiating coaching.
4. Coaches demonstrate respect for the coachee by:
 - (a) giving him/her their full attention during a coaching session.
 - (b) telling the coachee what he or she needs.
 - (c) talking until the coachee is ready to deal with barriers to success.
 - (d) watching how the coachee responds to peer pressure.
5. One of the roles of a coach is as:
 - (a) a systems thinker.
 - (b) task delegator.
 - (c) a performance maximizer.
 - (d) a performance contributor.
6. One of the things you can do to build rapport with coachees is to:
 - (a) talk with the coachee about why you are a good coach.
 - (b) create a safe environment and put the coachee at ease.
 - (c) look for ways to encourage the coachee to take risks.
 - (d) create an environment that meets your needs as a coach.
7. A pitfall you want to avoid as a coach is:
 - (a) coaching just for the sake of coaching.
 - (b) coaching those you do not want to retain.
 - (c) spending too much time coaching and too little time getting results.
 - (d) asking the coachee questions rather than giving the answer.
8. In a coaching situation, a coach that uses a Motivational Style will:
 - (a) talk about possibilities and use lots of encouragement.
 - (b) make the coachee feel comfortable.
 - (c) be very direct and straightforward.
 - (d) take a lot of time to probe coachee motivation.
9. Methodical coaches need to avoid the following during a coaching situation:
 - (a) focusing too much on feelings and emotions.
 - (b) taking too much time to get to key issues.
 - (c) focusing too much on details.
 - (d) focusing too much on the big picture.

10. When you communicate your expectations, one of the things you want to talk about is:
 - (a) your special qualifications as a leader.
 - (b) why you want this person to be part of your team.
 - (c) how long you expect the individual to take to learn the job.
 - (d) your expectations regarding communication.
11. When you assess a coachee, it is important to find out:
 - (a) how motivated a person is to do a good job.
 - (b) why the individual is highly motivated to do a good job.
 - (c) why skills keep increasing beyond expectations.
 - (d) which skills are important to master.
12. A common purpose of coaching is to:
 - (a) show the coachee you respect him/her.
 - (b) help the coachee develop talents.
 - (c) develop ways to manage burn out.
 - (d) help the coachee get over disappointment.
13. Openings for coaching present themselves during day-to-day work. You can seize an opportunity for coaching when:
 - (a) employees talk about prior coaching experiences.
 - (b) employees are not ready for promotion.
 - (c) employees demonstrate they are ready to take on new tasks.
 - (d) employees set goals with your assistance.
14. When you contract with a coachee, it is important to:
 - (a) develop a contract for at least one year
 - (b) think about whether a contract needs to be agreed to by the coachee.
 - (c) set up similar contracts for all those you are coaching.
 - (d) discuss how long coaching discussions will last.
15. One of the steps in the six step coaching process is:
 - (a) creating a coaching plan.
 - (b) looking for coaching opportunities.
 - (c) taking in data from others.
 - (d) providing your observations about performance.
16. Effective questions are relevant. This means these questions:
 - (a) tell you what you need to know.
 - (b) keep the coaching discussion on track.
 - (c) are open-ended.
 - (d) imply there is a right answer.

17. Coaches use probing questions to draw out the coachee when:
 - (a) the coaching plan is too complicated.
 - (b) the coach needs to encourage the individual.
 - (c) the coach wants the coachee to think more deeply.
 - (d) it is clear there is a need to brainstorm alternatives.
18. One part of a coaching action plan is:
 - (a) describing the coaching support you will provide.
 - (b) specifying the questions you will ask in subsequent discussions.
 - (c) describing what the coachee needs to do to play an active role.
 - (d) explaining how much energy the coachee has to expend to complete the plan.
19. One of the things you want to do to gather your thoughts before giving feedback is:
 - (a) think about how you want to interact with the coachee.
 - (b) decide if the feedback is important.
 - (c) gett in a mood to give feedback by doing self-reflection.
 - (d) make sure you can give the feedback in a private place.
20. One characteristic of effective feedback is that:
 - (a) it is highly personal.
 - (b) it pinpoints areas for growth.
 - (c) it is subjective.
 - (d) it is given over a three month period of time.
21. When giving just-in-time feedback, one of the things you want to talk about is:
 - (a) things to pay attention to.
 - (b) things to do later.
 - (c) things to do faster.
 - (d) things to do after the feedback is delivered.
22. One of the things you can do to build trust in difficult situations is to:
 - (a) give just-in-time coaching.
 - (b) tell the coachee what she/he needs to do better.
 - (c) keep your word to the coachee.
 - (d) talk about the next step.
23. One of the five most common workplace motivators is:
 - (a) growth.
 - (b) new responsibilities.
 - (c) high salaries.
 - (d) good managers.

-
24. One of the characteristics of Baby Boomer employees is:
- (a) they prefer command and control work environments.
 - (b) they pride themselves on their ability to survive.
 - (c) they want lots of coaching and feedback.
 - (d) they want to be valued for their technical savvy.
25. When you are coaching a team through failure, one of the steps is:
- (a) talking about continuous improvement.
 - (b) stepping back and identifying who contributed to the failure.
 - (c) helping the team see failure as an event and not personalize the failure.
 - (d) keeping the team working on the problem until they experience success.

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1

The Importance of Coaching



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Define coaching.
- Describe the key factors that make coaching a critical managerial tool in a competitive environment.
- Describe three attributes of an effective coach.
- Create a performance improvement plan to develop coaching skills.

My associate Jeff and I were training a group of newly promoted supervisors. Our topic was Effective Coaching and the discussion was lively. The group brainstormed a list of critical coaching skills and then, in pairs, each selected the three to five skills they believed most important. I circulated around the room and listened in on the conversations. I was struck by what two marketing supervisors were discussing and asked them to share their observations with the group. One of them began, “We talked about the fact that neither of us has had much coaching. So we’re glad that we’re learning how to coach. We would have benefited a lot from working with a good coach, and we want to make sure we do this for those we’re supervising.”

Several managers began to talk at once. An accounting supervisor captured much of what was being said. “Most of us can empathize with the fact that we’ve had little coaching. But the more I think about the ways in which it can make a difference, the clearer it is that coaching is vital.” I summarized the discussion by agreeing with the group—in today’s workplace, coaching is vital!

WHAT IS COACHING?

Let's begin by defining the word *coaching*. Read the following definitions and circle the one that best matches your description.

- Coaching is an interactive process that helps another person improve, learn something, or take performance to the next level.
- Coaching means working as a trusted counselor, guide, tutor or mentor.
- Coaching involves someone with more wisdom and experience sharing his/her knowledge and expertise.
- Coaching means an ability to diagnose an issue and propose a solution as well as to motivate others to achieve their best.
- Coaching is a form of feedback that helps another person realize what is not working and take steps to get on the right track.

Although each definition describes aspects of coaching, the first definition is the most accurate and comprehensive. Thus, coaching is *an interactive process that helps another person improve, learn something, or take performance to the next level*. Let's break down this definition. First, "coaching is an interactive process" means it is a dialogue of give and take between the coach and the coachee. Coaching is not a monologue and effective coaches listen as much as, sometimes more than, they talk. Second, coaching has multiple purposes. Sometimes the purpose is improvement, and the coach helps an individual overcome a problem. Sometimes coaching is about learning, and the coach enables the coachee to master a new skill, task, or behavior. Sometimes coaching is about growth, helping good performers maximize their potential. Coaching usually takes place in the context of a conversation—it is a conversation with a purpose. But coaching is also done when you invite an employee to sit in on a meeting to see how you handle it, or when you assign a special project that stretches an individual's skills.

Leaders who coach help their organizations do a better job achieving major business goals. A manager of a large retail store put it this way, "Coaching is the way you get the most out of employees. I owe it to the organization to maximize results. Coaching develops the next generation of leaders, retains top talent, and taps into the vast resources of human potential. When managers coach they release aspirations, build capabilities, and generate a strong sense of personal satisfaction. Coaching unlocks latent potential and reinforces strong skills where they already exist."

WHY COACHING IS MORE IMPORTANT THAN EVER

Organizations that do not perform at their peak find that over the long term, they are *unable* to compete. In fact, over the past several years it has become increasingly important for leaders to help organizations meet these challenges.

- Keeping customers happy
- Delivering high quality products and services
- Managing continuous change
- Retaining top talent
- Working in collaborative networked organizations
- Building personal capability to match performance demands
- Empowering breakthrough results
- Reinforcing business practices

Creating a coaching culture is essential to helping business meet these challenges successfully. Let's examine the role coaching plays in enabling organizational peak performance.

Keeping Customers Happy

In today's vigorously competitive market, businesses must develop relationships that retain the loyalty of existing customers and enable new customer markets to be served effectively. Keeping customers loyal and happy requires finding out what it takes to make your product or service stand out. Good coaches play a variety of roles in ensuring customer retention and growth. At one major insurance company, for example, customer retention depends on the quality and speed of service. Customers expect to deal with knowledgeable people who can make decisions on the spot. A reengineering team was formed to find several ways to improve the quality and speed of service delivery. Angie, the team leader told me, "Like all teams, they had to make an immediate decision about how to gather customer feedback. Our team chose to use the focus group approach, that is, meeting with small groups of customers face-to-face. My coaching really began here as we started to gather the data. Some of the feedback was hard to hear and discouraged us. I felt it was important to use lots of encouragement and remind the team we had an opportunity to turn things around. All the coaching paid off and we achieved some amazing results. We simplified the customer billing process and accelerated claims processing by 30 percent. Teams are a great way to solve business problems but the team leader must be a good coach."

Producing High Quality Products and Services

Leading organizations know how to deliver customized, high-quality products and services at competitive costs. Coaching keeps employees focused on quality excellence; it enables them to work in ways that are more productive, efficient, and effective. Good coaches make the link between individual quality and the organization's ability to produce quality products or services. They use coaching discussions to explain that sustainable market share comes primarily through leadership in the customers' perception of product or service quality.

One organization implemented a process called Faster Market Intelligence, which was designed to infuse competitor information into the company as quickly as possible. Several divisions put this process into place.

A business development manager described the importance of coaching, “Faster Market Intelligence was a real step forward but it is complex. I didn’t realize how much learning was required just to get it up and running. I found myself doing a lot of coaching every day and it paid off. Not only me—two of my senior specialists that were experts in FMI played a major coaching role. I doubt if we could have gotten FMI in place, to say nothing of getting its benefits, without excellent coaching support.”

Managing Continuous Change

“I think what’s key from a human resources standpoint is the ability to coach managers who need to help others deal with the pressure of change. The ability to deal with the changes we face today—change demanded by customers, government, and competitive forces—is a dilemma for managers at all levels. But often, the pressure of change seems more intense for employees. Coaching plays a vital role in equipping individuals to adapt, to learn quickly, and to master behaviors required to deal with continuous change.” This was Kristen’s observation about how coaching helped her organization manage change. What else do coaches do to help others deal with the pressure of change?

Coaches use their communication skills to overcome resistance to change. They listen deeply and uncover the reasons for resistance. Sometimes it’s fear, sometimes it’s anger, sometimes it’s disappointment. Once coaches understand the reasons for resistance, they can build the coachees’ confidence in their ability to meet the demands of change.

One nurse administrator at a large hospital told me, “Today, change is happening so fast it’s hard to keep up. At this hospital, we have seen an incredible amount of change. Last year we built a new facility and that stretched all of us. I invested a lot of time coaching my nursing team. I was amazed how much time I spent listening to their concerns and then finding ways, together, to meet new expectations.”

Retaining Top Talent

Employee retention refers to an organization’s ability to retain its most talented employees. This has become a critical issue. Why? Workforce demographics indicate some startling statistics that confront every employer:

- Each month more than 13 percent of workers in the United States quit their jobs.
- Fifty-five percent of U.S. employees often think of quitting or plan to quit within a given year.
- The average time to fill jobs has increased from 41 days to 51 days.
- More than half of all U.S. employers report that turnover continues to rise each year.

Leading edge companies—those that are doing a good job minimizing turnover and maximizing retention of key employees—use coaching to ensure employees experience a greater sense of satisfaction and fulfillment.

Coaching fosters a sense of bonding with an organization and, importantly, provides a forum for resolving issues that might otherwise cause employees to leave. Remember that the new generations in the workforce, Gen X and Gen Y, want a strong coaching relationship with their managers. In fact, one of the reasons they choose to stay with an organization is because they feel a partnership with their boss. Coaching creates this bond.

Working in Collaborative Networked Organizations

“It is always a challenge getting everybody on the same page on cross-functional projects. My hope is that we can stop reinventing the wheel. We’ve got to demonstrate that we can really help our clients get their products to the marketplace fast; I’ve got to have the cooperation of my counterparts around the world.”

The demands of leading projects like these are becoming more commonplace. Most of the organizations I work with engage in large, cross-functional projects, many of which span the globe. You may wonder, “What can coaching do to face challenges like these?” First, coaches clarify the importance of networking effectively with all stakeholders. As one coach said, “I make sure project leaders know that as soon as issues arise, they must get in there and resolve them quickly. Project leaders often underestimate the value of frequent communication on large, cross-functional projects. I share my experiences with them to illustrate that the only way to keep people engaged, motivated, and committed is through good communication.”

Second, large collaborative projects require sharp skills. Jack, coaching a major inter-organizational systems integration project said, “Large, inter-organizational projects require superior project management skills. Frankly, no matter how good you are at leading projects, working on big, global projects are a whole new ballgame. I coach project leaders on what it means to take their skills to the next level. For example, it is critical that the team carefully track progress and keep on top of everything that is happening in every part of the organization involved in the project.”

Building Personal Capability to Match Performance Demands

The need for increased competitiveness impacts everyone in the organization. As demands for higher performance continue to rise, the gap between performance expectations and personal capabilities widens. Take a minute and think about how your work has changed over the past 12 to 18 months:

- What new skills have you had to master?
- What new responsibilities have been added to your job?
- What challenges are you facing that require you to develop new ways of doing things?

It takes coaching to fill these performance gaps. Coaches explain not only what new skills are required but also why they are important. They

encourage coachees to stretch beyond perceived personal limits and provide the guidance and feedback indispensable for skill mastery.

I asked one coach, a manager in a small parts manufacturing company, what he did to help build personal capabilities. He shared his ideas with me. “I do a couple of things. In our business new technology is available all the time. Before you know it, you’re out-of-date. I use coaching discussions to understand what type of training people need to master new technologies. I also talk about what our competitors are doing and discuss best practices. This is especially important for my first-level supervisors. Sometimes there is a tendency to get complacent. Talking about best practices highlights areas where we need to build stronger capabilities for competitiveness.”

Reinforcing Business Practices

Organizations today, in light of Sarbanes-Oxley, must exercise a heightened degree of oversight in the area of ethical compliance. In fact, most of the companies I work with have put programs in place to reinforce their commitment to business ethics. A first-level manager in an investment firm said, “We used to take it for granted that talking about our business practices during new employee orientation was enough. Not any more. I coach my investment specialists in ethics on a routine basis.”

When you think about it, reinforcing business practices is an important coaching role. Nothing is more essential than making sure coachees understand what is expected in terms of conducting business in ways that are ethical and in keeping with your organization’s practices. Ethical issues range from hiring fairly to dealing with political pressure, questionable accounting practices, conflicting policies, and others.

Employees sometimes wonder whether the ethics code is just words. With constant attention to ethical decision making, companies avoid legal crises and other problems. As a coach you make knowledgeable suggestions about how to handle ethical dilemmas and reinforce the need for compliance. Coaching makes it easy for employees to overcome their reluctance to talk about troubling workplace issues. As one coach shared with me, “Advice from someone who has been there is vital. There is increasing scrutiny from everyone about how we do business. Also, you have to face the risk of personal liability. That’s a lot of pressure. Some aspects of compliance are clear—others are less so. I get coaching from my boss when I sense a gray area. Her insights and advice are invaluable.”

Empowering Breakthrough Results

Most organizations have lived through various rounds of cost cutting, reengineering, and similar measures designed to survive, trim expenses, and improve processes. What has become clear is that the leadership skills required for these organizational improvements are very different from leading for breakthroughs. *Breakthroughs* mean achieving heights the organization has never reached—in products or services offered in the marketplace. It means engaging the hearts, minds, and talents of everyone to create innovative customer solutions.

Effective coaches encourage new approaches and challenge old assumptions, as well as facilitate creative thinking. As head of a major Boston distribution center said, “In coaching conversations, both one-on-one and with teams, I help people understand that they can accomplish things they think are impossible. There’s an assumption that “special people” with “unique talents” achieve breakthroughs. But in reality, most of the important innovations we’ve seen over the last several years were done by people who had a vision of what’s possible and made it happen. Invariably, you find out that the person or team responsible for the breakthrough was the recipient of strong coaching.”

Certainly organizations seeking to create a powerful future understand that wherever high performance is required, coaching is essential. Take a moment and think about how coaching has personally benefited you.

Exercise 1–1: Your Best Coach

Instructions: Your best coach may be someone in your business or personal life. It may be someone you encountered while in school, in sports, or some other activity. Answer the following questions and describe how this person’s coaching benefited you.

1. Who was this coach? What role did this person play in your life?

2. What did this person enable you to do that you could have not done without his or her coaching?

3. What did this person say or do to coach you? Think about what he or she said, or the behaviors he or she exhibited that made the person a good coach.

Exercise 1–1 highlights how much value a good coach provides. Now let’s take it a step further and describe the attributes of a good coach.

ATTRIBUTES OF A GOOD COACH

Cell Corp. was facing a competitive crisis. The entrance of new competitors into the communications market threatened the organization's status as one of the top two or three companies in its industry. Many of the new entrants were small, agile companies that offered technologies Cell Corp. did not have. As customers' demand for voice, high-speed data, and video communications increased, Cell Corp. found itself losing business.

Jerry's team has been assigned responsibility for creating a high-speed dial-up technology. Customers were clamoring for this service; increasingly they heard competitors were able to provide faster Internet access that was more reliable and cost effective.

Jerry admitted, "I only thought about coaching when we had to get through a crisis—a major systems problem—that sort of thing. But the need to create this new technology is placing incredible demands on everyone. I've got to do a much better job coaching if we're going to meet this challenge. We've got to be focused, creative, and really pull together as a team. My project leaders will need lots of encouragement and help solving problems as they arise. I talked with a friend of mine who is a great coach. I asked him, "Tell me what a good coach does—I need to become one! Are there certain things great coaches do?" Jerry's question is a good one: What do good coaches do?

The Coaching Attributes Assessment describes six critical skills good coaches exhibit. Take the assessment to gain insight into which behaviors you already practice and where you need to develop stronger skills

Exercise 1–2: Coaching Attributes Assessment

Instructions: The assessment is designed to help you understand more about the attributes of an effective coach and gain insights into which behaviors you now practice and where you need to develop stronger skills.

For each statement, decide on a rating and record it in the blank to the left of the statement.

When you have responded to all the statements, turn to the score sheet, transfer your ratings, and calculate your total score. Next, read the interpretation; it will provide insight into your effectiveness as a coach.

Finally, you will have an opportunity to create an action plan that identifies specific attributes you want to strengthen. If you have an opportunity, ask one or two people who work for you to take the assessment. Gaining their perspective will provide a more objective appraisal of your skills as a coach.

To what extent do you typically exhibit the following attitudes? You:

	Almost Always	Very Frequently	Frequently	Occasionally	Almost Never
1. Understand what the coachee needs.	1	2	3	4	5
2. Take a goal-focused approach.	1	2	3	4	5
3. Help the coachee see mistakes as opportunities to learn to do things better.	1	2	3	4	5
4. Encourage the coachee to do his or her best.	1	2	3	4	5
5. Are willing to teach coachee something new.	1	2	3	4	5
6. Avoid distractions when coaching others.	1	2	3	4	5
7. Take the time to understand coachee's important concerns.	1	2	3	4	5
8. Help set goals for improvement.	1	2	3	4	5
9. Ask a coachee, "What do you think you need to do differently?" or similar questions.	1	2	3	4	5
10. Openly express a desire to see the coachee succeed.	1	2	3	4	5
11. Provide specific ideas or suggestions during a coaching session.	1	2	3	4	5
12. Listen to what the coachee needs from you at the moment.	1	2	3	4	5
13. Make sure you listen to the coachee's issues and concerns.	1	2	3	4	5
14. Work with the coachee to create a clear plan for achieving coaching goals.	1	2	3	4	5
15. Talk through how to overcome blind spots or obstacles.	1	2	3	4	5
16. Encourage the coachee to stretch his or her skills.	1	2	3	4	5
17. Share your experience with the coachee.	1	2	3	4	5
18. Maintain coachee's confidentiality.	1	2	3	4	5
19. Help the coachee assess strengths and weaknesses.	1	2	3	4	5
20. Carefully consider what you want to accomplish in a coaching session.	1	2	3	4	5
21. Help the coachee think through difficult issues.	1	2	3	4	5
22. Tell the coachee you believe he/she can take performance to the next level.	1	2	3	4	5
23. Carefully decide what suggestions to make during the coaching session.	1	2	3	4	5

24. Value coachees' ability to solve their own problems.	1	2	3	4	5
25. Explain your rationale when advising the coachee what he/she should do to solve a problem.	1	2	3	4	5
26. Show coachees how their performance impacts the entire work unit, even to the bottom line.	1	2	3	4	5
27. Listen to the coachee in order to identify good ideas.	1	2	3	4	5
28. Let the coachee know you have confidence in what he/she can do.	1	2	3	4	5
29. Advise the coachee how to overcome performance blocks.	1	2	3	4	5
30. Devote the time needed to coaching.	1	2	3	4	5
31. Talk with coachees about lessons learned to provide insight about what to do in the future.	1	2	3	4	5
32. Discuss long-term professional goals.	1	2	3	4	5
33. Give coachees lots of time to express their views when discussing performance improvement.	1	2	3	4	5
34. Make sure coachees know how you will support them.	1	2	3	4	5
35. Wait to give advice until the coachee is open to hearing what you have to say.	1	2	3	4	5
36. Respect who the coachee is as a person.	1	2	3	4	5

Coaching Attributes Assessment — Score Sheet

Discerns Needs	Demonstrates Results	Works as a Thinking Partner
	Orientation	
1 ____	2 ____	3 ____
7 ____	8 ____	9 ____
13 ____	14 ____	15 ____
19 ____	20 ____	21 ____
25 ____	26 ____	27 ____
31 ____	32 ____	33 ____
Total ____	Total ____	Total ____
Ave. ____	Ave. ____	Ave. ____

Encourages the Coachee	Provides Advice	Demonstrates Respect
4 ____	5 ____	6 ____
10 ____	11 ____	12 ____
16 ____	17 ____	18 ____
22 ____	23 ____	24 ____
28 ____	29 ____	30 ____
34 ____	35 ____	36 ____
Total ____	Total ____	Total ____
Ave. ____	Ave. ____	Ave. ____

TOTAL SCORE:

Coaching Attributes Assessment

The assessment you just completed was based on the following attributes of an effective coach:

Discerns Needs. Effective coaches discern what a coachee needs by:

- Seeking to understand what the coachee needs to do to turn performance around
- Uncovering what the coachee needs to do to move to the next level of performance
- Identifying the coachee's strengths and weaknesses
- Identifying gaps between actual performance and desired performance

Demonstrates a Results Orientation. Effective coaches demonstrate a results orientation by:

- Encouraging the coachee to see new possibilities
- Helping the coachee set goals for improvement or growth
- Creating and executing a coaching plan
- Showing the coachee how his or her performance impacts the entire team

Works as a Thinking Partner. Effective coaches act as a thinking partner by:

- Listening deeply and with empathy
- Helping coachees think through issues and identify what they need to do
- Drawing out ideas and knowledge
- Asking questions and reframing issues when the coachee has made incorrect assumptions

Encourages New Behaviors. Effective coaches encourage new behaviors by:

- Encouraging coachees to change
- Talking about how to close performance gaps
- Brainstorming ways to overcome performance obstacles
- Encouraging coachees to stretch their skills

Provides Advice. Effective coaches provide advice by:

- Advising coachees what to do in a way that is candid and caring
- Being sensitive to timing and providing advice when coachees are open to hearing it
- Listening carefully to the coachee before giving advice
- Being willing to teach the coachee something new

Demonstrates Respect. Effective coaches demonstrate respect by:

- Devoting full attention to the coachee during coaching discussions
- Listening carefully to what the coachee needs
- Maintaining confidentiality
- Seeking and valuing the coachee's input

Coaching Attributes Assessment

- 180–144: Your scores indicate strong coaching attributes. You demonstrate skills in discerning the needs of a coachee, maintaining a results orientation, and showing a willingness to act as a thinking partner. You also encourage new behaviors and, as needed, are willing to provide advice. Finally, you work with the coachee to stretch skills, you express confidence in the coachee, and you demonstrate respect for the coachee as an individual.
- 143–115: Your scores indicate you have good coaching skills. Review your assessment and note any patterns with respect to the questions where you scored 3 or less.
- 114–92: Your score indicates a need to improve your coaching approach. There are several areas in which you need to focus for development. Think about the aspects of coaching that you find most difficult to deal with. This will give you insight into which areas to focus on.
- Below 92: Your approach to coaching needs considerable improvement. It is likely that you find coaching difficult, or perhaps you have not had much experience coaching. Your scores indicate an opportunity to improve in all the coaching attributes. Select one or two areas that are most important and build your performance improvement plan around them.

Good coaches do a lot of things well. But a few particular attributes or characteristics distinguish the best coaches. We will look at each in greater detail.

- They discern what the coachee needs.
- They demonstrate a results orientation.
- They work as a thinking partner.
- They encourage the coachee.
- They provide sound advice.
- They demonstrate respect for the coachee.
- They possess the desire and willingness to be a coach.

Discern What the Coachee Needs

This is one of the first things coaches do when beginning a coaching relationship. Think about Jerry and his team. The team needs to do several things to develop the high-speed technology. Where does it start?

Jerry's boss described this attribute as follows. "Jerry's team is a good one. Getting this high-speed technology operational is a real test; they can do it but Jerry's got to coach them through it. But he must be strategic about where to focus his coaching efforts. Building their core strengths and helping them overcome weaknesses that will inhibit their ability to design this technology are his first priority."

Coaches like Jerry use several questions to assess what coachees need, for example:

- What new capabilities does the team need to develop?
- What can block our ability to develop this technology?
- Is there training we need?

By discerning needs, the coach makes a factual analysis, assesses strengths and weaknesses, identifies performance gaps, and guides people to close these gaps.

Demonstrate a Results Orientation

Good coaches tie their coaching conversations to goals for improvement, learning, or growth. They also make sure there is a plan in place that supports these goals. Jerry's friend gave him another insight into the importance of a goal-focused approach. He explained, "As you coach the team, make sure you explain to each person how his or her performance impacts the entire team. Results are about more than what each person does individually; people need to understand there is a cumulative effect on the bottom line. A good coach paints this picture—it makes each person's work more meaningful and motivates people to pursue goals."

I have experienced another aspect of results orientation first hand. Whenever employees left a coaching discussion muttering, "Why does she want me to do that?" I knew I had not done a thorough coaching job. I made it a point to follow up and explain *why* the goals we set are important, or why I stressed certain behaviors. A results orientation includes explaining your coaching rationale that puts your conversations into the broader context.

Work as a Thinking Partner

Good coaches listen as much as they talk. By listening deeply and with empathy, coaches help coachees think through issues and identify what they need to do.

Jerry found himself playing the role of a thinking partner several times during the project. His team worked aggressively to develop the high-speed Internet capability. Once a week, they met and discussed the status of the

project. Three months into the project, a special meeting was called to resolve problems with project priorities.

Jerry said, “I realized the priority issue provided several teachable moments. I had to ask myself, ‘Do I just tell the team what to do or do I help them think through the alternatives and make a sound decision?’ He decided to play the role of a thinking partner and help the group sort out conflicting priorities. Jerry listened to the discussion and then asked a few questions. “If we change our priorities, how will this impact the deliverables we have committed to in the project plan? How will this change affect other teams that are depending on our output? The subsequent discussion was very fruitful; Jerry watched the team wrestle with the implications of changing priorities. Like all good thinking partners, Jerry facilitated the team’s ability to solve the priority problem. His team made a well thought-out decision and kept the priorities unchanged.

Encourage the Coachee

Over the years I have asked various groups, “What do coaches do that encourage you and how do they communicate a positive approach to coaching?” Here are some of the most common responses. “My coach encourages me by . . .

- Caring about me and how I am doing.
- Making me feel confident.
- Wanting me to be successful.
- Reassuring me that I can do it.
- Not letting me give up.

The ability to encourage coachees is sometimes an undervalued attribute. Skilled coaches encourage coachees when they are discouraged, fearful, or feel inadequate to the task. Encouragement is also important when a coachee comes face to face with his/her limitations. Alexis, a software engineer, described her experience as follows. “I loved the opportunity to work on new products at DISC.COM. But if you’ve ever done it, you know it can be frustrating. Deadlines come around sooner than you think, conflicts emerge on the team, and customers change specs a million times. My project leader was an incredible coach. She would listen to me when I was at some real low points and coach me through them; she wouldn’t let me give up! I can still hear her telling me, ‘You can do this, Alexis. I have confidence that you’ll be able to work through the obstacles that are part of any new product development process.’ Then, she would remind me of all the things I had accomplished so far. By the time we finished talking, I felt ready to try again.”

Other things coaches do to encourage coachees include:

- Acknowledging transferable skills with enthusiasm
- Giving examples of what a good job would look like
- Providing concrete examples of how others have mastered new behaviors
- Giving praise when progress is made
- Helping the individual analyze successes and failures

Provide Sound Advice

As a coach, you can choose to be more or less directive. When you use the skill of providing advice, you are choosing to give the coachee specific direction. What types of situations call for giving advice? Look at the following list:

- The coachee needs specific guidance about how to overcome a problem
- You have knowledge that the coachee needs
- The coachee comes to you for an opinion about what to do
- There are blind spots that the coachee cannot see

Good coaches don't just launch into giving advice. Instead, they do three things to maximize the opportunity for learning and growth:

1. They make sure coachees understand the issue and where they need guidance, input, or suggestions.
2. They ask coachees what they have done to date. Once you understand what they have tried, you are in a better position to provide well-targeted advice.
3. They check with the coachees to make sure they know how to act on the advice.

A bank manager talked about how he offers advice to a coachee, "I believe it is important to offer advice in a way that is both candid and caring. There will be times when you need to initiate the advice giving; it is important to be sensitive to timing and provide advice when the coachee is open to hearing it. I learned this the hard way. I used to give lots of advice whenever I thought an employee needed it. But coaches need to demonstrate an understanding of the coachees' openness to listening, especially when the advice is difficult to hear."

Demonstrate Respect for the Coachee

Good coaches are respectful. You show respect when you avoid making assumptions, and listen carefully to what the coachee needs from you. Here is how Rebecca described her coach. "Andrea is an expert in sports medicine and she has been coaching me for six months. I just got my bachelor's degree and I really am a beginner in this field. Andrea treats me like a peer; she listens to my questions and shares her expertise in a way that is never condescending. What I notice is that she does not push her ideas on me but respects my ideas and encourages me to try new things."

Coaches also demonstrate respect by giving coachees their full attention during a coaching session. My friend Chris describes the importance of this. "Have you ever talked with someone who was constantly checking his watch, answering the phone, and otherwise communicating that you're interrupting his day? My boss was well intentioned but coaching discussions always went this way."

In addition, respectful coaches never divulge a confidence and honor the coachee's desire to keep certain information confidential. Sometimes an individual shares things with a coach that are highly personal. It is important to treat this information with care and respect the coachee's need to keep it private.

There is one other way coaches demonstrate respect—they respect the coachee as an individual. For example, they acknowledge the coachee's stress level, and don't coach when emotions are high. They also learn which coaching techniques are most appreciated by a coachee. For example, some tend to resent too much advice, whereas others value it highly.

Desire and Willingness to be a Coach

Think about all the benefits we've discussed—the ways others benefit from your coaching. Your coaching sparks insights that lead to learning, growth, and success. The desire to coach begins with seeing yourself as someone who wants to have an impact on others. Nothing is more important than a desire to be a coach. In fact, without that desire, all the other attributes aren't of much use. Remember that the most important coaching asset is a desire to coach people and make a difference in their lives.

A lead technician for an environmental services firm observed, "If you have the desire to coach, it can make up for your lack of experience and even, to some extent, your lack of skill. I have found that skills come with practice, and of course you get experience by coaching. But it all starts with desire. Without that, all the techniques and tools won't help you."

Exercise 1–3: Your Performance Improvement Plan

Instructions: The Coaching Attributes Assessment (Exercise 1–2) revealed what you consider your strengths and growth areas as a coach. In this exercise, identify the skill areas you want to focus on over the next six to nine months.

Step One: Write a statement that describes the things you and your team need to accomplish over the next six to nine months. Consider the business challenges that are most important.

Step Two: Identify two to three things the team needs to do to meet this challenge.

Step Three: List one to two coaching attributes you want to improve. These should be attributes that will help key individuals or the group meet the challenges identified in Step Two.

GETTING READY TO COACH

Let's end this chapter by examining some practical ways you can get ready to coach. You want to begin the journey of becoming a masterful coach and develop new skills that enable you to achieve this goal. Sometimes the issue is one of confidence. I have talked with people who want to be masterful coaches but question their skills, style, technique, etc. But in many instances people have more coaching assets than they give themselves credit for.

You have already examined the attributes of an effective coach. Now look at the following checklist. This is a list of personal traits that illustrate how qualified you are to begin your coaching role. You will gain confidence as you answer the questions and become aware of all you have to offer as a coach.

Exercise 1–4: What You Have to Offer

Instructions: Check the statements that best describe you.

- ☐ I have a desire to be a good coach.
- ☐ I have knowledge that I can share with others.
- ☐ I have had success teaching others.
- ☐ I have an ability to help others achieve results.
- ☐ I have been able to help others think through a problem.
- ☐ I am a good listener.
- ☐ I have the ability to give others good advice.
- ☐ I can encourage others to do their best.
- ☐ I like to see others succeed.
- ☐ I can help others see the big picture and see an issue from different perspectives.

How many statements did you check? If you checked at least half of these items, you already possess several assets that are important for masterful coaches. Congratulations—you are on your way!



Coaching is an interactive process that helps another person improve, learn something, or take performance to the next level.

Creating a culture of coaching is essential to helping businesses meet challenges related to keeping customers happy, producing high quality products and services, and managing continuous change. Coaching also helps organizations retain top talent, work in collaborative ways in a networked environment, build personal capabilities to match performance needs, empower breakthrough results, and reinforce business practices.

Good coaches exhibit several attributes. These include discerning what the coachee needs, demonstrating a results orientation, working as a thinking partner, encouraging new behavior, providing sound advice, demonstrating respect for the coachee, and possessing the desire and willingness to be a coach.

A three-part performance improvement plan is the first step in developing coaching skills. Step One is to write a statement describing the goals you and your team need to accomplish in the next upcoming six to nine months and the business challenges they represent. Step Two is to identify two to three things the team needs to do to meet these goals. Step Three is to choose one or two coaching attributes that you feel need improvement from those identified in the Coaching Attributes Assessment. Link these attributes to areas that will help key individuals or the group as a whole meet the challenges identified in Step Two.



Review Questions

INSTRUCTIONS: Here is the first set of review questions in this course. Answering the questions following each chapter gives you a chance to check your comprehension of the concepts as they are presented and reinforces your understanding of them.

As you can see below, the answer to each numbered question is printed to the side of the question. Before beginning, you should conceal the answers in some way, either by folding the page vertically or by placing a sheet of paper over the answers. Then read and answer each question. Compare your answers with those given. For any questions you answer incorrectly, make an effort to understand why the answer given is the correct one. You may find it helpful to turn back to the appropriate section of the chapter and review the material of which you were unsure. At any rate, be sure you understand all the review questions before going on to the next chapter.

1. Coaching has multiple purposes, including: 1. (a)
 - (a) helping someone learn.
 - (b) taking over a project.
 - (c) handling a problem.
 - (d) seeking more resources.

2. When coaches provide advice, it is important that they: 2. (c)
 - (a) give praise when progress is made.
 - (b) help the coachee analyze success and failure.
 - (c) make sure they understand what the coachee has tried thus far.
 - (d) avoid hurting the relationship by being too directive.

3. Leading organizations use coaching to ensure that customized, high-quality products and services are offered at competitive costs. Coaches help businesses do this by keeping employees: 3. (a)
 - (a) focused on quality excellence.
 - (b) aware of reengineering opportunities.
 - (c) in touch with competitors.
 - (d) aware of product strengths.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
Call Educational Services at 1-800-225-3215, ext. 600,
or email at ed_svcs@amanet.org.

4. Good coaches begin a coaching relationship by discerning what the coachee needs. They achieve this by: 4. (b)
- (a) empowering the coachee to take charge of the relationship.
 - (b) using questions to assess coachee strengths and weaknesses.
 - (c) telling the coachee how to address in performance gaps.
 - (d) looking for ways to encourage the coachee to do better.
5. The first step in a performance improvement plan to develop coaching skills is to: 5. (d)
- (a) choose a coaching partner.
 - (b) identify difficult employees.
 - (c) develop a demographic profile of your organization's workforce.
 - (d) describe your goals and the business challenges they represent.

2

Getting in Shape to Coach



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Describe your coaching mission.
- Execute the four primary roles of a coach.
- Implement three techniques for building rapport with coachees.
- Select the coaching relationships in which you want to invest the most time.
- Utilize your coaching style for maximum effectiveness.

Have you ever participated in a sport or played an instrument? Perhaps you exercise as part of your daily routine or act in a local theater group? If you do any of these things, you know the importance of preparation—whether you are getting ready to play a set of tennis, perform in an ensemble, run a mile, or act in a play. It is the same with coaching—you need to do certain things to get ready. Achieving extraordinary results begins with you, making sure you have set the stage for successful coaching. This is what allows you to bring out the best in the individuals you're coaching.

How do you get in shape to coach? Specifically, you need to:

- Clarify your coaching mission
- Understand your coaching role
- Build strong rapport with coachees
- Invest in coaching relationships
- Understand your coaching style and approach

Let's look at each of these steps, beginning with the importance of establishing your coaching mission.

CLARIFY YOUR COACHING MISSION

Your organization has a clear mission. Why is this important? A mission clarifies purpose, identifies what is to be achieved, and states how an organization provides value for its key stakeholders.

Think about yourself as a coach. How would you define your mission? Every great coach, whether in sports, music, or business, has a mission. These coaches develop their mission by reflecting on their goals as a leader, understanding why coaching is important, and knowing what they want to accomplish through their coaching. Clarifying your mission gives you greater confidence and a clear focus; it describes how you want to empower others through your coaching.

Let's look at a real life example. I was working with a group of managers who were responsible for coaching newly promoted first-level supervisors. We talked a lot about various coaching skills and then introduced the topic of the coaching mission. As an example, I shared my experience managing a group of human resource specialists. These individuals had strong academic credentials but very little work experience. I knew I would need to do a lot of coaching. I asked myself, "What do I want to accomplish as a result of coaching this team?" I decided that my mission was to use coaching to create a strong team that demonstrated superior communication and interpersonal skills and dealt with employees in a timely, respectful, and professional manner. That gave direction to my coaching efforts. So I had lots of conversations about how to set priorities based on the principles of excellent workplace communication, the importance of treating employees as internal customers, and similar concepts. I said to the class, "It took time, but the desired skills started to emerge. The reputation of the department became firmly established. Employee feedback told us we were doing a good job." In this example, the mission of the department became my coaching mission. At other times, your mission might be very specific. For example, another human resource manager I knew focused on streamlining HR processes for greater efficiency and productivity. Her coaching centered on this mission for several years.

Exercise 2-1: Your Coaching Mission

Instructions: Answer the following questions. They will help you create your coaching mission.

1. What do you want to accomplish?

2. What are your strengths as a coach?

3. What do you have to offer that is unique?

4. What do you know that others need to know?

5. What type of coaching would be helpful to you, that is, how can your coach help you build your coaching skills?

You should now have an understanding of your coaching mission. Let's move on and talk about the four major roles coaches perform. Keep in mind that the purpose for a particular coaching session may vary. But the four overarching roles are essential responsibilities that are part of every coach's job description.

UNDERSTAND YOUR COACHING ROLE

A lot of research has been done on the role of coaches in organizations today. Four key roles emerge in most of these studies. Remember that the clearer you are about your role, the better you will be able to coach effectively. The four roles are:

1. Coaching to develop other leaders
2. Coaching to maximize performance
3. Coaching for learning
4. Coaching for change

Let's discuss the four roles. As we describe each one, think about those that you need to perform.

Coaching to Develop Other Leaders

So often business leaders tell me there is a need to develop a larger population of leaders in their organizations. Many organizations are finding that internal development, especially coaching, is the best way to build a cadre of future leaders. A few years ago I worked with a large energy organization. It had invested considerable money in external training programs. The corporate training manager told me, “These efforts worked well but didn’t really yield the results we hoped. Our goal was to develop a strong group of first-level leaders and team leaders. When we looked at our succession planning, it was scary. There were so few people who were ready to move into key slots over the next two to four years. We realized coaching was the answer. We taught coaching principles to managers at all levels and gave them tools for becoming strong coaches. It’s paying off. Coaching people for high performance leadership every day is vital to developing future leaders.”

Coaching to Maximize Performance

Coaching came of age in organizations in the 1960s, but was used as an emergency measure when employees were in trouble. But over time, we began to study the nature of extraordinary success. Top achievers profiled in magazines, best-selling biographies, etc. were asked, “What’s the major contributor to your success?” In virtually every case, individuals credited a strong coach. Over the years the value of coaching continues to be reaffirmed as the best way to maximize the performance of others. Not everyone has the potential to rise to the top of his or her profession. But everyone does have talents, skills, and expertise that can be maximized through coaching. Marc, a GE manager for service and maintenance, was challenged to improve x-ray tubes his unit manufactured to meet the competition’s product. Jack Welch, GE’s CEO, skipped two levels of management to coach Marc. Marc talked about Welch’s coaching as the most powerful learning experience of his life and the major factor that enabled him to lead his team to extraordinary results. That’s how leaders use coaching to maximize performance.

Coaching for Learning

My best coach helped me become a better thinker. I described him as a “thinking partner.” Coaches help people learn by the questions they ask, the alternatives they pose, and the way they guide the coachee’s thinking. When people asked me about my coach and why he was so important to me, I said, “He helped me learn things I might have eventually learned on my own. But he helped me learn them more quickly, and used collaborative inquiry not only to help me solve problems, but also to examine the way I was thinking! I remember being up against a problem I couldn’t seem to solve. Talking with my coach I discovered that the way I was approaching the situation was actually preventing me from solving the problem.” This is the power of a coach that helps others learn.

One of my peers described the value of his coach and her role in his learning as follows, “I could always count on my coach to help me make the

best decision. I am very intuitive and don't like to think too much about the facts of a situation. My coach never said that I needed to be more analytical, but she shared her experiences in a way that I learned the value of doing my homework." Situations come and go but learning stays with us forever. Insights, breakthroughs, and innovations all come about by working with a coach who facilitates learning.

Coaching for Change

The nature of change has many forms. Sometimes change is highly personal, related to a significant shift in circumstances in our day-to-day lives. Other times, change is initiated by the organization, or in some other way imposed upon us. Sometimes we are the change agent and face the challenge of enlisting the support of others. Change may be small scale, affecting individuals or pieces of the organization, or it may be large scale, affecting the organization in its entirety. This is why coaching for change at the individual, team, and organizational level is vital. Chai, a team leader in an architectural firm said, "Coaching for change is every leader's job today. We used to do a lot of big projects, especially for hospitals and medical centers. That was our niche. But this market is competitive and more and more, customers wanted us to team with others, especially when it came to interior design. I have to coach my team about how to work inter-organizationally. So many of our projects require bringing together people who are used to being competitors, to produce a collective work product. The only way to do this is through coaching designed to build the team's collaborative skills." At its essence, coaching for change means managing the change dynamics, including helping people let go of the past and moving toward a powerful new future.

Exercise 2–2: Your Coaching Role

Instructions: Answer the following questions. They are designed to help you reflect on the four coaching roles just described.

1. On a scale of 1 to 5, to what extent do you use coaching to:
 - a. Develop other leaders _____
 - b. Maximize performance _____
 - c. Facilitate learning _____
 - d. Help others deal with change _____
2. How could your team or organization benefit by you doing a better job performing one or more of these coaching roles?

3. What advice or feedback will you seek from your coach to enable you to do a better job of:
 - a. Developing other leaders _____
 - b. Maximizing performance _____
 - c. Facilitating learning _____
 - d. Helping others deal with change _____

Now that you have a sense of coaching roles, let's look at how to build rapport with coachees. This opens the door for others to allow you to coach them successfully.

BUILD STRONG RAPPORT WITH COACHEES

The word *rapport* means connection, bond, or affinity. The success of a coaching relationship depends on making a good start with the coachee. The rapport created at the first meeting can determine whether the relationship is productive and beneficial, or difficult and contentious. Building rapport creates a willingness on the part of the coachee to take the risks required for learning or growth. Building rapport requires investing time and attention. At its core, rapport building is trust building. It is trust that gives the coach the right to advise, educate, reframe, probe, or teach others.

Remember that many people have never experienced good coaching. As you initiate the relationship, it is important to spend time getting to know the coachee, and, once you do so, to lay out the coaching plan. Also, no matter how good a coach you are, you cannot coach people without their cooperation. If you try to force coaching, others may acquiesce, without enthusiasm, and your coaching will yield few results. But when you build a powerful partnership with the coachee, you will realize your coaching mission and others will realize their full potential.

Exercise 2–3: Building Rapport with Coachees

Instructions: Think about a time when you were getting to know someone and sought to build rapport with that person. The following exercise presents a list of things coaches do to build rapport. Check those that, in your experience, were most helpful.

- ☐ Communicates in a welcoming and accepting tone of voice.
- ☐ Exhibits a warm and enthusiastic manner that demonstrates interest in the other person.
- ☐ Creates a safe environment by putting the person at ease.
- ☐ Notices what the individual is feeling, both words and emotions, in order to understand where the person is coming from.
- ☐ Displays an honest and sincere desire to get to know the other person.
- ☐ Is willing to reveal something about himself/herself in order to increase the level of intimacy.
- ☐ Demonstrates a willingness to invest time in developing the relationship.

- ☐ Pays close attention to what is being discussed.
- ☐ Avoids monologues and engages in a give-and-take discussion.
- ☐ Keeps focused when talking with the other person and listens attentively.

Now look at Exhibit 2–1. It describes how coaches, once the coaching rapport has been established, continue to build the relationship. If you have been coached, check the items that are most important to you; consider which qualities you value most in working with a coach.

The key to successful coaching lies in a strong relationship with the coachee. How effective you are depends on the ability to develop a sense of collaboration and partnership. As one senior manager said to me, “It is impossible to achieve your coaching mission without a meaningful relationship. Both you and the coachee need to be invested in coaching.”

How do you decide which relationships to invest in? Coaches make a strategic decision how to use their time and energy. They invest in coaching



Exhibit 2–1

Building Good Relationships

Research reveals that coachees identify the following as some of the most important characteristics of good coaches and as crucial to establishing strong coaching relationships.

Clarity of Communication

- ☐ Uses language that is easy to understand.
- ☐ Tells me the whole story.
- ☐ Communicates philosophy and values.
- ☐ Lets me know where I stand.
- ☐ Is always straightforward.

Focus on Results

- ☐ Keeps me focused on the goals ahead.
- ☐ Wants me to be successful.
- ☐ Sets attainable milestones.
- ☐ Has a strong sense of urgency.
- ☐ Is objective about things.

Respectful and Committed

- ☐ Keeps the promises he or she makes.
- ☐ Is easy to talk to.
- ☐ Gives me his or her full attention during discussions.
- ☐ Never divulges a confidence.
- ☐ Let's me make my own decisions.

Supportive and Encouraging

- ☐ Cares about me and how I am doing.
- ☐ Reassures me.
- ☐ Makes me feel confident.
- ☐ Wants me to be successful.
- ☐ Likes to spend time with me.

Handles Difficult Situations

- ☐ Doesn't hide bad news.
- ☐ Handles disagreements privately.
- ☐ Lets bygones be bygones.
- ☐ Is a stabilizing influence in a crisis.
- ☐ Operates well under pressure.

Stretches the Individual

- ☐ Challenges me to do my best.
- ☐ Sets a good example.
- ☐ Won't let me give up.
- ☐ Makes me work out most of my own problems or tough situations, but supports me.
- ☐ Wants me to stretch my skills.

those that enable them and their team to create the future they want. Let's examine this next.

INVEST IN COACHING RELATIONSHIPS

Good coaches use their time well. As a leader, you spend time coaching everyone on your team. But there are some individuals you want to coach more than others. How do you identify these people? The people you select will vary depending on your position in the organization and your role. If you're a project leader you may choose people with the talent and skills you need most; if you're a unit manager you may choose those who have potential to contribute more.

Chris, a manager of a large retail store, had this to say. "Employees' relationship with their manager is one of the most critical factors in creating and sustaining commitment. Managers begin building relationships on the first day of employment and create a sense of ownership by coaching, among other things. No matter what managers say about employees' importance to the organization, they demonstrate their commitment by investing time in them. I focus my coaching on those I really want to retain. It's competitive when you're trying to recruit top performers and keep them. This is where my coaching energy goes—building the loyalty of key people."

In the workplace today, retention is an important issue. Research shows that effective coaching aids retention, especially for Gen X and Y employees. Although there are many characteristics of high-retention employees, here are the ten that are cited most frequently. They are not in order of importance—each organization would rank them differently.

- Specialized knowledge or skills that are hard to replace
- Strong leadership skills
- Consistently top performers
- Highly experienced employees
- Individuals with cutting-edge skills
- Influencers of strong loyalty and morale
- Exceptional understanding of your business or industry
- Strong customer contacts or base of clients
- Excellent cultural fit and exemplifier of core values
- Departure will influence other key employees to leave

Now use these ten characteristics to do Exercise 2–4.

Exercise 2–4: Profiling Your Team

Instructions: The goal of profiling your team is to identify those whom you most want to retain. Consider the ten characteristics just presented and use them to categorize your employees. There are four categories; list each employee in the one of that best describes his or her contribution.

- **Most Essential.** These people are your stars. They consistently deliver top performance and demonstrate over half of the ten characteristics.

- **Strong Performers.** These individuals are very good performers and meet at least three of the characteristics. They are important to your team and consistently exceed expectations.

- **Competent Performers.** Most of the people on your team will fall into this category. These individuals are steady performers and meet expectations day in and day out.

- **Poor Performers.** These individuals are not meeting performance expectations and, if they do not improve, will not longer be part of your team. You need to invest time coaching these individuals for three to six months and note whether performance improves. If performance does not improve, you may need to introduce progressive discipline while continuing to coach.

We will return to this profile in Chapters 4 and 5.

UNDERSTAND YOUR COACHING STYLE AND APPROACH

Many managers I work with have never thought about their coaching style. It's something we take for granted without considering its impact on our coaching effectiveness. Different employees respond differently to each coaching style. There will be times when it is important for you to vary your style depending on what the coachee needs and what you want to accomplish during the coaching session.

Let's begin by diagnosing your coaching style by taking the Coaching Style Assessment, Exercise 2–5.

 Exercise 2–5: Coaching Style Assessment

Instructions: For each pair of items, assign a total of 5 points by dividing the points between both behaviors. Use any combination of points, e.g., 5-0, 1-4 or 3-2.

Think about yourself as a coach. Answer each question based on how you tend to approach and act in a coaching situation. There are no right or wrong answers, only how you prefer to handle a coaching situation.

	Points
1. I like to coach in a manner that:	
a. states what is expected from the coachee	___
b. uses lots of encouragement	___
2. In a coaching discussion, I like to:	
a. take a slow, patient approach to the discussion	___
b. carefully plan the coaching discussion	___
3. I find it helpful to:	
a. use lots of open-ended questions	___
b. confront poor performance or missed opportunities	___
4. It is important for me to:	
a. talk about possibilities and what the coachee can achieve	___
b. encourage lots of self-direction and empowerment	___
5. As a coach I see myself as:	
a. one who does a good job giving explicit direction and guidance	___
b. one who encourages a lot of personal reflection and introspection	___
6. I make it a point to:	
a. take charge of a coaching situation	___
b. be spontaneous and inventive	___
7. I tend to:	
a. be empathetic and seek to understand where the coachee is coming from	___
b. think about how and when to conduct a coaching discussion	___
8. I believe that:	
a. the best coaches focus on a collaborative inquiry	___
b. it is important to speak frankly and candidly	___
9. I find it easy to:	
a. use persuasion and influence during coaching discussions	___
b. listen for both content and feelings	___

10. I believe that:
- a good coaches provide explicit direction and instruction _____
 - b good coaches use lots of questions to encourage a deeper understanding _____
11. I tend to:
- a. focus on goals and outcomes _____
 - b. be creative and in the moment with the coachee _____
12. I find I am very comfortable:
- a building good rapport _____
 - b asking questions to elicit specific information _____
13. In coaching discussions, I tend to:
- a do a lot of assessing and evaluating _____
 - b get the discussion started immediately _____
14. I generally:
- a see myself as a resource for the coachee _____
 - b do all I can to make the coachee feel comfortable _____
15. I believe that a good coach should:
- a be clear and explicit, providing data to support his/her observations _____
 - b do about 80% of the listening and 20% of the talking _____

Now, go to the Scoring Sheet and tally your responses.

Straightforward

1a _____
 3b _____
 6a _____
 11a _____
 13b _____

Total _____

Motivational

1b _____
 4a _____
 6b _____
 11b _____
 14a _____

Total _____

Affiliative

2a _____
 4b _____
 7a _____
 12a _____
 14b _____

Total _____

Methodical

2b _____
 5a _____
 10a _____
 12b _____
 15a _____

Total _____

Facilitative

3a _____
 5b _____
 10b _____
 13a _____
 15b _____

Total _____

The following is a description of the five coaching styles:

- **Straightforward Style:** Coaches with a Straightforward style take a results-oriented approach to coaching. They speak directly and provide lots of advice and direction. These coaches take charge of the discussion and challenge the coachee to do his or her best.
- **Motivational Style:** These coaches like to be spontaneous in the coaching discussion. They like to talk about possibilities and use a lot of encouragement. Motivational coaches share lots of personal examples; it is their way of helping coachees understand how to act on their coaching advice.
- **Affiliative Style:** Affiliative coaches take the time to build rapport with coachees. In their view, it is important to establish a coaching partnership. Conversationally, Affiliative coaches ask a lot of questions in order to understand the coachees' perspective. These coaches pay close attention to the coachees' feelings.
- **Methodical Style:** As a Methodical coach you prefer to plan the coaching discussion carefully, using a step-by-step approach. You use questions to elicit lots of specific information and provide data to support your opinions and advice. Interpersonally, you don't show a lot of emotion during the discussion.
- **Facilitative Style:** Facilitative coaches let the coachee set the coaching agenda. Your approach is one of encouraging self-reflection and self-assessment. In your view, the coaching discussion is best conducted by using open-ended questions that facilitate self-discovery. You are a good listener who works collaboratively with the coachee.

Review the five coaching styles described in detail in Exhibit 2–2, then answer the questions about your style in Exercise 2–6. You need to do this before you even consider how to vary that style.

Exercise 2–6: Validating Your Coaching Style

Instructions: Answer the following questions about your style.

1. Which style best describes you?

2. List a couple of reasons why you chose this style.

3. Just to do a final check, how do you think others would describe your style?



Exhibit 2-2

Style Descriptions

Straightforward Style

What does this coach do in a coaching situation?

- Takes a direct approach to coaching.
- Speaks frankly and with candor.
- Focuses on the end result.

How does this coach relate to his or her coachee?

- Provides specific advice and feedback.
- Challenges coachee to do his/her best.
- Takes charge of the coaching discussion.
- Gets into the coaching discussion immediately.
- Confronts poor performance.

Motivational Style

What does this coach do in a coaching situation?

- Talks about possibilities and coachee potential.
- Inspires coachee to take performance to the next level.
- Is spontaneous and creative.

How does this coach relate to his or her coachee?

- Describes how she/he is a resource for coachee.
- Seeks to influence and persuade to action.
- Shares personal examples and illustrations.
- Uses a lot of encouragement.
- Engages in brainstorming to explore options.

Affiliative Style

What does this coach do in a coaching situation?

- Makes the coachee feel comfortable.
- Builds strong rapport and understanding.
- Takes a slow and patient approach.

How does this coach relate to his or her coachee?

- Seeks to build a strong partnership.
- Uses an empathetic approach.
- Seeks to understand where the coach is coming from.
- Listens for feelings as well as content.
- Creates a comfortable environment.

Exhibit continued on next page

Exhibit 2–2 continued from previous pageMethodical Style

What does this coach do in a coaching situation?

- Carefully plans the coaching discussion.
- Gives explicit direction about what to do.
- Pays attention to details and facts.

How does this coach relate to his or her coachee?

- Models logical thinking and a step-by-step approach.
- Displays little emotion during coaching discussion.
- Asks questions to elicit specific information.
- Provides a lot of data to support opinions or advice.
- Works to make sure coaching session runs smoothly

Facilitative Style

What does this coach do in a coaching situation?

- Encourages a lot of self-reflection.
- Works in a collaborative manner.
- Lets the coachee set the agenda

How does this coach relate to his or her coachee?

- Uses lots of open-ended questions.
- Uses lots of assessment to encourage self-reflection.
- Listens much more than he/she talks.
- Encourages self-discovery and learning.
- Wants the coachee to feel empowered

Sometimes you need to adjust your coaching style (see Exhibit 2–3). There is a close relationship between coaching style and interpersonal style. For example, individuals who have a Straightforward Style interpersonally usually respond best to a coach who takes a direct, candid, and results-oriented approach. Coachees who like to brainstorm, respond to encouragement, and like to see the long-term benefits of coaching respond well to Motivational Style coaching. Some individuals want a lot of support from the coach. These individuals respond to the Affiliative Style. Employees who are analytical and respond to logic and reason get the most from a coach who takes a Methodical Style approach. Finally, the Facilitative Style is most effective with coachees who like self-reflection. These individuals respond best to questioning techniques that encourage them to find their own answers. Now select someone you need to coach. First, decide which coaching style is most like his or her interpersonal style. Try to select someone whose style is different from yours. There is a close relationship between coaching style and interpersonal style. Then complete Exercise 2–7.

 Exercise 2–7: Assessing Your Coachee’s Style

Instructions: Using the style descriptions in Exhibit 2–2, complete the following questions *about the person you selected* as someone you need to coach.

1. Which style best describes this individual?

2. List two reasons why you chose this style.

3. Select one or two suggestions from Exhibit 2–3 that will help you coach this person, and record them below.

4. Now refer again to Exhibit 2–3 and identify one or two things you need to avoid doing during a coaching session.

Congratulations! You have just worked through five key things you need to do to get ready to coach: clarifying your mission, understanding your role, building strong rapport with coachees, investing in coaching relationships, and understanding your coaching style. In the next two chapters you learn the seven-step coaching process. Before you continue, take a moment and reflect on everything you have learned in this chapter by answering the following questions.

1. What are your major learnings about yourself as a coach?

2. What are the biggest changes you plan to make to do a better job getting ready to coach?



xhibit 2–3

Adjusting Your Coaching Style

Coaching in the Straightforward Style

When you work with someone whose Interpersonal Style is Straightforward, you want to coach that individual as follows:

- Define what role the coach will play
- Provide candid feedback
- Get the individual involved in training, new tasks, etc. immediately
- Make sure the coachee knows how to get the job done
- Clearly communicate expectations and goals

During the coaching session you need to make sure you do not speak in a manner that is too Straightforward. Thus the coach needs to *avoid* the following:

- Dominating the discussion
- Pushing the coachee too fast
- Taking ownership of a problem

Coaching in the Motivational Style

When you work with someone whose Interpersonal Style responds best to the Motivational Style, you want to coach that individual as follows:

- Brainstorm alternatives with the coachee
- Offer encouragement and inspiration
- Generate excitement about growth, learning, or other opportunities
- Help the coachee see the long-term benefits and gains
- Engage in open communication to surface issues and concerns

During the coaching session you need to make sure you do not speak in a manner that is too Motivational and overwhelm the coachee. Thus the coach needs to *avoid* the following:

- Glossing over obstacles the coachee perceives as significant
- Talking the coachee into something
- Overwhelming the coachee with your zeal

Coaching in the Affiliative Style

When you work with someone whose Interpersonal Style responds best to the Affiliative Style, you want to coach that individual as follows:

Exhibit continued on next page

Exhibit 2–3 continued from previous page

- Let the coaching session proceed at the pace the coachee sets
- Ask questions that encourage the coachee to realize his/her potential
- Explore the coachee's reservations
- Discuss the coachee's feelings about the performance or developmental opportunity
- Make it clear the coachee has your full support

During the coaching session you need to make sure you do not speak in a manner that is too Affiliative. Thus the coach needs to *avoid* the following:

- Focusing too much on feelings and emotions
- Taking too much time to get to the key issues
- Sacrificing the need to get results

Coaching in the Methodical Style

When you work with someone whose Interpersonal Style responds best to the Methodical Style, you want to coach that individual as follows:

- Use an orderly and logical coaching plan
- Set up milestones
- Use data and factual information
- Talk through how to deal with problems or obstacles
- Explain in detail what the coachee needs to do

During the coaching session you need to make sure you do not speak in a manner that is too Methodical. Thus the coach needs to *avoid* the following:

- Focusing too much on details
- Showing lack of enthusiasm or motivational language
- Setting standards that are too high

Coaching in the Facilitative Style

When you work with someone whose Interpersonal Style responds best to the Facilitative Style, you want to coach that individual as follows:

- Take a collaborative approach
- Encourage introspection
- Build agreement about what to do
- Ask reflective questions
- Help the coachee gain a deeper understanding

During the coaching session you need to make sure you do not speak in a manner that is too Facilitative. Thus the coach needs to *avoid* the following:

- Failing to confront problematic issues
- Personalizing issues when coachees resist coaching
- Failing to reach closure and get commitment to action



Achieving extraordinary results begins with setting the stage for successful coaching. This allows you to bring out the best in the individuals you are coaching. Every great coach has a mission. These coaches develop their mission by reflecting on their goals as a leader, by understanding why coaching is important, and by knowing what they want to accomplish through their coaching.

A lot of research has been done on the role of coaches in organizations today. Four key roles emerge in most organization. The first of these is developing other leaders. Coaching people for high performance every day is vital to developing future leaders. Second, coaches play a key role in helping others maximize performance. Over the years the value of coaching continues to be reaffirmed as the best way to maximize the performance of others. Third, coaches help people learn. Insights, breakthroughs, and innovations all come about by working with a coach who facilitates learning. And fourth, coaches use their skill to help others change. Coaching for change means managing the dynamics that help people let go of the past and move toward a powerful new future.

The success of a coaching relationship depends on making a good start with the coachee by building rapport. Building rapport creates a willingness on the part of the coachee to take the risks required for learning or growth. They invest in coaching those who will enable them and their team to create the future they want.

The need to retain key employees is an important factor in identifying the coaching relationships in which to invest the most time. High-retention employees can be identified by some of the following characteristics: they may have strong leadership skills; be consistently top performers and/or highly experienced; be individuals with cutting-edge skills; work as influencers of strong loyalty and morale; possess an exceptional understanding of your business or industry; have a strong customer contacts portfolio or base of clients; demonstrate an excellent cultural fit and be an exemplifier of core values; or be an individual whose departure will influence other key employees to leave. Developing a profile of your team members to determine the level of their performance (most essential, strong, competent, or poor) helps you assess where you should invest the most coaching time.

Different employees respond differently to a coach's style. There will be times when it is important for you to vary your style depending on what the coachee needs and what you want to accomplish during a coaching session. The primary coaching styles are straightforward, motivational, affiliative, methodical, and facilitative.



Review Questions

1. One of the things you want ask yourself when you clarify your coaching mission is: 1. (a)
 - (a) What are my strengths as a coach?
 - (b) Why is coaching not always my first priority?
 - (c) How much time will I spend coaching?
 - (d) What do great coaches usually do?
2. Coaches build rapport with coachees by: 2. (b)
 - (a) talking a lot about themselves.
 - (b) communicating in a welcoming and accepting tone of voice.
 - (c) asking a lot of open-ended questions.
 - (d) keeping the relationship professional.
3. The four primary roles of a coach are: 3. (b)
 - (a) coaching to develop other leaders, coaching to spark innovation, coaching to maximize performance, coaching for learning.
 - (b) coaching for learning, coaching to develop other leaders, coaching to maximize performance, coaching for change.
 - (c) coaching for change, coaching to improve market share, coaching to develop other leaders, coaching to maximize performance.
 - (d) coaching to maximize performance, coaching for learning, coaching virtual teams, coaching for change.
4. A coach with an affiliative style wants to avoid: 4. (b)
 - (a) talking too much about expectations.
 - (b) pushing the coachee too fast.
 - (c) overwhelming the coachee with zeal.
 - (d) generating too much excitement about an opportunity.
5. When you make a decision to invest time in coaching an individual, it helps you: 5. (d)
 - (a) influence the individual to achieve strategic objectives.
 - (b) communicate your vision with impact and clarity.
 - (c) become a more influential leader from that person's perspective.
 - (d) enhance your ability to retain that individual.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
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or email at ed_svcs@amanet.org.

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3

The Coaching Process, Steps One to Four



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Communicate your expectations.
- Assess a coachee's skill level.
- Define the purpose of coaching.
- Design a coaching contract.

Effective coaches rely on a step-by-step roadmap to execute the coaching process. Exhibit 3–1 illustrates the seven-step coaching process. We explore this process in Chapters 3 and 4, examining the first four steps in this chapter:

- Step One: Communicate Your Expectations
- Step Two: Assess Coachees' Skill and Motivation Level
- Step Three: Define the Purpose of Coaching
- Step Four: Agree on a Coaching Contract

Let's start with communicating your expectations, the first step.

STEP ONE: COMMUNICATE YOUR EXPECTATIONS

So much of coaching involves talking with employees about your expectations. Every coach has expectations—expectations for performance, growth, skill acquisition, and so forth. It can often take an employee months to figure out what you as a manager expect. In that time, there is ample opportunity

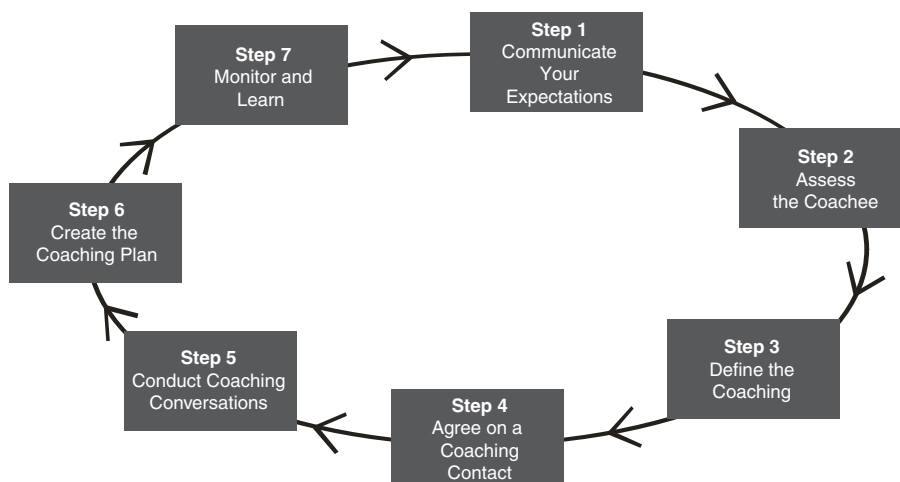
for miscommunication and misunderstanding. Here's a simple exercise: Assume it's your first day of work at a new job. You have gotten to know something about the person you are working for during the interview process. You hope for the best and anticipate a good working relationship. But there's a lot you don't know. If you had a crystal ball, wouldn't it be nice to know:

- What really pleases your new boss?
- What really irritates your boss?
- What your new boss' management style is like?
- How people are expected to work together?
- How your boss makes decisions?
- How your boss likes to communicate, for example, face-to-face or via e-mail?
- What it is really like to work in this department?

Strong coaches make sure they communicate their expectations. When Jani gets a new employee, she spends time talking about what she expects. She told me, "We're a brokerage firm; that means we work at a fast pace. I hire people who are self-starters and can work independently. I expect them to hit the ground running and come to me when they need something. I talk about this during the first few days someone works with me. I want them to know what to expect, and what I expect. It's a time saver and it helps people get off to a good start."

Think about the people you coach. Now answer the questions in Exercise 3-1.

E Exhibit 3-1 The Coaching Process



 Exercise 3–1: Communicating Your Expectations

1. Think about your expectations regarding communication. In what type of situations do you expect others to initiate communication? For example, when there are problems, keeping you updated, etc. Consider as well which issues you want to discuss face-to-face, rather than address through e-mail.

2. What are some of the things that irritate you? For example, being surprised by problems, taking an issue to your boss before talking with you, etc.

3. What are some things that really please you? For example, taking the initiative to deal with problems, going beyond what customers expect, etc.

4. How do you expect people on your team to interact with one another, with customers, with other departments, etc.?

5. What can people expect from you as a manager? For example, do you have regular staff meetings, how often do you give feedback, etc.?

6. What is important for people to know about your department “culture”?

Be sure you have a discussion about expectations early in your relationship with the coachee. In fact, find time to talk with the individual shortly after he or she is hired. This sets the foundation for your coaching relationship.

STEP TWO: ASSESS COACHEES’ COMPETENCE AND MOTIVATION LEVEL

Your ability to diagnose your coachees’ competence and motivation level is important. Dennis, a friend of mine, coaches soccer. I watched him one Saturday morning and was impressed with his ability to give each player very specific instructions. I asked him, “How do you know what each player needs?” Dennis revealed, “You have to get an idea of each kid’s skill level. During practice, I watch them closely and make a decision about how skilled they are; I also find out how motivated they are to make the team. My job is to help the inexperienced ones get better and assign the best players to a position that will challenge them.”

That’s your task too, assessing each coachee on two dimensions, competence and motivational level. Level of competence refers to the extent to which the coachee is meeting expectations, that is, has mastered the job and demonstrates sound interpersonal behavior. Coachees gain competence over time. The second part of the assessment, motivation, considers the extent to which the coachee displays enthusiasm and an active interest in doing his or her best. Like my friend Dennis, you adjust your coaching based on how you assess the coachee’s competence, or skill level, and motivational level.

Exhibit 3–2 depicts the nine skill and motivation levels. Note that coachees can be high, moderate, or low with respect to both competence and motivation. Take a moment to examine Exhibit 3–2. Then read the general descriptions of the various levels of competence and motivation.

E**Exhibit 3-2****Description of Skill and Motivational Levels**

COMPETENCE	High	High Competence High Motivation • Highly skilled and looks for ways to excel	High Competence Motivated • Highly skilled and committed to doing a good job	High Competence Low Motivation • Highly skilled but performing below capabilities
		Competent High Motivation • Skilled and vigorously seeks growth	Competent Motivated • Skilled and keeps performance at expected levels	Competent Low Motivation • Skilled but not meeting performance expectations
	Low	Low Competence High Motivation • Not skilled but working hard to meet expectations	Low Competence Motivated • Not skilled but making a sincere effort to meet expectations	Low Competence Low Motivation • Not skilled and demonstrates little interest in meeting expectations
		High	MOTIVATION	Low

Low Competence and Motivated

This is one of the easiest categories to target. Employees who fall into this category may be new on the job, or need to master a new task or behavior. For those who are low in competence and either motivated or highly motivated, you need to pinpoint areas in which they need coaching to be successful. For example, one of my clients manages a customer service call center. She hires inexperienced service reps and provides on-the-job training. After three weeks of training, coaching is ongoing. Sometimes she coaches new reps to improve the questions they ask. Sometimes coaching focuses on behaviors, such as ensuring the caller's problem is completely resolved. You will engage in similar types of coaching for those who fall into this category.

Low Competence and Not Motivated

When I was managing in a large corporation I was always alert to identify these individuals. I remember when I took over an office administration group. The staff was dedicated but two or three people were performing poorly and didn't seem interested in getting better. I learned that my predecessor had done very little coaching and had provided almost no feedback. If your experience is like mine, you may find that people in this category are unaware of their low skill level. That means coaching will have to be intensive until performance starts to turn around.

In some instances prior coaching has been unsuccessful. For whatever reason, some people are just not motivated to do a better job. You'll recognize this when you get excuses, blaming, and other reasons for below-par performance.

Competent and Motivated

Individuals who are competent and either motivated or highly motivated are not only performing well but seeking to keep performance strong. In fact, those that are highly motivated are actively pursuing growth in the form of new challenges or more responsibilities. Sophie takes a strong coaching role with all her employees. She supervises systems analysts and has done so for the past several years. Sophie told me, "I'm glad to say that I can categorize most of my employees as competent and either motivated or very motivated. When I coach those who are motivated, I focus on strengthening their skills and building their knowledge—that ensures they keep on doing what is expected. For those that are highly motivated, we talk about what they can do to take their skills, knowledge, or job performance to the next level.

Competent and Not Motivated

Individuals who have the skills and experience required to do a good job may not be inspired to do so. That presents an opening for coaching. I remember the first time I confronted this situation. A supervisor was frustrated by a senior human resources specialist who was performing far below his potential. Scott, the supervisor said, "I didn't understand what the problem was at first. But it became clear after a couple of months that although Joe was a competent human resources professional, he was not motivated to meet my expectations. The signs were pretty obvious—missed deadlines, just doing enough to get by, little enthusiasm for the job—everything he did communicated his lack of motivation. When I really understood what I was dealing with, I started aggressive coaching." The signs Scott observed are common when a coachee is not motivated.

Highly Skilled and Highly Motivated

Think about the people you coach. Who are your experts? They are the people you go to when you need difficult problems solved; they are also the ones who mentor others. Individuals who fit here are highly motivated and will remain so as long as their expertise is acknowledged.

Jack talked about his group of paralegals, "I know when a paralegal is an expert because that person can answer any question a lawyer throws at them. They can research an issue so thoroughly that I get everything I need for a brief. I also find that experts can operate with a great deal of autonomy. They really don't need a lot of help from me or any other attorney to do what we need them to do."

Highly Competent and Not Motivated

Similar to those who are competent and not motivated, these individuals are performing far below their potential. Sometimes the reasons are outside the workplace. Individuals with a lot of talent who are not motivated to contribute need coaching but may also need counseling if indeed there are personal issues impacting motivation level. But go ahead and engage in coaching and work with the individual. You may find things you can address. We examine the different motivators in Chapter 6. Through coaching, you may find out that what motivates the individual is lacking and is the root cause of low motivation.

 Exercise 3–2: Assessing Skill and Motivation Level

Instructions: Select three to five individuals you need to coach and complete the following exercise. You may want to use some of the individuals you profiled in Chapter 2, Exercise 2–4 (Profiling Your Team).

- 1. List the names of the individuals and their role on your team.

Name	Role on Team	Skill/Motivation Level Assessment

- 2. Now, using the descriptions and Exhibit 3–2, assess each team member’s skill and motivation level.

COMPETENCE	High	High Competence High Motivation	High Competence Motivated	High Competence Low Motivation
		Competent High Motivation	Competent Motivated	Competent Low Motivation
	Low	Low Competence High Motivation	Low Competence Motivated	Low Competence Low Motivation
		High	MOTIVATION	Low

Coaching Each Skill/Motivation Level

Now that you have assessed skill and motivation levels, let's look at some suggestions for how to coach each group.

Low Competence and Motivated

Individuals who lack skill but are motivated usually need a coach to help them identify what they need to do to raise their skill level. You can use several techniques to help the coachee increase his or her skill and motivation level.

- Work with the coachee to develop an improvement plan.
- Set up milestones and agreements for follow up.
- Explain the support you will provide as the coachee executes the skill improvement plan.
- Talk with the coachee and provide feedback as he/she shows improvement; this will help keep motivation high and encourage the individual to keep working toward skill mastery.
- Use coaching conversations to analyze successes and failures. It is important for the coachee to realize what is working and not working. Ask questions that help the individual self-assess his/her performance.

Low Competence and Not Motivated

Individuals who lack both skill and motivation need a highly directive coach. Begin the coaching process by making sure the coachee understands what a good job looks like. In addition, you need to:

- Set specific skill improvement goals.
- Make sure the coachee knows how to get the job done.
- Provide candid feedback so that the person understands exactly where he/she stands.
- If the individual needs training, get the person involved in training immediately.
- Talk about your priorities. This is important if several skill areas require improvement. Tell the individual which ones need to be mastered first and communicate your expectations. This ensures that the coachee knows what is most important to you.

Competent and Motivated

Sometimes coaches neglect these individuals. That's because they are doing a good job and are motivated to keep meeting expectations. But these individuals need to be coached as a means of sustaining both skill level and motivation. Here are some things you can do to coach these individuals:

- Brainstorm growth alternatives.
- Encourage the coachee to challenge himself/herself.
- Share your knowledge and experience.
- Talk about obstacles and risks if you are encouraging the individual to take on more responsibility.

- Use coaching sessions to establish a process for responsibility transfer, including how you will delegate new responsibilities. This ensures the individual is set up for success.

Competent and Not Motivated

For many coaches, these individuals are an enigma. Why do they lack motivation? It is important that you don't try and figure this out yourself. You need to work with the coachee and together try and pinpoint what's wrong. There are several things you can do to accomplish this, including:

- Ask the individual questions and listen to his/her concerns.
- Encourage the coachee to self-diagnose.
- Talk with the individual about different types of motivators. A coachee who is motivated by autonomy may exhibit low motivation because her work is closely scrutinized.
- Provide support but talk about accountability. Only coachees can improve their motivation level. You don't want to assume responsibility for increasing the coachee's motivation level.

Highly Competent and Highly Motivated

It can be challenging to coach individuals who are giving you peak performance and enthusiasm. But your best employees are also those you most want to retain. Use coaching to help these individuals explore new challenges; it will ensure their motivation remains strong.

- Ask the individual what he or she wants to achieve next and discuss options.
- Set up stretch goals that really challenge the individual; engage the coachee in defining these targets. Let the person know why you are presenting him or her with this challenge.
- Encourage the coachee to design a plan for achieving the stretch goals. Work as an advisor to refine the plan.
- In some instances, you may want to encourage the coachee to shift to a totally new area of responsibility, or this may be something the coachee wants to do. Strategize with the individual and talk candidly about what it will take to be successful.

Highly Competent and Not Motivated

Individuals who have superior skills but lack the drive to do well pose a unique challenge. For example, it is difficult to know how skilled the individual is when motivation is low. Your coaching will be similar to the techniques suggested for those who are competent and not motivated. In addition, you also may want to:

- Use coaching sessions to talk about the contribution the individual could make because of superior skills. This is designed to let the person know that you recognize his/her skills. It can also encourage the person to open up and talk about why his or her motivation is low.

- Let the coachee know that you want to offer support, even if the reasons for low motivation are driven by factors outside the workplace. Advise the coachee that there are resources you can offer if he or she wants counseling from someone else.
- Make it clear that the individual needs to deal with whatever is causing low motivation. Those who are highly competent are typically in key roles. The coachee needs to understand the importance of working with you or someone else to improve motivation.

STEP THREE: DEFINE THE PURPOSE OF COACHING

Coaching is a conversation with a purpose. Once you have assessed skills, ask yourself, “What is missing that, if provided, would really make a difference for the coachee and the team?” Establishing a purpose keeps you and the coachee focused; it is the first step in accomplishing strong results through coaching. Look at Exhibit 3–3, which describes the most common purposes and benefits of coaching. Then complete Exercise 3–3.

Exercise 3–3: Establishing the Purpose of Coaching

Instructions: Select two to three people from Exercise 3–2. For each person, determine the purpose of coaching and write this in the space provided.

Individual #1

Competence and Motivation Level

Purpose of Coaching Discussion

Individual #2

Competence and Motivation Level

Purpose of Coaching Discussion

Individual #3

Competence and Motivation Level

Purpose of Coaching Discussion

These purpose-specific discussions are planned conversations. But as a coach you also want to be alert to opportunities that emerge. In these instances, you want to seize the moment and coach.

An opening for coaching is that critical moment when you can get a lot of mileage out of a coaching conversation. Openings come several ways. Some may be a direct request on the part of a coachee before taking on an



xhibit 3–3
Purpose of Coaching

Purpose of Discussion	Benefits of Coaching
Building Skills	• Help coachee master new competencies • Link performance goals to skill acquisition
Performance Improvement	• Deal with barriers to competent job performance • Uncover reasons for below par performance
Developing Talents	• Help coachee prepare for a future opportunity • Explain a clear career path
Overcoming Conflicts	• Teach coachee how to resolve differences • Advise coachee how to avoid misunderstandings
Problem Solving	• Teach coachee how to think through problems • Coach individual regarding how to overcome obstacles
Commitment and Achievement	• Encourage commitment and build morale • Talk through issues that help coachee move to the next level of achievement

important assignment. Others are recurring as part of the normal business cycle, like annual performance reviews, budget cycle, etc. Some are presented by a particular circumstance, such as difficult performance issues, customer complaints, a major change, etc. Still others occur around important firsts, such as before the first visit of a key customer. Finally, some openings occur randomly. For example, one manager told me, “I seize openings when people come to me and say, in effect, ‘I’m stuck’! In that moment, I know they’re ready to listen to what I have to say. It’s the best time to coach.”

Think about openings for coaching that are likely to present themselves in the course of your day-to-day work. These are in the moment opportunities that emerge. Consider which of the following situations might present an opportunity for coaching. Ask yourself if there is someone who:

- Is ready to take on or has taken on new tasks?
- Can take on significantly more responsibility?
- Is dealing with a major work challenge?
- Has asked for coaching?
- Needs to develop new skills to stay current?
- Is repeating the same mistake or having the same problem?
- Is taking on a new role, for example, leading his or her first project?
- Is seeking your advice in a particular area?
- Is demonstrating mental blocks or wrong thinking?
- Wants to learn a new set of skills?

Let’s talk about how to set up a coaching relationship. You already know how to communicate your expectations, assess skills, and determine the purpose of coaching. We now examine contracting for coaching.

STEP FOUR: AGREE ON A COACHING CONTRACT

Every coaching relationship is different. A few weeks ago I was debriefing a group of managers who had just completed a leadership development program. We talked about their experience working with a coach. One common theme emerged from those who had the best coaching experience; these individuals described the importance of contracting. For some, the contract was informal, for others, more formal.

The following list contains things you want to discuss as part of creating a contract.

- **Goals of your coaching.** Discuss the specific things you and the coachee want to achieve as a result of coaching. Ask yourself, “What is possible for this person to do?” You also want to ask the coachee, “What do you want to achieve?”
- **Coaching schedule.** Discuss how often you and the coachee will meet. Will you meet weekly, every two weeks, monthly?
- **Length of meetings.** Discuss how long coaching discussions will last. Certainly, meeting duration can vary but it is good to talk in general terms. In so doing, you’ll make sure you set aside the appropriate amount of time.

- **Duration of coaching relationship.** The purpose of coaching will determine how long the relationship will last. Coaching for specific skill mastery usually means a short-term, very focused coaching relationship. Coaching for overall performance improvement often requires you to spend more time coaching. When you are coaching someone who works for you, the coaching relationship is ongoing. So, rather than clarifying the duration of the coaching relationship, you'll discuss the timetable for accomplishing the coaching goals you and the coachee have agreed upon.
- **Format for coaching.** More and more, coaching does not always have to be face-to-face. Let the coachee know that when it's impractical to meet in person, you can coach over the phone.

Exercise 3–4: What You Learned in Steps One to Four

Instructions: Let's reflect on what you have learned while working through the first four steps of the coaching process. To do this, answer the following questions.

1. Reflect on Steps One to Four. What are the major things you learned about each step?

Communicating Your Expectations

Assessing Coachees' Competence and Motivation Level

Defining the Purpose of Coaching

Agreeing on a Coaching Contract

2. What actions do you plan to implement immediately?



As a coach you need to develop a step-by-step roadmap for executing the coaching process. The first four steps in the coaching process are: Step One, communicate clear expectations; Step Two, assess coachees' skill and motivation level; Step Three, define the purpose of coaching; and Step Four, agree on a coaching contract.

Strong coaches make sure they communicate their expectations to employees. In so doing, they minimize the opportunity for miscommunication and help coachees get off to a good start. Talking with a coachee shortly after he or she is hired sets the foundation for your coaching relationship.

Your ability to diagnose your coachees' competence and motivation levels is important. Two things are critical when you make this diagnosis: to what extent has this individual mastered critical skills, job responsibilities, or behaviors; and how motivated is this individual to do a good job?

Coaching is a conversation with a purpose. Coaches need to think about the purpose of their coaching. It keeps the coach and coachee focused, and it is the first step in accomplishing strong results.

An opportunity for coaching is that critical moment when you can get a lot of mileage out of coaching conversations. Opportunities come several ways, and good coaches are sensitive to and seize these teachable moments.

Every coaching relationship is different. Contracting with your coachee, whether formally or informally, clarifies key aspects of the coaching relationship. Contracting includes talking about the goals of coaching, the coaching schedule, and the format for coaching.



Review Questions

1. When you clarify your expectations, one of the things you want to discuss is: 1. (a)
 - (a) your management style.
 - (b) how long you have been a manager.
 - (c) how you prefer to work with your boss.
 - (d) what other departments contribute.
2. Low Competence and Motivated employees are those who are: 2. (b)
 - (a) performing below expectations.
 - (b) new to the job.
 - (c) deliver their best.
 - (d) often discouraged by heavy workloads.
3. One of the primary reasons for coaching is to: 3. (c)
 - (a) develop shared vision.
 - (b) build stronger communication.
 - (c) solve problems.
 - (d) manage frustrations.
4. When you contract with a coachee and agree on the duration of the relationship, you need to: 4. (a)
 - (a) recognize that coaching for performance improvement always requires more time than skill coaching.
 - (b) determine how long a coaching relationship will last.
 - (c) set aside time for face-to-face coaching.
 - (d) involve the person you coach in setting up the contract.
5. One of the things you can do to coach those who are highly competent and highly motivated is to work with the individual and: 5. (a)
 - (a) set stretch goals.
 - (b) determine aspects of your job the individual can assume.
 - (c) talk candidly about ways to avoid burnout and stress.
 - (d) talk about why you want to provide coaching less frequently.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
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The Coaching Process, Steps Five to Seven



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Develop effective listening skills and build strong questioning techniques.
- Conduct various types of coaching conversations.
- Create a coaching plan.
- Evaluate coaching effectiveness by monitoring behavior.

In Chapter 3 we examined the first four steps in the coaching process: Step One, communicate your expectations; Step Two, assess coachees' skill level; Step Three, define the purpose of coaching; and Step Four, communicate your expectations. In Chapter 4 we examine the final three steps: Step Five, conduct coaching conversations; Step Six, create the coaching plan; and Step Seven, monitor and learn.

Before exploring Step Five, conduct coaching conversations, we explore two critical questions: How do you lead a coaching conversation? and How can you make sure the coachee is actively engaged in the discussion? Mastering the essentials of listening and questioning, two skills that every successful coach has mastered, gives us the answers.

DEVELOP EFFECTIVE LISTENING SKILLS

Listening is both a visible and invisible activity. The visible aspects of listening are the first things coachees notice; they include your posture, eye contact, and welcoming or distracted body language. The invisible aspects are

the things that are going on in the mind of the coach. Both aspects greatly impact whether you actually hear what the coachee has to say. Successful listening requires that you carry out both the visible and invisible aspects well.

What does a coach do to practice good listening? Let's take a look at three important aspects of effective listening: staying focused, understanding the message, and respecting the coachee.

Staying Focused

Staying focused is one of the biggest challenges to listening. In order to stay focused you can do several things:

- Clear your mind of whatever has been occupying your thinking before the coachee enters the room.
- Make sure your office, or wherever you are meeting, is free from distractions. If your computer is on, turn away from it so you are not distracted by new e-mail messages.
- Prepare to mentally engage with the coachee, and keep your mind open to whatever the coachee has to say.
- Notice how the coachee enters the room and his or her body language as the discussion begins. Does the coachee seem excited or discouraged? What else does the body language tell you?

Understanding the Message

You will spend most of your conversation building an understanding of what the coachee has to say. As one coach said, "You have to remain open to the coachee's message while mentally interacting with the information. I make sure I don't ask too many questions too quickly but use a few well-directed inquiries to get a better understanding of what the coachee is telling me."

Coaches listen *for* certain things, rather than listening *to* what the coachee says. What are some of the things coaches listen for? Barry is a senior editor in a publishing firm. He talked about a recent discussion with one of his editors. The editor lamented that he was tired of the publishing business, saying things like, "I feel like I'm losing my identity; I don't think I'm really making a difference in this business." Barry said, "I listened closely to the underlying message and asked myself, 'What's he really concerned about?'" I realized this individual believes the value of books is to make a positive impact on the lives of others—educating, informing, challenging, and enlightening. He saw editing as insignificant to meeting this goal. I said to him, "Editors perform many functions. Suppose you had an opportunity to be on the panel that signs new authors?" This really excited him; the new assignment was a direct link to his passion. I would have missed it unless I listened to the underlying message."

There are times when the coach is listening for gaps between what the coachees are saying and what they are really doing. For example, many supervisors say they want their people to be empowered. I worked with one supervisor who talked about this all the time. But I noticed that whenever a problem arose, the supervisor was quick to take charge of the situation.

During one of our coaching sessions, I pointed this out. There was some defensiveness on her part, but she came to realize there was a gap between what she said and what she did.

Respecting the Coachee

Coaches show respect for the coachee by letting individuals express themselves, by not interrupting, and by not judging what the individual says. Aaron, a medical director, was reflecting on a recent coaching experience. He said, “I always thought I was a pretty good coach. I set up a weekly coaching session with Elise, a new administrator. But after our second meeting, she seemed to be shutting down and was less open. It suddenly occurred to me that I was doing most of the talking. I remembered what my best coach told me about the 80/20 rule—the coachee does 80 percent of the talking, the coach 20 percent. I had reversed this! At our next meeting I made sure I did not finish Elise’s sentences, or introduce new topics that were on my agenda, but not hers.”

To show respect for the coachee, you need to:

- Take a breath before you interrupt.
- Remember that the focus is on the coachee; resist the temptation to introduce new topics before you have explored the one under discussion.
- Pause when you are tempted to finish a person’s sentence or thought—keep listening!

The Listening Process

We’ve examined what it takes to be a good listener. Now, let’s look at how you will execute the listening process when you are face-to face with the coachee. Take a look at Exhibit 4–1, which illustrates the four-step listening process, and at Exhibit 4–2, which provides a description of each step.

Example: Effective Listening

Let’s examine a situation that illustrates how effectively coaches do or do not listen. Read Kristen’s story and evaluate her skills.

Kristen, the manager of a municipal planning team, was coaching Devon, an environmental specialist interested in career growth. Devon has requested a transfer to the training department. Her interest in developing computer-based learning systems is strong and that’s a new direction the training group is pursuing. Kristen decides to talk with her about this move.

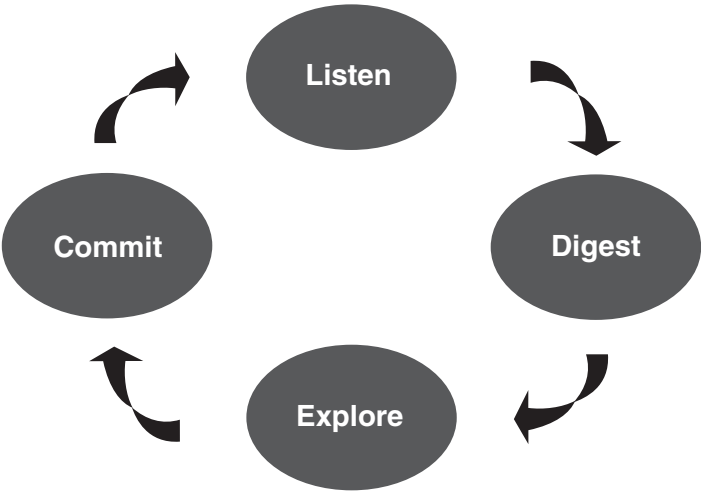
Kristen begins the discussion by listening to Devon’s explanation about why she wants to be part of the training group. Shortly into the discussion, Kristen says, “What you have to remember, Devon, is that today’s trainers have very strong computer skills. That department designs a lot of computer-based training. I am skeptical about your ability to acquire the skills needed. I know you are motivated but that may not be enough.”

Devon makes a good case about why her experience, supplemented by additional training, will enable her to meet the challenges of the new job. She



xhibit 4–1
The Listening Process

The way we listen to coachees can build trust.



advises Kristen that she has been asked to be part of a cross-functional team that will start up in a couple of months. Its task is to design several new training programs for city employees. She believes working on this project will help her understand what it takes to design effective computer-based training. During her description of the cross-functional opportunity, Kristen interrupts the discussion to take a phone call. She apologizes to Devon and says, “That call was important. Just let me relay the message I got to my boss and then we can go on with our conversation.” It takes Kristen two to three minutes to e-mail her boss.



xhibit 4–2
Description of the Listening Process

Step	Purpose of Step	What Coach Does	What Coachee Feels
Listen	Seek to understand	Listen for what’s said and not said.	“I want to be heard and understood.”
Digest	Process the information	Clarify what the coachee is saying.	“I want to talk about the real issue.”
Explore	Open discussion of ideas	Brainstorm ideas with the coachee.	“I want to hear your ideas.”
Commit	Decide on next steps	Get agreement on what the coachee will do.	“I want to come to a decision about what to do.”

Kristen refocuses her attention on Devon and asks, “What do you see as the next steps? What can I do to support you?” Devon explains that she needs Kristen’s support to get involved in the cross-functional team. She says, “I am willing to put in extra hours so that my regular duties don’t suffer, but I may fall behind on a few things. However, I’ll make sure all the high priority projects are on track.” Kristen frowns and says, “What you’re saying is that you can’t really give your job the attention it needs if you work on the cross-functional team? That’s going to put more pressure on the rest of us.” Devon restates what she said and reassures Kristen she can be part of the cross-functional team and still keep up with her most important work.” Kristen agrees, reluctantly, and closes the meeting.

Exercise 4–1: Assessing Kristen’s Listening Skills

Instructions: List two or three things Kristen needs to improve with respect to her listening skills.

Answer to Exercise 4–1: Improving Kristen’s Listening Skills

Kristen made several mistakes during her coaching session. Let’s examine where she needs to improve. We’ll also look at a couple of other things good listeners do and avoid doing.

First, strong coaches are aware of how well they are listening. As a listener, Kristen’s listening abilities were inhibited because she filtered the information Devon communicated. *Filtering* means listening to what the coachee says with preconceived ideas and prejudgments. That’s why Kristen was quick to assume Devon would not be able to acquire the skills needed for the training position.

Coaches need to be aware of their listening challenges, including the filters they are using. Some filters are so deeply ingrained they are hard to recognize. To recognize yours, ask yourself, “How quick am I to judge what other people tell me?” Filters guide how we respond to others, whether we can be in the moment with the coachee rather than listening for what we expect to hear. Test yourself by asking, “How often do I ask people to repeat themselves because I misinterpreted what they were saying?” It is likely Kristen has a bias about employees’ inability to balance cross-functional project work with day-to-day duties. She revealed this when she assumed Devon would not be able to do it.

Second, good coaches make sure they are not interrupted during a coaching session. Kristen stopped the discussion to take a call and then sent her boss an e-mail. Interruptions like this disrupt the thoughts of the coach

and the coachee. It also lets the coachee know that the coach needs to do other things—things that are more important than talking with the coachee. Similarly, you need to make sure you don't schedule appointments too close together. As your next appointment approaches, you will be distracted and rush the coaching session to conclusion. In fact, I've had coaches cut off a discussion in the middle of a meeting, just when I was making an important point!

Third, a good coach must listen to make sure the coachee is not saying what he or she thinks you want to hear. When you suspect a coachee is "saying the right things," think about why the person is not being candid. In these situations you need to tell the coachee what you think is happening, for example, "I get the idea that you are telling me what you think I want to hear." You may need to reassure the coachee; remind the individual that you want to hear what is really happening, where he or she is struggling, etc. and that you are not there to judge. This encourages the coachee to be honest and not fear criticism.

Fourth, remember that there are times when you need to paraphrase what the person has said to you. Paraphrasing is not putting words in the coachee's mouth. It's restating what the coachee has said in simpler language, in your own words, and then checking with the individual to see if you have paraphrased correctly.

Your Listening Skills

It is hard to underestimate the importance of listening. Too many times we focus on what we have to say. We feel it is what we tell the coachee that influences them, motivates change, and gets them to take action. But really it is how we listen that has the greater influence on behavior. The way we listen encourages people to achieve, produce, and get results.

Exercise 4–2: Assessing Your Listening Skills

Instructions: Think about the four-step listening process and answer the following questions.

1. In what areas do you exhibit poor listening skills?

2. Why do you find the areas identified in Question 1 challenging?

3. Specifically, what will you do differently the next time you meet with a coachee to ensure you listen effectively?

FORMULATE STRONG QUESTIONING TECHNIQUES

The second skill necessary to conduct coaching conversations is developing and asking strong questions. We begin by considering what make a question effective.

Qualities of Effective Questions

One of the most powerful things a coach can do is ask good questions. This is more challenging than it first appears. As leaders we tend to think, “I know how to ask a question!” Let’s take a look at some of the pitfalls you may not even be aware of in asking good questions.

Exercise 4–3: What’s Wrong with This Question?

Brooke, a financial manager, is coaching one of her analysts, Kyle. He has been on the job about six months and Brooke believes he is ready, with coaching, to take on more responsibilities. She opens the coaching conversation by asking Kyle the following question:

“Do you think there are things you need to work on or be more skilled at in order to take on more responsibilities, or do you think you have mastered everything and can still do a good job on current projects even with more to do?”

List two to three reasons why this is not a good question.

Answers to Exercise 4–3: What’s Wrong with This Question?

Effective coaches know that good questions elicit useful information. Let’s look at the attributes of effective questions and how Brooke’s question fell short.

Brief

An effective question is brief; it enables the coachee to quickly understand what you're asking. Brief questions help the individual maintain his or her attention by getting to the point. This is just one of the problems with the question Brooke asked. By the time she got to the end of the question, it's likely Kyle forgot the first part! Similarly, the longer, or more complex the question, the more difficult it is for you to remember what you asked.

Clear and Understandable

Good questions are clear and understandable. This is the second mistake Brooke made. Her question has at least three inquiries embedded in it. Put yourself in Kyle's place, which one do you answer first? It's not really clear what Brooke wants to know and what she is after. Thus, when Brooke asked, "Do you think there are things you need to work on in order to take on more responsibilities, or do you think you have mastered everything and can still do a job on current projects even with more to do?" her question was multi-focused. Brooke's question implies there is a "right" answer. If Kyle really wants to take on more responsibilities there is only one answer he can give. The way Brooke asked the question discourages Kyle from frankly discussing his concerns or needs. Kyle may want to explore ways to balance his workload with new responsibilities but he is unlikely to bring it up.

Relevant

Effective coaches keep their questions relevant. Coachees can be surprised and thrown off balance when you spring a question that is irrelevant to the topic under discussion. As a coach, you want to keep the discussion on track. Make sure your questions don't encourage a tangent that wastes time and confuses the coachee.

Open-ended

Finally, effective questions are open-ended. This almost goes without saying. But in a difficult coaching conversation, the coach sometimes forgets this. One coach told me, "When I'm trying to make a point and the individual is resisting me, I tend to force the issue. That's when I forget that I have to keep the questions open-ended, even if it means the coachee will not give me the answer I want."

Major Types of Questions

Look at Exhibit 4-3, which describes five major types of questions and provides an example of each. Reviewing this exhibit provides a basis for the next topic, conducting coaching conversations. Each discussion uses one or more types of questions so you need to be familiar with them before we proceed.



Exhibit 4–3

Five Types of Questions

Factual Questions	Questions that are designed to elicit data, information background, or establish a common understanding. Example: <i>“What is the status of your three projects?”</i>
Probing Questions	Questions that encourage the coachee to provide a more thorough explanation. These are “why” questions. Example: <i>“Why do you believe you need more staff?”</i>
Hypothetical Questions	These are “what if” questions that encourage a coachee to consider new ideas or explore new options. Example: <i>“What if you tried another approach with her?”</i>
Either/Or Questions	Either/or questions help a coachee decide which alternative to pursue or which choice is the best. Example: <i>“Would you rather go back to school or enroll in an on-line course?”</i>
Summary Questions	Summary questions allow a coach to bring part of a coaching discussion to a close and move on to a new topic. Example: <i>“Let me review what we have discussed so far. . .”</i>

STEP FIVE: CONDUCT COACHING CONVERSATIONS

You use all of your listening skills and questioning techniques in conducting a coaching conversation. We begin the discussion by examining the various types of coaching conversations.

Coaching conversations are special conversations. Every time you talk with a coachee there’s the possibility of revealing opportunities, solving problems, encouraging growth, and exploring other aspects of the coachee’s performance. Coaching conversations differ from routine conversations in that they require a commitment to the topic—not just chitchat, but a conversational exchange that makes a difference. Let’s look at the type of conversations you will conduct.

The Appraisal Conversation

Many new coaching relationships begin with assessment. David took over a team in a large financial services organization. He said, “One of the first things I wanted to do was get an idea about who was on my team. I believe in the value of coaching and I particularly like to begin by discussing core strengths and weaknesses. I use a lot of probing questions to elicit a person’s self-evaluation, questions like, “What do you see as your greatest strengths?” After nine months I do a formal performance coaching session. In these situations I also find

assessment questions useful. I begin by asking each person, “How does my assessment of your performance match yours?”

The Encouragement Conversation

Many coaches tell me confidence building conversations are essential. Confidence building conversations use a variety of probing, hypothetical, and other types of questions. Sue, an insurance agent, told me that her coach keeps her motivated through confidence building coaching. Sue said, “It’s easy to get discouraged when you have a bad month. It’s hard to imagine you’ll ever turn things around. Stacy, our area director, coaches us when we review our monthly results. She helps me see what’s possible, even when my numbers are down. By focusing on the future, she challenges me to set more ambitious goals! That may sound strange, but encouraging me to be more aggressive tells me she has confidence I can get my sales up.”

Remember that factual questions—statements, really—can be confidence builders. For example, skilled coaches use factual statements to encourage a coachee, by saying things like, “Let me tell you what qualities I see in you.” Follow up these confidence-building statements by asking an assessment question, for example, “Do you agree with the qualities I see?” Together these widen horizons of possibilities for coachees to consider.

The Teaching Conversation

One of the toughest coaching challenges is knowing how and when to give advice. There was a time when coaching conversations were only about telling the coachee what to do. But today effective coaches give advice strategically, seizing teachable moments. It’s important to make sure the coachee is ready to hear your ideas. So before launching into what you have to say, ask the coachee, “Can I give you some advice?” or “Would you like to hear what I would do?” or “Let me explain what I see as your best option in this situation . . . ?” In so doing, you’re offering advice, not imposing your ideas. Framed as a question, you open the door for discussion, using your advice to begin a dialogue in which you and the coachee talk about the best course of action.

The Probing Conversation

Sometimes you need to draw the coachee out. Probing, hypothetical, and either/or questions are all useful for helping an individual think more deeply, find the answer, and extract meaningful lessons learned. I frequently conduct coaching sessions with managers who are grappling with lots of issues. It’s important for me to guide the discussion in a way that helps them examine complex issues and draw the right conclusion. I remember one manager who was facing a difficult reorganization. The reconfigured organization was going to impact lots of people, and involved a degree of risk because of merging departments that had been “competitors.” I wanted to make sure the manager thoroughly explored the pros and cons of his reorganization plan. I asked questions like:

“Why do you think you are struggling with this decision, since you told me this is absolutely the right thing to do?”

“Tell me more about the situation you are facing.”

“Give me an example of the type of resistance you expect—what do you think it will be like?”

The Correcting Conversation

What do you do when someone you are coaching is making decisions based on misconceptions or wrong assumptions? Carrie, a senior associate with a management consulting firm, described her situation to me. She said, “To be a good consultant you have to listen carefully to what is happening with the client, digest lots of information, and recommend the right course of action. We hire lots of well-educated people who are eager to prove themselves and move up the partner track fast. Sometimes they’re too eager; they jump to the wrong conclusion based on a shallow understanding of the real issue. Coaching in these situations is tricky because I don’t want to tell the consultant what to do. I use a correcting conversation to help the individual realize they’re drawing erroneous conclusions. Some of the statements and questions I use are:

“That’s one possible interpretation about the client’s situation. What’s another?”

“Aren’t you making a quick assumption about the underlying problem based on similar experiences?”

“Let’s make a distinction between what the client actually said and how you have interpreted what he said.”

The Commitment Conversation

The coach needs to do everything possible to ensure the coachee acts on commitments made during a coaching conversation. I make it a point to end every coaching conversation with a summary question that encourages action. Some of the questions I use are:

“What’s your next step?” “I want to remind you of your commitment to...”

“When will you have this issue resolved?”

Sometimes commitment conversations are necessary when your coachee is slow to make changes. Encouraging the individual to act is important. Not only do you want the coachee to move forward, but you also want to know if there are reasons why he/she is procrastinating.

Exhibit 4–4 summarizes these six types of conversations and when to use each.

Now complete Exercise 4–4. Read each situation and decide which type of coaching conversation is most appropriate.



xhibit 4–4
Types of Coaching Conversations

Type of Conversation	When To Use This Conversation
Appraisal Conversation	• Understand what the coachee needs. • Engage the coachee in self-assessment.
Encouragement Conversation	• Help the coachee overcome fear or discouragement. • Help the coachee see past blind spots or obstacles.
Teaching Conversation	• Provide specific information and share experiences. • Teach the coachee something new.
Probing Conversation	• Get the coachee more engaged in the discussion. • Engage the coachee in thinking more deeply about the issue.
Correcting Conversation	• Reframe wrong assumptions or decisions. • Correct how the coachee approaches a situation.
Commitment Conversation	• Help the coachee commit to taking action. • Clarify the next steps when the coachee is unsure.

 Exercise 4–4: Your Coaching Conversation

Situation 1

You are coaching someone who aspires to supervision. Over the past two months you have delegated team leader responsibilities to this individual. Your observation reveals that she tends to micromanage others. However, she is pleased with her performance. She feels that since all deadlines were met and “nothing fell through the cracks,” she is well on her way to moving into an official leadership role.

Purpose of Conversation	What Type of Conversation?

What Questions Will You Ask?

- ---
- ---
- ---
- ---

Situation 2

You are coaching a high performer. She has only been in the job two months but has demonstrated the ability to take on higher level work. However, you want to make sure you don't advance her too fast and possibly overwhelm her with too much responsibility, too soon.

Purpose of Conversation

What Type of Conversation?

What Questions Will You Ask?

- ---
- ---
- ---
- ---

Situation 3

You are coaching someone with an "attitude problem." He is negative and you constantly get complaints from others. His attitude is "can't do" rather than "can do." You are not sure how he will accept your coaching.

Purpose of Conversation

What Type of Conversation?

What Questions Will You Ask?

- ---
- ---
- ---
- ---

Answers to Exercise 4–4**Situation One**

The purpose of this coaching conversation is Performance Improvement. In this situation, you need to help the aspiring supervisor change the way she is supervising others. You want her to understand that micromanaging others is not what you are looking for in a supervisor.

Thus, you want to have a Correcting Conversation with her. Some of the questions you might ask are:

“What assumptions are you making about what makes an effective supervisor?”

“Have you thought about the downside of micromanaging employees?”

“Think about what the people you manage need most from a supervisor. How do those qualities match what you’re doing?”

Situation Two

The purpose of the coaching conversation is Developing Talents. Your high performer must decide what she is prepared to take on in terms of greater responsibilities. This requires an Assessment Conversation. You want the coachee to consider what she can realistically do, how soon, and when. This will tell you how to handle the responsibility transfer, and after assuming new duties, what type of coaching the person will need. Questions you might ask are:

“What do you think are your greatest strengths in taking on new duties?”

“What obstacles do you foresee in moving to a new level of responsibility?”

“What can I do to support you in making this change?”

Situation Three

The purpose of this coaching conversation is Problem Solving. This is a difficult coaching situation that involves dealing with an “attitude problem.” Situations like this require a combination of Teaching and Probing Conversations. First, you need to describe what impact a negative attitude is having on job performance. This aspect of teaching allows you to explain what acceptable behavior looks like. Next, you want to engage the coachee in an open discussion. Probe the individual and find out the reasons for the negativity. It’s important to combine these two types of conversations. Some of the things you might say during the discussion are:

“When you deal with customers, this is the attitude you need to adopt . . . ”

“You usually expect the worse when dealing with customers. Why is that?”

“Tell me what you’re going to do to work better with customers?”

Planning Your Coaching Conversation

You now have an opportunity to design a coaching conversation. Remember that many times you will conduct more than one type of conversation during a single coaching discussion. For example, you might begin a discussion and engage the individual in an appraisal conversation. As you understand the coachee’s self-perception, it becomes clear you need to shift to a probing conversation or a commitment conversation. Exercise 4–3 instructs you to select a couple of people you want to coach and plan the type of conversation you want to conduct. You may want to refer back to Exercise 3–2 and choose from those people whose competence and motivation level you have already assessed.

 Exercise 4–5: Planning the Coaching Conversation

Instructions: Select one or two people you need to coach and answer the following questions.

Person #1: Name _____

1. Describe the purpose of the discussion.

2. What type of conversation(s) will you have with this person?

3. What type of questions will you ask or what statements will you make to generate discussion?

Person #2: Name _____

1. Describe the purpose of the discussion.

2. What type of conversation(s) will you have with this person?

3. What type of questions will you ask or what statements will you make to generate discussion?

STEP SIX: CREATE THE COACHING PLAN

Coaching sessions need to conclude with agreement on a plan of action. To begin the process, summarize what's been discussed and review the options you have explored.

An experienced coach provided the following advice: "I brainstorm possible options with the coachee. This reinforces the idea that the coachee and I are in this together and allows me to play the role of thinking partner. Then we discuss, sort out, and evaluate possible courses of action. I close the brainstorming session using summarizing questions to solidify what has been discussed and what the coachee has said he/she will do."

You need to make sure the coachee is committed to actually doing what you have agreed on. How do you do this? Ask commitment questions and read the verbal and nonverbal behavior. For example:

"How soon will you get started with the new project?"

"What's most exciting to you about this opportunity?"

"How soon will you start working on this?"

"What is your first step?"

"When do you want to schedule the first status check?"

Remember that when an action plan is ambitious, coachees need to display strong commitment and motivation. Also, the more aggressive the action plan, the more a coachee needs to know he or she has the support of the coach. Great coaches are able to do this without undermining the coachee's initiative to take action. You want to make it clear that you are available to provide advice, act as a sounding board, and brainstorm ideas if the coachee gets stuck. In some instances, the support means using your influence with your peers or senior managers to open doors. Your goal is to make sure there are no barriers to success; you also want to make sure the coachee has the resources needed to do the job.

You'll want to work with the coachee to design a realistic action plan. Consider a plan that includes the following components:

- **Action**—specific task or activity
- **Expected Results**—the deliverables, in other words, what outcomes will be achieved as a result of the actions
- **Completion Date**—when the action or activity is to be finished
- **Resources**—what the coachee needs in terms of resources
- **Coaching Support**—what you will do to help the coachee
- **Status Review**—when you will do the first follow up

Let's see how this might play out.

Mike, a new college instructor, needs to improve his evaluations, the year-end assessments of teachers by their students. His department chairperson is coaching him. The two have agreed that over the next semester Mike will pursue the following plan:

Action: Design team projects that enable students to practice implementing the concepts taught.

Expected Results: Students will be able to pinpoint their own learning gaps and take a more active role in the learning process. Subsequent instructor evaluations should show higher scores on specific measures, such as “Keeps students engaged through participation in relevant assignments” and “Creates a learning environment that encourages practical application of theories and concepts.”

Completion Date: End of the next semester.

Resources: Introduce Mike to teachers who get high scores on these measures. They can share some of their techniques with him.

Coaching Support: Coach Mike as he develops team projects, providing the benefit of my experience and offering advice about what makes a successful project.

Status Review: Review project proposals at four-week and eight-week intervals.

STEP SEVEN: MONITOR AND LEARN

The final step in the coaching process answers the following questions:

“What do you do between coaching sessions?”

“What do you look for?”

“How can you determine whether your coaching is effective?”

These are questions all good coaches ask. Step Seven is designed to monitor what’s happening with the coachee and learn what you need to focus on in subsequent coaching conversations. The following situation gives you an example of how Step Seven works.

Example of Monitoring and Learning

Brittany was an account executive for a digital communications company. Due to rapid growth, she finds herself handling a large workload. At first, Brittany found it exhilarating. She said, “I didn’t mind working through lunch and until 9:00 p.m. every night. But I am beginning to feel burned out. We’re hiring people but they are ‘nine to fivers.’ I hate to complain and I’m starting to sound like a victim. But I don’t see any way out of the time I am putting in. How else will everything get done?” Sean, her manager, began coaching Brittany. He worked with her to start transferring some of her responsibilities to two new account executives. Sean talked with Brittany about her business development goals. He advised her to focus on these and helped her prioritize her other work. Sean said, “Right now you’re trying to do everything. Your new business targets are top priority. You’ve got three other projects we can revisit in six months. They’re not critical. I want you to help me orient the new people we’ve hired but I don’t expect that to take much time. Let’s meet every two weeks for a

status check. But you should feel free to come to me any time if you have questions.”

 Exercise 4–6: Monitoring Coaching Effectiveness

Instructions: Think about Sean’s situation in coaching Brittany. What are two or three things he should monitor?

Answer to Exercise 4–6: Monitoring Coaching Effectiveness

Sean should take the following steps to monitor his coaching effectiveness:

- Look for changes in behavior. For example, he will note whether Brittany actually works to transfer tasks to new account executives and puts her less important projects on hold.
- Observe whether Brittany asks for his help when she runs into problems or roadblocks.
- Check to see how Brittany is doing meeting her new business goals.

Some of the other things a coach can do to monitor performance between coaching session include:

- Checking to see whether the coachee is showing evidence of mastering new skills, or putting new learning into practice.
- Observing the extent to which the coachee is fulfilling his/her new responsibilities, and noting areas in which additional coaching is required. You also want to assess whether the individual has the capabilities to do what is required.
- Rewarding and recognizing changes in behavior, goals achieved, etc. This is important because it encourages the coachee to keep pursuing goals and making changes.
- Keeping track of the extent to which the coachee takes initiative and seizes opportunities. For some coachees this will be more important than others. But typically, between coaching sessions, the coachee has opportunities to act on coaching commitments. You want to observe whether this is happening.
- Setting up interim coaching sessions when you need to make quick course corrections. This is a time for a correcting conversation, or perhaps some specific instructions. If you’re having regular coaching conversations, you’ll be able to get the coachee back on track in a timely way. But there are times when you can’t wait and must take immediate action. Keep spaces in you calendar so you are available to give extra coaching if required.

- Remember that a key to both Step Six and Step Seven is good follow through. Make sure you set up the next coaching conversation at the end of each session. This communicates that you are going to stay on top of what's happening. The idea is not to create an endless series of coaching meetings. But you want to communicate that coaching for results requires accountability—for example, keeping the action plan from getting lost in day-to-day tasks or the crisis of the moment. Accountability means that you too will be working collaboratively to get things done. It encourages the coachee to come to you with problems or questions.



Key aspects of effective listening in a coaching situation include staying focused, understanding the message, and respecting the coachee. The steps in the listening process that lay the foundation for trust in the coaching relationship are: listening, where the coach seeks to understand; digesting, where the coach processes the information; exploring, where the coach and coachee openly discuss ideas; and committing, where they decide on next steps. Successful coaches demon-

strate their listening skills by exhibiting several characteristics: they are aware of how well they listen, they make sure they are not interrupted during a coaching session, they listen to make sure the coachee is not just saying what he or she thinks the coach wants to hear, and they occasionally paraphrase what the coachee has said for confirmation.

One of the most powerful things a coach can do is ask good questions. Effective coaches know that good questions elicit useful information. Effective questions are brief, clear and understandable, relevant, open-ended, and they invite an open and honest response.

Similarly, coaching conversations are special discussions. Every time you talk with a coachee you have the possibility of revealing opportunities or solving problems, encouraging change, and other things. Coaching conversations are designed to appraise, encourage, teach, probe, correct, or secure commitment.

Effective coaching sessions conclude with agreement on a plan of action. Brainstorm what to do with the coachee and then evaluate possible courses of action. You also need to make sure the coachee is committed to actually do what you have agreed on. Use commitment questions to confirm agreement to move forward and take action. A coaching action plan specifies the following: the action to be taken, the expected results, a completion date, the resources available, coaching support, and the date of a status review.

The final step in the coaching process is designed to monitor what is happening with the coachee and learn what you need to focus on in subsequent coaching conversations. There are several things to pay attention to between coaching sessions, including monitoring changes in behavior, checking to see if there are roadblocks, and observing the extent to which the coachee seizes opportunities.



Review Questions

1. Effective questions are brief and enable the coachee to: 1. (a)
 - (a) quickly understand what you're asking.
 - (b) focus on several things at once.
 - (c) avoid having to give a yes-or-no response.
 - (d) give answers that are relevant.
2. Encouragement conversations are essential because: 2. (b)
 - (a) the coach needs to give the coachee advice in a diplomatic manner.
 - (b) the coach needs to help the coachee focus on future possibilities.
 - (c) the coach needs to encourage the coachee to think more deeply.
 - (d) the coachee has misconceptions or is making poor decision.
3. In order to make sure the coachee is committed to actually doing what you have agreed on, ask a commitment question, such as: 3. (c)
 - (a) Is this coaching plan too complicated?
 - (b) What have you learned from our coaching sessions?
 - (c) When will you get started working on this?
 - (d) Did we brainstorm enough alternatives?
4. One of the things a coach monitors between coaching sessions is: 4. (b)
 - (a) with whom the coachee is meeting.
 - (b) whether the coachee is showing evidence of mastering new skills.
 - (c) how much energy the coachee is exhibiting.
 - (d) whether the coachee has an action plan.
5. Coaches make sure they understand what the coachee is saying by: 5. (c)
 - (a) keeping an open mind.
 - (b) respecting the coachee.
 - (c) listening to what the coachee is saying.
 - (d) overlooking discouragement or negativity.

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Delivering Coaching Feedback



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Describe the purpose and characteristics of effective feedback.
- Construct and deliver good feedback messages.
- Deliver difficult feedback.
- Deliver just-in-time feedback.
- Lead a peer feedback meeting.

The legendary Ted Williams of the Boston Red Sox had a goal of being the greatest hitter who ever lived. But what most people don't realize is the extent to which Williams sought feedback. Ted knew that no matter how much talent a person has, we don't see ourselves as others see us. Feedback provides that fresh, objective lens. A coach steps back and watches how the coachee performs; his or her feedback enables us take our performance to a new level. But feedback is only helpful if it is effective. So it is imperative that you set the stage with the coachee. The first step is getting ready to give feedback.

GETTING READY TO GIVE FEEDBACK

Even in the best of situations, feedback is an emotional moment. How do you get ready to give feedback? What do you need to do to set up the feedback session for success? Let's look at six essential things.

First, gather your thoughts. Don't rush into a feedback situation and speak before you think about what you want to say. Ask yourself:

“Why am I delivering this feedback?”

“What do I want to say?”

“What impact do I want to have as result of this feedback?”

I shared these guidelines in a training session a few years ago. One of the individuals in the workshop challenged, “But what if you don’t have time to gather your thoughts—suppose you’ve got to give it on the spot?” “Good question,” I responded, “But preparation doesn’t have to take hours. What you want to avoid is blurting out something you will regret, or that will incite a situation.” Gathering your thoughts means taking at least a minute or two to think before you speak.

Second, wait until you can talk in person. One of my colleagues said, “I remember one of my worst feedback experiences. I admit the project was in trouble, in part because I was a new project manager, but feedback by e-mail? I couldn’t believe my manager did that! To me, it was disrespectful—it was a waste of time because I was so upset.” Face-to-face feedback communicates to the coachee, “This is so important I am making sure I deliver it in person.”

Third, make sure you’re in a position to give the feedback in a private place. This was once taken for granted. But today, with so many companies using open office spaces, there is a temptation to talk in an open cubicle where others can overhear the conversation. Privacy helps ensure the individual can focus on what you’re saying, not on who else might be listening. Like coaching sessions, both you and the coachee need to give full attention to the feedback discussion. That can’t happen in a public setting. When you’re in a public place, all the coachee is thinking about is, “Let me just get through this!”

Similarly, select an appropriate environment. Leaders often assume their office is the best place to deliver feedback. But when you’ve got to give bad news, your office may not be the most appropriate setting. Remember that the setting is as important as the message you’re about to deliver. Consider using the employee’s office, or even better, a neutral space like a conference room. Employees tend to be more relaxed in a neutral area. If you do decide to use your office, sit next to the individual rather than across the desk. This sets a more conversational, less emotional tone and helps the individual be more at ease.

Fourth, set up the discussion. Don’t just launch into what you have to say. Begin the discussion by talking about things like common goals, reviewing prior discussions, describing why you need to talk about these issues now, or similar things. Talk about the reasons for delivering this feedback, for example, why it is important for the employee to understand what’s not working and why. Putting the feedback in a meaningful context helps the employee understand its importance.

Fifth, prepare notes to guide what you want to say. When you speak extemporaneously, you’re more likely to talk about motives, not actions, or speak in generalities, rather than facts. Getting into motives means you are speculating about something you can’t know that’s not really important. Remember that you are giving feedback about results, performance, or

interpersonal interactions, not personality. What's important is explicitly giving solid feedback that the coachee can understand and act on. Also, consider whether you yourself should have done things differently.

Clare, an entrepreneur magazine publisher, had this to say. "Start-ups are a special situation. The hours are long and whether you'll make it is uncertain. I hired everyone here and thought I'd made good decisions. One of my best writers was promoted to department head. She didn't have experience but she was such a good writer I took a chance. I didn't do any coaching—I was busy running the magazine and signing up subscribers. When Robin began to struggle, I didn't notice until it was almost too late. I had to give her tough feedback but I assumed part of the responsibility. Talking about my culpability made it a little easier for Robin."

Finally, be prepared to talk about the next steps. Certainly, you'll want to hear the coachee's response to feedback and what he/she will do to correct the problem. But come to the meeting with what you believe needs to happen. In some instances, the coachee may not know what to do, or may be so discouraged that he or she feels the situation is hopeless. Your description of an improvement plan communicates that the feedback the person has just received is the first step toward turning things around.

GIVING EFFECTIVE FEEDBACK

Feedback discussions are a means for learning, growth, and positive change. We're going to look at eight characteristics of effective feedback. To initiate this discussion, consider what ineffective feedback looks like by doing Exercise 5–1. You may have been the recipient of it—most of us have.

Exercise 5–1: Characteristics of Poor Feedback

Instructions: List two or three characteristics of poor feedback.

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Most Common Complaints About Feedback

Why do some leaders give feedback in a way that brings out the best in others, whereas others do it in a way that brings out the worst? Why do some people give feedback in a way that others gladly accept, whereas others only put people off? Masterful coaches in business, sports, etc. avoid feedback that:

- Doesn't enable learning or growth
- Is too general
- Is not timely
- Is subjective and judgmental
- Doesn't describe what needs to change
- Is based on assumptions
- Is negative and demoralizing
- Is close-minded

Characteristics of Effective Feedback

Let's look at the seven characteristics of effective feedback, which are summarized in Exhibit 5–1. Then we'll examine a few do's and don'ts. The combination of these two provides a solid foundation for understanding what you need to do to give good feedback.

First, effective feedback helps the coachee see the gap between intended performance and actual performance. Have you ever been frustrated, trying to get better at something but not knowing how, or what you're doing wrong? In my spare time I sometimes do cross-stitching. I'd gotten to be pretty good but when I saw really excellent work I knew I was falling short. So I asked

E

xhibit 5–1
Characteristics of Effective Feedback

Characteristics	Description
1. Effective feedback helps the coachee understand performance gaps.	Use feedback to describe how to overcome performance issues.
2. Effective feedback identifies and confronts blind spots.	Use feedback to reveal patterns of thinking or behavior that coachee is oblivious to or does not want to acknowledge.
3. Effective feedback helps an individual learn from his or her mistakes.	Feedback shortens the learning curve by extracting lessons learned from mistakes.
4. Effective feedback pinpoints areas for growth and development.	Feedback enables the coachee to reach full potential by sharing perceptions about strengths, special skills, etc.
5. Effective feedback provides an objective and data-driven description of behavior.	Feedback is expressed using data and explicit observations so that the coachee understands specifically what he or she needs to do more or less of.
6. Effective feedback is timely.	Feedback is well timed and allows the coachee to immediately turn around performance or seize opportunities.
7. Effective feedback celebrates small wins.	Feedback inspires individuals and keeps motivation high.

my friend Cindy to help me. I was amazed. She took one look at a piece of my work and immediately gave me a couple of wonderful suggestions. That's an example of how feedback helps close performance gaps.

Second, feedback helps us confront our blind spots. What does this mean? Matt was in a rut. He is a team leader in a major hotel. His company had made the strategic decision to expand its presence in southern California and open a number of new hotels. In his industry, the ability to attract quality employees *quickly* is a major competitive factor. Matt was under pressure to fill a number of open jobs and get a new San Diego hotel staffed. To do this, he had to expedite his usual hiring process. Matt was resisting this change. David, his manager, used feedback to confront Matt's resistance. David said to him, "Matt, I know you put the hiring process in place; you've got a lot invested. But we've got to find a way to get people on board faster. At this rate, we'll never get the hotel staffed on time. It's hard to change processes we've developed. The need for change is not a reflection on you but refusing to change will be."

Third, effective feedback enables people to learn from their mistakes. Shrewd coaches use feedback to shorten the learning curve. All of us can empathize with how difficult it is to face mistakes. A good coach helps us refocus and shift from remorse or embarrassment to insight into what we need to do differently.

Fourth, feedback pinpoints areas for growth and enables people to realize their full potential. Chelsea had this to say. "I think I'm pretty objective about how good an engineer I am. But I never considered taking on a major facility redesign project. It amazed me that my manager thought I could do this! His feedback was convincing—he talked about how good a project manager I am and that I was the ideal person for this job. Without his feedback, I never would have considered this opportunity."

Fifth, feedback should be descriptive rather than subjective or evaluative. Subjective feedback is based on assumptions. This type of feedback is often vague, that is, nonspecific, accusatory, and judgmental. Descriptive feedback is based on observed behavior and data. The goal of descriptive feedback is open communication that builds understanding, empathy, and trust. It is specific and accurate. The coach is willing to check inferences when he or she is unclear about what observed behavior means.

Here's an example of how to distinguish between descriptive and subjective feedback. Bill manages a copy center. He said, "I was walking through our facility the other day and heard one of our client reps arguing with a customer. When he finished, I told him I'd overheard the conversation. I asked him to go through the whole situation and explain why he was brusque in his comments. The rep disagreed and said he was merely being "assertive." I called it "hostile." He didn't get it and I realized calling his behavior "hostile" was vague and subjective. I said to him, "Let me describe exactly what I saw and heard. I heard the customer ask you when his printing job would be done. You told him how busy we are. When he asked for an estimate, you responded, 'I can't tell you precisely when and I don't want to be put on the spot. Your voice was raised.' I talked him through how he might have

responded differently and helped him understand why I was so concerned.” That’s the power of descriptive feedback. It paints a picture for the individual.

Sixth, effective feedback is timely. A colleague of mine coined the phrase, “Feedback has a short shelf-life.” I couldn’t agree more! If I hear one complaint about feedback more than any other, it’s that feedback is not well timed. So many people tell me things like, “I heard about all the mistakes I’d made over the past year when I got my annual performance review. By then, it’s too late to do anything.” Coaches that are slow to give feedback undermine their credibility. They rob the coachee of the opportunity to take just-in-time action to turn around performance or seize an opportunity for learning or growth. One tip though: You need to let enough time pass so that you are not simply acting out of anger, frustration, embarrassment, etc. That’s critical when you’re upset, even emotional about what’s happened. Wait until you can talk with the coachee in a calm, objective manner before you give the feedback.

Seventh, effective feedback creates small wins that stimulate, rekindle, or engage people’s energy and drive. Use feedback messages to inspire individuals and keep motivation high. An information technology manager said to me, “Nothing is more difficult than big technology projects. Nobody is happy and there is never enough time. I make sure I set aside time to give the team feedback—what’s going well, what are immediate problems we need to take care of, where we are on the timeline, things like this. Talking about small victories keeps everyone energized.”

The Do’s and Don’ts of Coaching Feedback

There are a few do’s and don’ts associated with giving effective feedback. They are a few simple things you want to remember, and they can make all the difference between success and failure when delivering feedback. Many of them are common sense, but are things we tend to forget. Take a look at Exhibit 5–2. It’s a quick checklist that summarizes the do’s and don’ts of effective coaching feedback.

Example of Delivering an Effective Feedback Message

The following example provides you with an opportunity to practice giving effective feedback. After reading the following situation, complete Exercise 5–2.

Joanne is a consultant who wanted to become more involved in creating leadership development programs. She asked Ron, her boss, for an opportunity to design an executive training session dealing with critical thinking skills. Ron agreed and worked with Joanne on a rough course outline and timetable for delivering the first draft. Ron talked with Joanne a couple of weeks before the first draft was due; she said everything was fine. But Joanne missed the due date. When Ron asked her what happened, she said she misunderstood the deadline. Ron and another consultant had to work all weekend to get the first draft done.

Ron was very upset. But he waited until he calmed down and before talking with Joanne. He told me, “I was so tempted to just spew out my



Exhibit 5–2
Coaching Do’s and Don’ts

Do	Don’t
Focus on changeable behavior.	Don’t talk about personality traits or personal style.
Start by positively affirming talents, gifts, and what the person is doing that works well.	Don’t start with negatives or launch immediately into corrective feedback.
Take into account the coachee’s needs and your own needs.	Don’t ignore your own feelings and emotions when speaking to coachees. If either of you is upset or angry, wait before giving feedback.
State feedback clearly, then check for comprehension.	Don’t rush through the feedback without giving the coachee time to digest and understand what you are saying.
Give manageable amounts of feedback; if there are several issues, focus on those that require immediate action.	Don’t overload employees with too much feedback.
Use observable data and factual information.	Don’t use assumptions or generalizations.
Make it clear that a person has a choice about acting on the feedback.	Don’t insist that the person agree with your feedback.

frustration and anger, I decided to write out how I felt and then rewrite it. That’s how I was able to give Joanne good feedback.”

 Exercise 5–2: What to Say to Joanne?

Subjective Message	Descriptive Message
“This assignment was a stretch assignment; you didn’t appreciate how important it was to meet this deadline with a quality product.”	
“You tend to overestimate your skills; you’re not realistic about what you can and cannot do.”	
“Covering your failure by calling it a miscommunication shows a lack of professionalism.”	

In the left column of Exercise 5–2 are Ron’s subjective messages. Using the Descriptive Message space, rewrite each message using the seven characteristics of effective feedback presented earlier in this chapter. Pay particular attention to writing a message that is both descriptive and based on facts or observable data.

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Exhibit 5–3

What to Say to Joanne?

Subjective Message	Descriptive Message
“This assignment was a stretch assignment; you didn’t appreciate how important it was to meet this deadline with a quality product.”	“When we agreed on the deadline, I asked if you had questions about the pilot due date or the quality of what you had to deliver. You said the development schedule was clear and you felt confident about delivering a high-quality pilot course.”
“You tend to overestimate your skills; you’re not realistic about what you can and cannot do.”	“Course development requires both content knowledge and an ability to create a learning experience that builds skills. This was a stretch assignment. Your content knowledge is good but you are inexperienced in creating a total learning experience.”
“Covering your failure by calling it a miscommunication shows a lack of professionalism.”	“I want you to talk with me when you have problems completing an assignment. It doesn’t hurt your reputation as a consultant to ask for help. But your reputation is damaged because we had to take over the project at the last minute to get it done.”

Now turn to Exhibit 5–3. It shows you what an effective message for Joanne would look like. Compare it to the message you crafted.

Preparing to Conduct Your Feedback Meeting

Select someone to whom you need to give feedback. Then, based on what you learned from Exercise 5–2, complete Exercise 5–3. I recommend writing out the Subjective message before crafting the Objective message that you will deliver. That’s because it sometimes helps to get down on paper unedited feedback. Read your subjective comments over, then decide how to deliver the feedback objectively.

 Exercise 5-3: Designing Your Feedback Message.

Subjective Message	Descriptive Message

DELIVERING DIFFICULT FEEDBACK

When is it most difficult for you to do a good job giving feedback? A public relations manager said to me, “Feedback is never easy for me to give but it’s particularly hard when I know it is going to be a difficult discussion. I tend to procrastinate and have a hard time saying what I most want to say.” I think all us can empathize with this manager’s feelings—it is tough to give good feedback in difficult situations. Let’s look at techniques for dealing with these feedback challenges. To begin, complete Exercise 5–4. It instructs you to think about a difficult feedback situation you are facing in your current work situation, and then answer the three questions.

Exercise 5–4: Giving Feedback to Difficult Person

Instructions: Think of a “challenging” person with whom you currently work. This could be a peer, a subordinate, or even your boss. It should be someone for whom an effective feedback conversation would be useful.

1. Describe the behavior that this person exhibits. Be specific.

2. What “labels” would you be tempted to use to describe this person (lazy, arrogant, always late, unmotivated, etc.)?

3. What have you tried so far in terms of dealing with the behavior?

Now look at Exhibit 5–4. It provides examples of how you can phrase feedback for a difficult person.

You can frame the feedback message in a way that is clear and descriptive by using statements that use:

- **A specific example.** It is always good to provide specific information in difficult feedback situations. For example, if you are talking with someone who denies there is a problem, or does not understand what needs to be different, giving the individual a specific example paints a picture.
- **“If/then” statements.** These statements clearly point out the consequences of an individual’s actions. If/then statements are particularly



Exhibit 5–4

Framing Feedback Messages

Certain phrases help you frame your feedback message in ways that are more objective and descriptive, and that avoid “labeling.”

Use a Specific Example

“As a portfolio manager you need to do a better job listening to the concerns of our customers. For example, last week two customers expressed concern about their investments. When I asked you what you have done to resolve the issue, you said, “I haven’t gotten to it yet. Our commitment was to respond to them as soon as we could.”

If/Then

“If we can’t get agreement on how to realign your responsibilities, I can’t do anything about the excessive hours you are working. I need to know which projects you want to keep and those you want to hand off.”

What I like about that is . . . and what I don’t like is . . .

“I really like the fact that you are asking senior managers to give input on your project— it will build support as we move forward. What concerns me is that you were too general when you asked for input. I suggest you . . .”

When you . . . I feel . . . Because . . .

“When you agreed to let everyone know when you’re out of the office, and you don’t, like yesterday, I feel frustrated because you’re not available and decisions get delayed.”

Behavior Impact

“I’ve been encouraging everyone to speak up in team meetings. I noticed that in today’s meeting you interrupted Liz. After your third interruption, she shut down and we never got to hear her ideas.”

What we agreed to is . . . and what’s happening is . . .

“You agreed to meet with me at 9:00 before our staff meeting. For the past two weeks, you’ve been unavailable when I came to your office for the meeting.”

effective when you want to let the coachee know what will happen if the problem is not addressed.

- **“What I like about that is . . . and what I don’t like about that is . . .” statements.** Framing the feedback in this way helps you give balanced feedback. Many times it is important to point out what went well in a given situation and contrast that with what needs to change.

- **“When you . . . I feel . . . because” statements.** In some coaching situations, you want the coachee to know how you feel. But you don’t want to launch into talking about your feelings without putting them in the proper context. These statements juxtapose the coachee’s behavior with your feelings about that behavior.
- **Behavior impact statements.** Impact statements provide a powerful description for the coachee. Coaches use this technique when individuals don’t understand the consequences or outcomes. For the individual receiving the feedback, it provides a clearer understanding of why a change in attitude or behavior is essential.
- **“What we agreed to is . . . and what is happening is . . .” statements.** This is another way of framing the feedback to provide specific data. One of the reasons you want to end the coaching session with a commitment to action is to make sure you have an agreement about what the coachee will do. In instances where the coachee does not follow through, these statements allow you to remind the individual in a feedback session.

Now complete Exercise 5–5 by thinking about and writing out feedback messages using one or more of these phrases.

Exercise 5–5: Write Out Your Feedback Message

Instructions: Think about phrases you might use to frame your feedback message:

JUST-IN-TIME FEEDBACK

My friend Lisa teaches people how to make effective presentations. I’ve watched her lead training sessions and am amazed at the improvement people make during a six-hour workshop. I’m even more amazed as I watch her give feedback. It’s quick, it’s balanced, and it communicates a powerful, exact message in a simple way. I asked Lisa if she thought her approach would work for other types of feedback situations. She said, “I use three pieces of feedback: Things to Keep Doing, Things to Pay Attention to, and Things to Improve. It can be adapted to a variety of situations in which someone wants to give feedback.”

Here’s an example of this technique. I worked with a manager who had to deliver sensitive feedback to one of our consulting clients. Corey put in a lot of time preparing a written report and then developed a PowerPoint presentation. He had a short 30-minute client meeting. I played the role of the client and he practiced giving me the feedback he had to deliver. Using Lisa’s technique, this is the feedback I gave Corey:

Things to Keep Doing

- You made good strong opening comments.
- You kept your comments short and focused.
- You maintained good eye contact, especially when talking about the most serious problems.

Things to Pay Attention To

- Watch the pace of the discussion; the comments were crisp but sometimes you seemed to rush.
- Make sure the client has the full report at least a week before your meeting; he has to read it before you meet.
- Be careful how much humor you use. The report is not good news and I don't think you can lighten the mood with humor.

Things to Improve

- Keep your voice strong throughout the discussion.
- Use more examples to illustrate your key points.
- Don't attribute any of the feedback to the people you interviewed.

One of the things I like about this technique is that it forces the coach to focus on more than just improvements. It makes you consider all aspects of performance, and think in specifics. Talking about strengths and weaknesses is helpful, but there is a danger of lapsing into generalities. This approach forces you to ask, "How does this person need to be different, what is he or she doing that really works, and what are a few things to watch out for?"

Exercise 5–6: Providing Just-in-Time Feedback

Instructions: Think about someone to whom you want to give some quick feedback and answer the following questions.

1. Describe the person and the situation.

2. List three things the person should keep doing.

3. List three things the person should improve.

4. List three things the person should pay attention to.

PEER FEEDBACK

In the next chapter we examine how to use coaching to help teams grow and mature. But feedback can also build stronger teams as well as enhance each person's contribution to the team. Every day a team changes in some way. Team members develop new skills, the team itself faces new challenges, change disrupts the team's routine, etc. The leader must consider, "What's the right approach for giving feedback to the team?" Savvy leaders like Taylor have this to say. "When team members provide feedback to one another, it is an opportunity for an individual to learn how he or she is perceived by peers. I work for a computer manufacturer. We're responsible for doing product documentation. It's too easy for words like "team" and "team-work" to become clichés—what do they really mean? Groups mature through awareness and learning. That's why we use peer feedback. I can say the same thing but it has more impact when you hear it from your peers."

Peer feedback focuses on what a team member does well and needs to do better. Because team members are often most responsive to what their peers say, peer feedback motivates the most meaningful behavior change. A team needs to work together for at least a year before you engage in peer feedback. You want to ensure all team members are comfortable with the process; this is critical to producing the best results.



Exercise 5–7: Individual Feedback Activity

Instructions: This is a peer feedback group exercise you can do with your team. It is designed to give and receive feedback in a structured manner, and to guide individuals in working through issues and concerns. The eight steps are as follows:

Step One. Decide the period of time you want the feedback to cover. Will it be annual, at the completion of a major project, etc. Explain that this is an opportunity for each person to share what he or she contributes to the team and get feedback from others that reaffirms self-perceptions and provides insight about how to contribute more.

Step Two. Talk with the group about how to give feedback. You can use the seven guidelines for effective feedback described in this chapter.

Step Three. Ask team members to answer two questions:

“I see myself as a valuable member of the team because _____.”

“I believe I could be more valuable to the team if I _____.”

If you are using the feedback activity to debrief a key project, you can modify the questions:

“I believe I was a valuable member of the project team because _____.”

“I believe I could have been more valuable to the team on this project if I _____.”

Give people three to five minutes to write out their answers to these questions.

Step Four. Ask for a volunteer to begin and give that person two or three minutes to answer both questions. Consider whether you want to participate in this exercise. If you do, lead off the discussion yourself by answering the two questions.

Step Five. After the first volunteer has finished, ask each team member to spend three to five minutes giving feedback. Stipulate that those giving feedback should introduce their comments with the phrase, “I see you . . .” Instruct them to talk first about the value the individual is providing and then describe what the person can do to be more valuable.

Repeat steps Four and Five until everyone has had a chance to share his or her self-perception and get feedback from others.

Step Six: Lead a summarizing discussion by asking three questions:

How close were your own self-perceptions to others’ perceptions of you?
What kinds of traits, behaviors, and attitudes were cited as being of greatest value?

Were there any common themes?

If you have an opportunity, chart the common themes.

Step Seven: After the discussion is complete, allow five to seven minutes for team members to review all the information they have heard. Ask everybody to decide which feedback items they want to address. Advise them to select no more than two items to work on over the next six months. Now, ask each person to share the selected items with the entire team. Go first and share the items you have selected.

Step Eight: Conclude this feedback exercise by acknowledging the team for being willing to give feedback. Express your intention to follow through on the commitments you have made and your hope that each team member will do the same. Thank the group for their participation.

ASKING FOR FEEDBACK

Before we leave this chapter, let's talk about how to ask for feedback. Gia is a property manager for Baird and Warner. We were having coffee one day when she talked with me about the importance of asking for feedback. Gia said, "In any given year, I work with ten to fifteen property owners. You assume you're doing a good job and then you get feedback that tells you otherwise. That taught me to ask for feedback."

Have you ever had an experience like Gia's? So often people tell me they want more feedback but don't know how and when to ask for it. The following sample questions provide suggestions about what you can ask to solicit feedback.

- What do you *not* like about the way I interact with you?
- What do you think I could more of?
- What do you think I could do less of?
- What do you think I should stop doing?
- What do you think I should keep doing?
- What do I do that makes your job easier?
- What do I do that makes your job more difficult?
- What do you see as my strengths?

Exercise 5–8: Getting Feedback from Others

1. Think about how feedback from others could help you and select one or two questions you want to ask others. Write them down.

2. Decide from whom you want to get feedback.

3. How will you use the feedback you solicit? You want to be able to tell those from whom you are seeking feedback why you want this feedback.



Feedback provides the coachee with a fresh, objective lens. A coach steps back and watches how the coachee performs; their feedback enables us to take our performance to a new level.

Coaches must be ready to give feedback. To do this, gather your thoughts, wait until you can talk in person, and make sure you can talk in a private place. You also need to select an appropriate environment, set up the discussion, and prepare notes to guide what you say.

Feedback discussions are a means for learning, growth, and positive change. Seven characteristics of effective feedback include helping the coachee see performance gaps, confronting blind spots, helping people learn from their mistakes and pinpointing areas for growth, providing descriptive rather than subjective and evaluative feedback, making sure feedback is timely, and celebrating small wins.

When delivering difficult feedback, it is important to provide specific examples, frame feedback with “if/then” statements, contrast what went well in a given situation with what needs to change, juxtapose the coachee’s behavior with your feelings in response to that behavior, make impact statements that illustrate the effects of the coachee’s behavior on others, and summarize what the coachee has agreed to do with what he or she has actually done.

Just-in-time feedback is a three-step process for delivering quick, balanced feedback. Coaches use it in the moment, and describe what the coachee needs to keep doing, to pay attention to, and to improve. This technique forces the coach to focus on more than just improvements and think about all aspects of performance.

Peer feedback is a tool that helps build stronger teams as well as enhance each person’s contribution to the team. It is an eight-step system designed to give and receive feedback in a structured manner and guide individuals through issues and concerns.

It is important to know how and when to ask for feedback. Questions for eliciting feedback include:

- What do you like about the way I interact with you?
- What do I do that makes your job more difficult?
- What do you see as my strengths?



Review Questions

1. Coaches gather their thoughts before giving feedback, asking themselves:
(a) How long do I want the feedback session to be?
(b) Why am I delivering this feedback?
(c) Who else has provided feedback?
(d) Why do I need to provide positive feedback? 1. (b)
2. One of the characteristics of effective feedback is that:
(a) it is general.
(b) it enables people to learn from their mistakes.
(c) it is highly personal.
(d) it does not create an emotional response. 2. (b)
3. In using a peer feedback technique, one of the steps is deciding:
(a) the period of time you want the feedback to cover.
(b) how and when to involve those outside the team.
(c) which team members to include and exclude.
(d) how to let the team decide what it wants to ask. 3. (a)
4. When you solicit feedback from others, one question to ask is:
(a) why don't you want to cooperate with me?
(b) what is your motivation for giving me this feedback?
(c) do you feel you can be objective in giving me feedback?
(d) what do you think I could do more of? 4. (d)
5. When delivering difficult feedback, it is important to:
(a) give the coachee time to process the information.
(b) take into accounts the coachee's needs.
(c) use an impact statement that shows the coachee the consequences of his or her behavior on others.
(d) make it clear the person has a choice about acting on your feedback. 5. (c)

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
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6

Coaching for Motivation and Retention



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Define motivation and list its characteristics.
- Describe the baseline expectations of all employees.
- Implement the six most common types of motivation in performance coaching.
- Identify the demographic composition of your organization's workforce.
- Coach employees who belong to different generations, based on their key motivators.
- Use coaching throughout the employment life cycle to enhance retention.

Think about how you might answer the following questions:

Over the past few years, have you found it more difficult to keep individual and team motivation high?

Do you find that you have to think more and more about what motivates different groups of employees?

Over the past few years have you found it more challenging to coach in a way that inspires commitment and loyalty?

When I ask these questions in my workshops, I find that virtually all managers answer “yes” to all three. Every organization I know is concerned with increasing employee commitment, loyalty, and motivation. A mid-level bank manager talked with me over coffee about his struggles. He said, “I

don't think traditional motivational techniques work any more. Expecting unconditional loyalty and long-term service is a thing of the past. The workplace I knew is gone. I would say that when I joined this organization most of us were motivated by the prospect of a raise and maybe a promotion after several years of service. But new workplace realities mean dealing with employees who are motivated by lots of different things, some of which I am not sure I can offer."

WHAT IS MOTIVATION?

Motivation begins by understanding what employees want from their managers and the organization. Over the past few years, our understanding of the relationship between coaching and motivation has increased. This chapter explores this connection. Our first step is to build a basic understanding of what motivation means.

Motivation is derived from the word *motive*, which means an emotion, desire, need, or similar impulse that causes one to act in a particular way. In the workplace, motivation means to provide an incentive, to move to action, or to impel. Running a business, government agency, or not-for-profit organization requires leaders to understand the essence of motivation. Ed leads a real estate team responsible for buying and selling commercial property. His team is implementing an initiative to promote and market its services to major institutional borrowers. Ed said, "This is a major effort. I need to motivate everyone to give 100 percent to get it done! I know how I think about motivation, but I need some guidelines."

Look at the following motivation statements and decide which ones are true and which ones are false. Answering these questions will develop the guidelines Ed is seeking.

Exercise 6-1: Characteristics of Motivation

Instructions: Indicate true or false for each of the following statements.

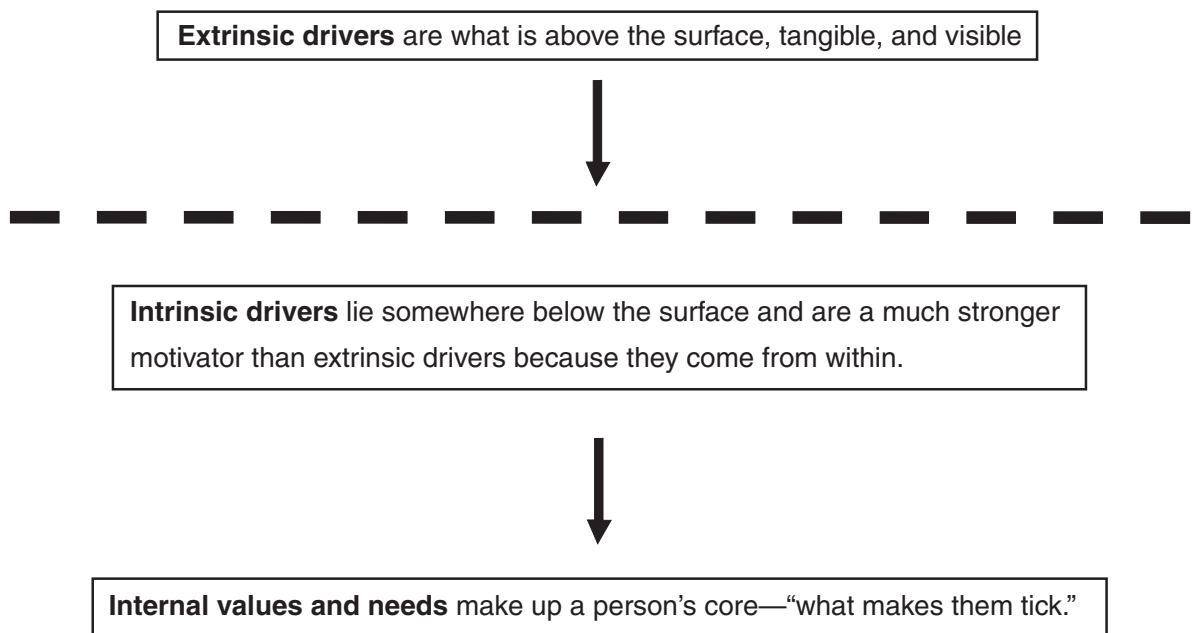
- ___ Good leaders are ones who can motivate others.
- ___ Different things motivate different people, although all people find money motivating.
- ___ Motivation is an art, not a science. It takes time and a willingness to experiment.
- ___ Motivation includes doing something to achieve a positive result as well as avoiding something to steer clear of a negative consequence.
- ___ Motivators can change over time and also as a result of life experiences.

Answer to Exercise 6-1: Characteristics of Motivation

1. You may be surprised to learn that the first statement is false. The idea that leaders motivate others is a popular misconception. All of us are primarily self-motivated. Good leaders are those that create an environment that allows people to realize what motivates them.

2. The second statement is also false. This is another popular misconception. Money is a motivator for some but not for all. Indeed, different things do motivate different people. Leaders make a grave mistake when they assume there is a fixed set of motivators that all people respond to.
3. This statement is true. This is one of the reasons leaders need to be flexible and try different motivators.
4. How many times have you been motivated to pursue something of value and the next day motivated to avoid a bad outcome? Motivation includes both doing something to achieve a positive result as well as avoiding something to steer clear of a negative consequence. This statement is true.
5. The last statement is also true. The things that motivate us can change over time as well as a result of life experiences. A recent college graduate told me, “When I was in school I was highly motivated to be a top student—lots of ambition. I thought I would have the same motivation for a career. But as I get older, the more I am more motivated by the challenge of being a good father.”

Motivation can be internal or external, that is, intrinsic or extrinsic drivers impel us to do what we do. Extrinsic drivers are above the surface, tangible, and visible. Intrinsic drivers lie somewhere below the surface and are much stronger motivators because they come from within. Both are derived from a person’s core values—what makes us tick. Look at Exhibit 6–1, which illustrates the relationship among intrinsic motivators, extrinsic motivators, and core values.

E**Exhibit 6–1****Three Levels of Motivation Within an Individual**

WHAT MOTIVATES EMPLOYEES

Understanding what motivates people begins by understanding human needs. Abraham Maslow assumed that people are motivated to satisfy various needs and that these needs are arranged in a hierarchy of importance. At the bottom are physiological needs, basic survival needs such as air and food. Next are safety needs, for a secure physical and emotional environment. They include adequate clothing and housing and the need to be free from worry about money and job security. The workplace motivator: enough money to live on. Next are belongingness needs, which are related to social processes. They include love, affection, and the need to be accepted by one's peers. The workplace motivator: community needs; working in good faith with others toward a common purpose; enjoying the feeling of camaraderie.

Next to the top of the hierarchy are esteem needs, which include the need for a positive self-image and self-respect as well as the need for recognition and respect from others. The workplace motivator: having work we care about, work that makes a difference and fulfills us. Finally at the top we have self-actualization needs, which involve realizing one's potential for continued growth. The workplace motivator: having input regarding important issues; being a "player" in some of the big decisions in an organization.

Let's translate Maslow's hierarchy into what motivates people in the workplace by using an illustrative example.

Example of What Motivates Employees

The following is Akim's exit interview given to Jack by the human resource manager. Akim, who was one of Jack's most valued team members, left to join a competitor.

"I came to this organization because the technology you are developing is cutting edge. Initially, I worked on exciting projects and, even from the first week, I had a say in which projects I was assigned to. But as we got busier, that began to change. Jack seemed too busy to pay attention to little things. We were under pressure and projects were delegated without regard as to whether they represented opportunities to learn. I talked with Jack about this for several months but nothing changed. I put in a lot of overtime; it's important for me to meet my commitments and I did that. But even when we got caught up and the pressure eased, projects were still assigned at random. We never went back to talking about our interests and being allowed to choose projects where we could be exposed to new technology.

"What really made me decide to leave was the reassignment of three technology development projects to another group. I understand this was not Jack's decision but we didn't hear it from him directly. I heard it through the grapevine, and then some of my peers heard the same rumor. It was only when we asked Jack that he told us it was true. We would have understood if he had told us directly but he said, 'I didn't realize how much it mattered—there will be other projects.' This was very demotivating for all of us.

I am getting more money in my new job but that really was not the deciding factor. I'm leaving because I want to work at a place that I thought

was true of this company—a place where I can make a contribution and have input into the work I do. I don't see an opportunity to make a difference here.

I am grateful for what I learned. I am sure it will help me in my new job.”

Understanding Akim's Motivators

To understand what motivated Akim to leave, begin by thinking about the interview and reviewing the six most common workplace motivators:

1. **Meaning:** being able to do work we care about, work that makes a difference and that is fulfilling.
2. **Dignity:** maintaining self-respect and the respect of others for who we are and what we contribute.
3. **Community Needs:** working in good faith with others toward a common purpose; enjoying the feeling of “belonging” and camaraderie.
4. **Influence:** having input regarding important issues in the organization; influence for some means being trusted with more autonomy.
5. **Growth:** having the opportunity to learn, to be challenged, and to develop professionally in a supportive environment.
6. **Safety/Security:** having enough money and other resources to live without fear of endangered survival or physical well being.

Exercise 6–2: Key Motivators for Akim

Instructions: Using the preceding list, select two key motivators for Akim. Identify the real, underlying reasons that he decided to leave Jack's team.

1. _____

2. _____

Answer to Exercise 6–2: Key Motivators for Akim

Akim left the organization because he is motivated by Meaning, the opportunity to do work that is important, and also by Growth, having the opportunity to learn. You might have selected Influence, which is also important to Akim. He believes his new job will meet these needs.

Coaching and Motivation

Successful organizations are those that are the most adept at attracting and retaining talented employees. This challenge is even greater because of changes in the composition, expectations, and working arrangements of today's workforce. As the competition for high quality employees intensifies, leaders are responsible for creating a climate that keeps employees motivated, engaged, and performing their best. Most experts believe that managers have the most critical role in keeping employees motivated. That's

where coaching comes in. Coaching enables employees to meet their needs to contribute, learn, team, influence, or grow. As you build a relationship with coachees, you will understand what motivates them and use coaching to address these needs. Remember that motivation changes throughout an employee's lifecycle with the organization. Strong coaches maintain an awareness of these changing motivational needs.

Let's transition from an understanding of general motivators to specific employee expectations. We begin by considering why employees have left your organization.

BASELINE EXPECTATIONS OF ALL EMPLOYEES

Effective leaders understand the baseline expectations of employees. Research indicates there are a few critical reasons why talented employees leave an organization. I call them baseline expectations. That means that if they are not met, you are likely to experience turnover. As you read these, note the relationship among the baseline expectations, Maslow's hierarchy of needs, and the workplace motivators.

- **Job Security.** Employees need to have a sense that their work will be ongoing and not worry about self-survival. This is the most basic need in Maslow's hierarchy. For employees, it is essential that they feel secure working for your company and work unit.
- **Emotional Safety.** Employees need to work in an environment that is supportive, nonthreatening or coercive. Maslow's model doesn't specifically identify the importance of emotional safety but it is also a part of security needs.
- **Acceptance by Others:** Employees need to feel that they belong to a group or team, and that they are accepted by the team.
- **Active Participation:** Employees need to feel they influence the activities and decisions of the group and that they are making a contribution that is valued.
- **Good Relationship with Manager:** Employees need to feel that their manager is positively motivated on the individual's behalf.
- **Feelings of Personal Competence:** Employees need to feel validation on the part of the manager and peers of the individual's worth, skills, and abilities.
- **Fulfilling Potential:** Employees need to feel that the work they are doing is meaningful and that it enables them to achieve all they are capable of achieving.

Exercise 6-3: Identifying Motivators

Instructions: Think about your team. It is critical that you know why your best employees sometimes leave and go to work for someone else. Answer the following questions. As we go through the next topics, you may want to return

to this analysis. Subsequent material will help you understand how to deal with the issues that have caused turnover.

- How many employees have you lost over the past three years? _____

- Estimate how many of these employees:
 - had less than one year of service _____
 - had less than five years of service _____
 - had five to ten years of service _____
 - had more than ten years of service _____
- For each group, list the top one to three reasons for departure. Refer to the list of baseline expectations in the previous section and to the list of common workplace motivators.
 - Less than one year of service

 - Less than five years of service

 - Five to ten years of service

 - More than ten years of service

Look at the reasons you listed for each group. Are there any patterns or common themes. For example, are the same reasons listed for more than two employee groups? List any common themes below:

Now, let’s link motivation and coaching directly. In order to coach for high motivation and retention, you need to understand your team in detail. That means understanding each team member on a person-by-person basis. It is this understanding that enables you to use a motivational coaching strategy. Your first step is to examine the generational demographics of your workforce.

UNDERSTANDING THE DEMOGRAPHICS OF YOUR WORKFORCE

Today’s workforce is primarily composed of three demographic groups: Baby Boomers, Generation X (Gen X), and Generation Y (Gen Y), sometimes called Millennials. There are also a few older employees who belong to the Silent Generation. Research shows that retention challenges can best be understood along generational lines. For example, the Gen Xers and Gen Yers are more apt to change jobs with greater frequency than Baby Boomers. Each of these employee groups has distinctive features, preferences, and motivators that affect their loyalty. Remember that today, employee loyalty requires making a strong connection between the individual and his or her work. Organizations must abandon a one-size-fits-all approach to retention and design a strategy that recognizes the unique motivational needs of each employee group.

Let’s do an exercise that helps you identify each group’s major characteristics.

 Exercise 6–4: Whom Do You Want on the Project Team?

Instructions: You are one of three people leading a major project. Four people have been proposed to you as possible team members. You know you won’t get all four so it is important that you rank order your choices.

Read the description of each of the four individuals in Exhibit 6–2 and rank them from 1 to 4, using a rating of 1 for the person you most want on the team and 4 for the one you want least.

List the reasons for your ranking. You will have a little information about each of these individuals to help you make your decision.

Rank	Name	Reason for Ranking

**Exhibit 6–2****List of Employees**

Name	Here's What You Know
Anne	• 64 years old • values loyalty, doing things right, and “American values” • likes strong leadership; long-time employee
Ken	• 46 years old • values proven performance, getting the job done and flexibility • likes being part of a team; feels others should pay their dues
Abby	• 32 years old • values independence, finding new ways to work and innovative technology solutions • likes to be recognized for her contribution
Gary	• 26 years old • values social responsibility, getting ahead and power of positive thinking; wants to be treated as part of the team • likes quick answers and lots of feedback

COACHING THE MULTIGENERATIONAL WORKFORCE

Take a look at the four groups listed below. The percentage represents the proportion of each group in the workforce today.

- | | | |
|---------------------|-----|--------|
| • Silent Generation | 10% | [Anne] |
| • Baby Boomers | 45% | [Ken] |
| • Gen Xers | 30% | [Abby] |
| • Gen Yers | 15% | [Gary] |

Description of Each Group

The Silent Generation

These employees were born before 1946. They like a hierarchical environment. After years of working under command and control management, these employees are patient and tend to wait for promotion, climbing the ladder slowly, deliberately, a step at a time. Silents often have difficulty adjusting to the changes in the workplace, including the emergence of collaborative, networked structures, technology-based communication, and frequent change.

Baby Boomers

These individuals were born between 1946 and 1964. They have “paid their dues” and climbed the ladder under the old rules. They find themselves fighting to remain loyal amidst constant downsizing, restructuring, and reengineering. These individuals pride themselves on their ability to survive

but fewer today are willing to keep up the frenetic pace. Boomer women led the charge for workplace flexibility, and now many Boomers have caught on to the free-agent mindset. Boomer work ethic is one that values a personal sense of worth. They believe in hard work, as evidenced by putting in lots of hours. These workers also value a more democratic feel in the workplace and responded well to the emphasis on more participative and inclusive workplaces. Boomers have a strong desire to get ahead and make a difference by their work. These employees often view their work group as their social group and their relationships with their peers is very important. This generation of workers was the first to emphasize social activities in the workplace.

Generation X

Gen Xers were born between 1965 and 1977. They are growing up and moving into positions of leadership. They form the vanguard of the free-agent workforce. Free agency means individuals have more loyalty to themselves and their careers than to their employers. These employees are cautious and know their security rests in staying on the cutting edge. Xers are willing to sidestep rules to get things done faster, better, and smarter.

Generation Y

Gen Yers were born between 1978 and 1986. These individuals came of age during the most expansive economy in the last thirty years. They are the first truly global citizens. They are socially conscious and volunteer-minded. These employees are poised to be the most demanding in history.

Cuspers

They are sometimes called “Tweeners” because they are born within three years of the end of a generation and often resemble the previous or next generation, more so than the one in which they were born.

In general, individuals born after 1962 exhibit a number of changes in their workplace attitudes and behaviors. For example, prior generations were more apt to put up with a supervisor and working conditions they didn’t like because of loyalty. Patience and sacrifice were valued. But newer generations of workers are not willing to endure a poor boss and will quickly leave the organization in search of a better person to work for. They want to be able to identify with their manager, and must feel that this individual is a leader who is worth following. In fact, they want to be able to make an emotional connection with their boss. That’s because these workers search for mentors and role models. In addition, Gen X and Gen Y employees generate emotional connections elsewhere than the job.

Thus, employee retention requires distinguishing between these generations of workers and their different perceptions of the workplace. Now let’s think about what makes each group of workers stay.

 Exercise 6–5: What Makes Them Stay?

Think about the challenges you have faced in your company in retaining each generation of workers.

1. What do you find is important to each generation, that is, what organizational factors and practices tend to influence them to stay with your organization?

Silents

Baby Boomers

Generation Y

Generation X

2. Are there organizational factors or practices in your company that tend to be important to all groups, regardless of the generation to which they belong?

Coaching Each Generation of Workers

You must realize that these generational differences impact how you coach each group of workers. Good coaches are those to whom all generations of workers want to be loyal. You have taken the first step by identifying what is important to each generational group. The next is to determine what your employees want in their future and how you can use your coaching to help them attain their goals. Every generation values a coach who is invested in helping make them successful. The following checklist provides coaching strategies for each generation of workers.

Remember that employees who stay three years are apt to stay much longer. That's why coaching needs to begin as soon as individuals are hired and throughout the employment life cycle. Coaching leads to satisfaction and engagement. Even when job satisfaction is low, employees who are

engaged because of a strong relationship between the manager and the employee exhibit high retention.

Silents. When coaching Silents, use coaching conversations to:

- _____ Build an understanding of how things are done.
- _____ Help them understand that processes and systems are sound.
- _____ Offer feedback and recognition to praise them for hard work and dedication.

Boomers. When coaching Boomers, use coaching conversations to:

- _____ Help them understand strategic goals and the big picture.
- _____ Provide the structure they desire in work assignments and tasks.
- _____ Lay out well-planned work assignments and projects.
- _____ Help the individual execute responsibilities effectively.
- _____ Clearly define requirements for attaining rewards.
- _____ Embed organizational culture, that is, norms and values.
- _____ Build skills and capabilities.
- _____ Help them understand change from a strategic perspective.
- _____ Motivate through positive and accurate feedback.

Gen Xers. When coaching Generation Xers, use coaching conversations to:

- _____ Help them strengthen their careers.
- _____ Strategize ways to provide flexible work assignments and schedules and set appropriate boundaries.
- _____ Discuss how to provide challenging work that uses skills to the fullest.
- _____ Provide quick recognition of talents and contribution.
- _____ Discuss desire for quick advancement and help the individual continue to advance, either upward or laterally, by mastering new skills.
- _____ Discuss personal development options and opportunities.
- _____ Recognize the individual's contribution and talk about what he/she has achieved.
- _____ Talk about how to align the organization's values with personal values.
- _____ Discuss "what's in it for me" in order to motivate stronger commitment and loyalty.
- _____ Explore the importance of work/life balance.

Gen Yers. When coaching Gen Yers, use coaching conversations to:

- _____ Motivate through lots of coaching.
- _____ Discuss how to take advantage of their technical savvy.
- _____ Provide instantaneous feedback.
- _____ Talk about which rules are important and which ones are optional.
- _____ Treat as colleagues and talk to them as adults.

 Exercise 6–6: Coaching Your Workforce

Instructions: Select two to three employees, each from a different generation. Refer to the coaching strategies in the preceding section and identify at least two ideas you can use to coach each person.

Employee #1 Name _____

Generation: _____

Employee #2 Name _____

Generation: _____

Employee #3 Name _____

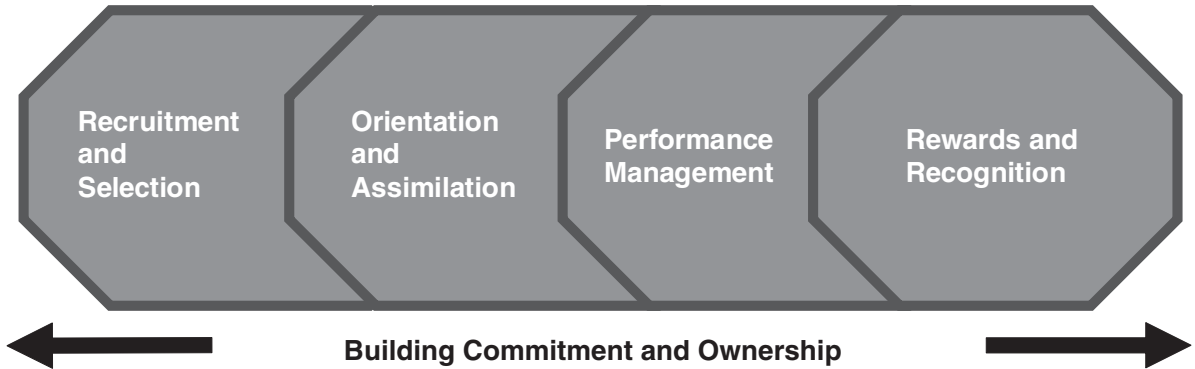
Generation: _____

THE EMPLOYMENT LIFE CYCLE

The most important relationship employees have is with their manager. Studies show that even when work conditions are less than ideal, employees stay with an organization if they have a good relationship with the manager. The employment life cycle encompasses the individual's tenure with an organization. It starts with the decision to join an organization and, in instances of high retention, ends with a committed, long-term, and satisfying relationship. Exhibit 6–3 depicts the employment life cycle.

Coaching Throughout the Lifecycle

In Chapter 1 you learned that 55 percent of U.S. employees often think of quitting or plan to quit within a given year. In fact, many begin considering changing jobs within the first 90 days of employment. That's why you have to accept that your role in building commitment begins the day the individual is hired. Once you hire someone, coaching begins. What can you do at three critical stages of the employment life cycle to motivate loyalty, engagement, and satisfaction? The following section will give you lots of ideas.

**Exhibit 6-3****Employment Life Cycle****Recruitment and Selection**

The human resources department usually leads recruitment and selection. In other instances, your manager may take the lead responsibility in hiring new employees. However, it is important for you to be actively involved in the screening process. Though it is appropriate for human resources to do the initial screening, once the final selection process is underway, the relationship building process begins. For these candidates, the interview process is also a coaching opportunity, in which you can:

- Talk with prospective employees about how you lead, the norms of your workgroup, your expectations, and similar things. The individual will have an opportunity to evaluate the extent to which you and the work group are a good fit.
- Get the team involved in the interview process. Make sure this is a private conversation between members of your team and the candidate, without you and human resources. Encourage your employees to be candid about what it is like to work in your organization and to talk about how you lead. Candidates value this type of peer-to-peer discussion.

Remember that those who work for you, for example as supervisors or team leaders, are also in a position to hire people. Make sure these individuals are intimately involved in the final interview process. Younger employees develop loyalty to the person for whom they work; even if you and the employee get along, retention will be difficult if the individual does not have a good relationship with his or her immediate supervisor.

Orientation and Acclimation

Similar to recruiting, orientation activities are usually led by the human resource department. But that's only one part of getting employees acclimated. For maximum effect on retention, you want to get personally involved in the acclimation process. Use coaching to help employees feel like a part of your team during the first few weeks of employment. Coaching activities can be used to:

- Clarify the person's role and the roles of the other team members.
- Talk about company and department policies and procedures, particularly those that are most important to the individual.
- Consider assigning a buddy to provide peer guidance and coaching.
- Talk about team dynamics, helping the new employee get to know how the group works together.
- Provide insight into how your department works with other departments. This may have been discussed during the interview but you want to coach the individual and make sure he or she knows what's important to know early in their employment.

Performance Management

How you manage performance is vital to employee satisfaction. When employees develop concerns within the first 90 days of employment it's usually related to performance expectations. Alexis described her experience by saying, "I felt my boss' expectations were unrealistically high. I was on the job 60 days and was expected to know what all the acronyms meant, get up to speed on a couple of large projects I inherited from my predecessor, and supervise two junior installation specialists. I was overwhelmed and demotivated." Here is how you can use coaching to avoid the problems Alexis and others experience and keep motivation high:

- Talk about job responsibilities and clarify performance expectations.
- Establish specific goals. Employees need to know what is most important and where to focus their energies. Make sure the goals are realistic to ensure the greatest possibility for early success. This is confidence building. You want to reaffirm that you are available to coach any time the individual needs it.
- Set more challenging goals as the employee achieves the initial ones. Use coaching sessions to brainstorm goals that are meaningful and rewarding. Remember that prolonged repetition of the same tasks leads to boredom; people start looking for more exciting opportunities—often outside your organization.
- Conduct the first appraisal after 30 days of employment. This is your opportunity to give critical feedback. Most employees say that they want more feedback rather than less. The first discussion should focus on coaching for mastering the job, and pointing out any gaps in desired and actual performance. Also check to see how the employee is feeling and solicit his/her feedback.

- Include discussion about growth and development in subsequent performance coaching. As a coach, think about opportunities that are specific to each individual. Present growth opportunities in a way that maximizes the likelihood that the employee will be excited and eager to take advantage of them.

Rewards and Recognition

Recognition plays an important role in retaining the best employees. So often, managers think about formal recognition programs that provide big rewards and lots of visible recognition. Although this is important, you can do a lot in one-on-one coaching to motivate employee retention through recognition. Consider using your coaching to:

- Discuss specific contributions the individual has made. Many employees value the personal words from their manager-coach more than formal rewards.
- Pass along praise you have received from others. This provides an opportunity to reinforce the attributes others have observed.
- Find out what people find rewarding. As described when we talked about motivators, each person is different. Coaching discussions are an opportunity to probe what you can do to recognize good performance in a way that the individual values most.

Prospective employees form opinions about whether they would consider working for your organization before you consider them as candidates for employment.

It is critical to attract and select the right people to help ensure strong loyalty, prevent turnover, and help employees make an immediate and positive contribution to the organization. Coaching initiates the commitment building process, starting on the first day of employment and continuing throughout the tenure with the organization.



Motivation is derived from the word *motive*, which means an emotion, desire, need, or similar impulse that causes one to act in a particular way. The key workplace motivators are meaning, dignity, community needs, influence, growth, and safety and security.

Effective leaders understand the baseline expectations of employees. Research indicates there are a few critical reasons why talented employees leave an organization. These are baseline expectations. That means that if they are not met, you are likely to experience turnover. As you read these, note the relationship among the baseline expectations, Maslow's hierarchy of needs, and the workplace motivators.

As a coach you must understand the demographic composition of your organization's workforce and realize that generational differences impact how you coach each group of workers. Good coaches can inspire loyalty from all generations of workers. Your first step is to identify what is important to each generational group. The next step is to determine what your employees want in their future and how you can use your coaching to help them attain their goals. Every generation values a coach who is invested in helping make them successful.

Remember that employees who stay three years are apt to stay much longer. That's why coaching needs to begin as soon as individuals are hired and throughout the employment life cycle. Coaching leads to satisfaction because it creates a strong relationship between the manager and the employee, as nothing else does. Studies show that even when work conditions are less than ideal, employees stay with an organization if they have a good relationship with their manager. The employment life cycle encompasses the individual's tenure with an organization. It starts with the decision to join an organization and, in instances of high retention, ends with a committed, long-term, and satisfying relationship.

Over half of all U.S. employees often think of quitting or plan to quit within the first year of employment. That's why you have to accept that your role in building commitment begins the day an individual is hired. Once you hire someone, coaching begins. Your coaching helps orient and assimilate, manage performance, and reward and recognize good performance.



Review Questions

1. The most important relationship an employee has is with his or her: 1. (c)
 - (a) internal customers.
 - (b) external customers.
 - (c) manager.
 - (d) fellow team members.

2. One of the characteristics of motivation is that: 2. (b)
 - (a) all people are motivated by money and prestige.
 - (b) people are primarily self-motivated.
 - (c) leaders must find ways to motivate people.
 - (d) Motivations tend to remain constant throughout our lifespan.

3. A baseline expectation of all employees is: 3. (a)
 - (a) emotional safety.
 - (b) physical comfort.
 - (c) high paying jobs.
 - (d) working for the same manager.

4. It is important to understand the demographics of your workforce because: 4. (c)
 - (a) they change the longer employees work for you.
 - (b) unless you understand them, open communication is difficult.
 - (c) each generational group responds to different motivators.
 - (d) each generational group is more like the previous one in terms of motivators.

5. As a coach, you can help orient and assimilate new employees by: 5. (c)
 - (a) extending the interview process until you are sure you have the right person.
 - (b) overseeing what human resources does to orient the person.
 - (c) clarifying the person's role and the roles of other team members.
 - (d) letting the person find his/her way but being available for question.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
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or email at ed_svcs@amanet.org.



Coaching Teams for High Performance



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Execute the role of a team coach for shared leadership.
- Coach virtual teams from long distance.
- Coach teams to make continuous improvements.
- Use coaching to help teams learn from and recover from failure.
- Implement a peer coaching process.

In Chapter 2 we discussed the role of the coach. In this chapter we examine the role of the team coach. I use the term “team coach” to describe the role of managers, supervisors, or team leaders in coaching their teams for high performance. We look first at the key responsibilities. Then we explore how to know when you are doing a good job coaching for shared leadership.

Let’s talk first about the concept of shared leadership. The term “shared leadership” as applied to teams emerged in the 1980s. It contrasts with directive, or command and control leadership, in which leadership resides exclusively with those at the top of the organization. With the emergence of team-based organizations, it became clear that shared leadership was essential if teams were to fulfill their full potential and deliver maximum value to the organization. When teams share leadership, they assume decision making authority and joint responsibility for the team’s results.

The idea of shared leadership is based on mutual respect, strong capabilities, and collaborative processes. Teams evolve into shared leadership; leaders who intentionally model certain competencies help teams develop the skills required.

THE ROLE OF THE TEAM COACH

What can a coach do to develop shared leadership skills? The following is a list of ten responsibilities of a team coach. As a coach, you use your coaching skills to:

- Facilitate collaborative team problem solving.
- Guide the team in examining possible approaches to a task.
- Teach interpersonal and teaming skills.
- Provide formal and informal feedback.
- Encourage experimentation and new approaches.
- Advise the team on how to work effectively with other teams.
- Use information to build knowledge and understanding.
- Delegate responsibility to the team to build capability.
- Review plans and provide ideas and opinions.
- Help the team agree on specific actions to be taken and clarify expected results.

Now, let's apply this list to your role. Study Exhibit 7-1, then do Exercise 7-1. Exhibit 7-1 lists the questions you need to answer to define your role as team coach. Every coaching role is somewhat unique. That's why you want to identify the roles you want to perform. Exercise 7-1 provides an opportunity to write out your answers to the questions posed in Exhibit 7-1. When you complete Exercise 7-1, you will have done a good job describing your team coaching role.

Exercise 7-1: Defining Your Team Coaching Role

1. Help the team set and achieve goals

What goals do you want to work with the team to establish?

What milestones will you use to measure progress?

How will you coach the team to achieve these goals?



Exhibit 7-1

Thinking Through Your Team Coaching Role

1. Help the team set and achieve goals

What goals do you want to work with the team to establish?

What milestones will you use to measure progress?

How will you coach the team to achieve these goals?

How will you involve the team in achieving these goals?

2. Determine what training is needed to build team skills

What do team members need to learn?

What is the best way to help the team master these skills through coaching?

What skills need to be learned immediately, which over the next year, etc.

3. Help build team relationships

What specific things will you do to build team relationships?

Which relational and interpersonal skills will be the focus of your coaching?

4. Motivate shared leadership

How will you recognize and reward shared leadership?

Are there changes in processes, procedures, or work methods that will facilitate shared leadership?

How will you coach the team to encourage shared leadership?

5. Monitor performance

How will you know when the team is doing what you want it to do?

How often will you check in and what method will you use?

As you gradually increase team responsibility, what will you look for to confirm the team has mastered specific tasks?

6. Provide feedback

How will you let the team know how it is doing?

When will you begin using peer feedback?

How will you involve the team in achieving these goals?

2. Determine what training is needed to build team skills

What do team members need to learn?

What is the best way to help the team master these skills through coaching?

What skills need to be learned immediately, which over the next year, etc.

3. Help build team relationships

What specific things will you do to build team relationships?

Which relational and interpersonal skills will be the focus of your coaching?

4. Motivate shared leadership

How will you recognize and reward shared leadership?

Are there changes in processes, procedures, or work methods that will facilitate shared leadership?

How will you coach the team to encourage shared leadership?

5. Monitor performance

How will you know when the team is doing what you want it to do?

How often will you check in and what method will you use?

As you gradually increase team responsibility, what will you look for to confirm the team has mastered specific tasks?

Let's take this a step further. In a busy workplace, sometimes coaches abandon their coaching role in a way that undermines shared leadership. A friend of mine was coaching a facilities maintenance team. Carlos said, "I found myself taking on tasks I had delegated to the team. Sometimes I was letting the team find its own way, sometimes I was too involved. The result was a mixed message that confused the team." Here is a list of warning signs you need to be aware of as you coach for shared leadership. They indicate you have stepped out of the coaching role and have moved into a hierarchical leadership mode.

- You find you are talking more than listening. If this is happening, you are directing the team.
- You are making most of the decisions, even those the team is capable of making.
- All communication is flowing through you; step back and think about why. Coaches who encourage shared leadership encourage and facilitate peer-to-peer communication.
- You seek credit for the results the team has produced. Shared leadership means sharing the credit and the kudos. The more leadership the team successfully assumes, the more credit you want to give them.

- You find yourself delegating tasks but continuing to be involved in the work. When you do this, you are still in a day-to-day management role.
- The team doesn't know what to do and you find they are coming to you for the answer. As you transfer responsibility to the team, it is natural that they will have questions. But if this continues, you need to ask more facilitative questions that encourage them to figure out what to do.
- You are resolving all the conflicts and differences of opinion. In these situations it is important to encourage peers to talk and work out their differences, interceding only if they cannot resolve the issues. Your coaching needs to focus on teaching people how to work through interpersonal issues and use them as a learning opportunity.

Exercise 7–2: How Are You Doing?

Instructions: We have just examined how to determine whether you are really coaching for shared leadership. Reread the seven statements and answer the following questions.

1. Which of the seven warning signs are problems for you? Select one or two.

2. What can you do to move from a directive or managerial role to more of a team coach?

3. What type of feedback will you seek from the team to assess the extent to which you are facilitating shared leadership?

Coaching for shared leadership enhances your ability to retain high-quality workers. Teams that are capable of taking on leadership tasks don't emerge after a few coaching sessions. Effective coaches that engage and empower them build them.

COACHING LONG DISTANCE

Exhibit 7-2 shows representative comments from Eric's team. Eric is DataPoint's Marketing Manager. DataPoint provides sophisticated marketing services for a variety of clients. It does market research and analysis, develops client-specific marketing strategies, and helps clients launch new products by managing trade show activities and creating promotional materials. Eric had just put together a worldwide marketing team. I was working with him to design their first planning meeting. He wanted to get his fifteen key managers together to do this.

As we were planning the meeting, I said, "One of the challenges you'll have once the team is up and running is how to coach it. We're getting together as a group in three weeks, but that won't happen again—not for at least a year."

Managers like Eric are more and more common. They are leading teams that are geographically dispersed. That's why they're called virtual teams. They work in different offices, at some distance from one another, and communicate through conferencing, e-mail and by telephone. They rarely meet face-to-face.

E

Exhibit 7-2

Global Teaming

"Global teaming has to be done. We've got to find a way to pull in the expertise of people in Europe and the Far East. It's the only way we're going to get a handle on those customers' needs. There's no way somebody in London can understand the expectations of our Singapore customers. You've got to spend time with them on their home turf."

—Senior Account Representative/London

"Managing the logistics alone is a nightmare. We've got to get promotional material ready for tradeshow that begin in Seattle and end in Singapore. But our competition this year is fierce. We've got to demonstrate that we can really help our clients get their products to the marketplace fast. I can't do it from our Seattle headquarters—I've got to have the cooperation of my counterparts around the world."

—Marketing Communications Supervisor/Seattle

"It's clear that global project teams are the future of our business. Domestically, when we want to get the best solution, we give it to a team. On a bigger scale, it's no different. We're a marketing-driven company. Eric's marketing team is a model for how we've got to run this company, teaming around the world to get the highest quality services to our clients."

—Human Resources Manager/Seattle

Think about Eric's situation for a minute. What are two or three challenges he will face in coaching the team? List your answers below:

Building a virtual team requires the same type of activities as building an onsite team. You have to agree on goals, develop collaborative processes, communicate effectively, solve problems, etc. All these activities require effective coaching. Eric and managers in similar situations need to:

- Set up periodic face-to-face meetings, using the time together for maximum effect, including coaching. An information technology director I know schedules a face-to-face meeting twice a year for his virtual team. Team members assemble from California, Minnesota, and Florida. He uses these meetings to coach the team about joint goals, process improvements, and high priority issues. Similarly, he engages them in problem solving, coaching them in a way that encourages new solutions.
- Talk with the team early on about how you will handle your coaching responsibility. Let them know which issues you will coach as a team and which ones you will handle on a one-on-one basis. For example, Rebecca talked with me about how she does this. She said, "Most coaching sessions are progress updates that we do by audio or video conferencing. The call lasts about 15–20 minutes. I start off by restating goals and agreed upon actions and then check to see how we're doing. I spend most of the time talking about issues where help is needed, and coach the team through each of them. If things are going well and further coaching is not required at this point, we end the call. If further coaching is required I set up a follow-up call, not necessarily with the whole team, but with those who need the help."
- Deal with performance issues face-to-face. Sometimes this is difficult. One advertising executive said, "I have creative teams working in five states and three across Europe. When a team is struggling and I need to get involved, I start off coaching over the phone. Sometimes that is enough to get things on track. If not, I schedule a personal meeting. I hate to lose people, so I do everything I can to salvage the situation. One rule of thumb—you can't really do in-depth coaching over the phone. You've got to be eye-to-eye."
- Use e-mail to communicate effectively with virtual teams. E-mail etiquette dictates that messages should be brief, condensed, and informal. Avoid long-winded messages and defer complex matters for face-to-face communication.

COACHING FOR CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

Team leaders who encourage continuous improvement help their teams achieve full potential. As one team leader said, “I’ll need to be even more of a coach in the future. My coaching efforts will focus on giving my team what it needs in order to continuously improve performance results. The tougher the challenges, the more coaching I’ll need to do.”

How can you help a team progress from conversations about improvements to making continuous improvement a way of life? Zack’s logistics support team took on this challenge. Like many others, he used a simple process to move his team from doing what’s expected to making continuous improvement a way of life. Here’s what they did.

Step 1: Initiate Discussion

Zack’s first step was to initiate discussion about improving his team’s services. That means talking about the benefits of doing things better, safer, faster, cheaper, or more productively. Initiating this dialogue raises the team’s awareness and reveals what’s possible. Zack observed, “You have to realize that when you start this discussion, you have team members who have already been thinking about how to improve things but may be reluctant to share them with you and fellow team members.” As you open up communication, you will find that most of the ideas come from the team. In your role as a coach you need to:

- Describe strategic challenges so the team understands what the organization needs to achieve.
- Encourage the group to look for small improvements and set modest goals.
- Initiate discussion of problems so the team can decide what action to take.
- Talk about how others view their work and what customers expect.
- Listen carefully to employees’ ideas and focus on understanding what’s causing frustrations, blocking productivity, or undermining effectiveness.
- Discuss what role each person will play in working to meet the improvement goal.

Step 2: Pursue Improvement Goals

Zack talked a lot about this step. “Once the team starts working on the improvement goal, you will do a lot of coaching. Working together to solve a problem or upgrade a work process presents new challenges.” As a coach, you need to:

- Make sure the team has good plans in place to support the improvement effort.
- Use coaching opportunities to build interpersonal skills, especially communication skills.
- Facilitate team discussions in a way that encourages different perspectives and new ideas.
- Point out small wins that occur as the team makes progress in achieving the goal.

Step 3: Pursue More Significant Improvements

A human resources team set an ambitious goal: linking its human resource strategy to business needs. As the senior vice president of human resources said, “We wanted to ensure that our major HR activities were really contributing to the business. We worked with managers across the organization. Our organization is pursuing an aggressive strategy of growth through innovation. By continuously working to improve our services and processes, we will really be delivering what the organization needs.”

This team is an example of what happens when Step 3 is mastered. Teams strive for more significant improvements and breakthroughs often occur. They stretch and take on more challenging goals, each of which impacts the business in increasingly important ways. The HR team revolutionized the organization’s approach to human resources. As one senior manager said, “Human resource activities became more strategic. Rather than working in parallel, HR became a business partner. It was a turning point for the function and, in some way, for the entire organization.”

To coach your team through Step 3:

- Make sure the team’s more aggressive goals will not only impact the organization’s competitiveness but also be realistic. Good coaches don’t let the team take on more than it is ready to do.
- Help the team identify obstacles and brainstorm ways to overcome them.
- Recognize that sometimes teams resist moving to Step 3. Complacency is a danger all good team coaches are sensitive to. If this happens, talk with the team about the major gains to the organization, to the team, and to individual competence. Your support is critical, including talking about how you will coach the team through mistakes, problems, etc.

Step 4: Make Continuous Improvement a Way of Life

To make continuous improvement a way of life, you need to put mechanisms in place to encourage this mindset. You may also need to increase the empowerment of the team. For example, Zack’s logistics group reduced late orders from over 15 percent to 5 percent. Then it reduced the lead time needed to acquire parts and other supplies by almost 30 percent through creative breakthroughs. Here are some of the things Zack did as team coach to embed the continuous improvement mindset:

- Encourage the team to look for ways to make significant improvements and support their ideas.
- Provide examples of what other teams have done.
- Coach the team to maintain a continuous improvement mindset in all aspects of its work.
- Make sure the team learns new tools that become available to aid continuous improvement efforts.

 Exercise 7–3: Coaching for Continuous Improvement

Instructions: Think about your team. Begin by asking, “What do we need to do better, safer, faster, cheaper, or more efficiently?” Write out the improvement in the space below:

Now, list three or four things you can do to coach the team from agreeing on the improvement (Step 1) to making continuous improvement a way of life (Step 4):

1.

2.

3.

4.

DEALING WITH FAILURE

Teams that strive for continuous improvement sometimes don’t succeed. As a team coach, you have to help your team deal with failure, regain momentum, and get back on track. The way the coach handles failure makes the difference between the team’s decision to keep pursuing significant goals or deciding to play it safe. In the following example we’ll apply the five steps listed in Exhibit 7–3 to a real-life situation. This will give you a better understanding of how to use them when your team has a failure.

Example: The Failed Membership Drive

Ed couldn’t remember when he had been more disappointed. He was manager of membership development for Dallas’ Small Business Chamber of Commerce. His team of eight industry representatives committed to increase chamber membership by 15 percent. But by year end, they had only achieved 8 percent. True, a 15 percent increase in membership was an ambitious target. But the team had been excited and really felt it was doable. All its other goals, designed to improve member services and involvement in chamber activities, had been achieved. Too bad about missing the 15 percent target, Ed thought—it would have been an outstanding achievement.

The team is discouraged and Ed wants to coach them through the failure. He’s going to take them through the five-step process we just described.

E**xhibit 7–3****Dealing with Failure**

- Step 1.** *Talk with the team about what failed.* Be specific and identify the nature of the problem. Use your coaching skills, especially facilitative questioning, to help sort out what went well and what didn't.
- Step 2.** *Put the failure into perspective.* Sometimes team members exaggerate the impact of a missed goal or failed project. As the leader, use feedback and constructive advice to help put what happened in perspective. Encourage the team to examine the failure in the context of their experience, the difficulty of the goal, the nature of the error, and other factors.
- Step 3.** *Determine what can be learned from the failure.* Valuable lessons often come from mistakes. Asking questions like, "What have we learned?" or "If we were faced with a similar situation now, what would we do differently?" facilitates learning.
- Step 4.** *Help the team see the failure as an event.* Avoid making the failure personal. When failure depresses a team, everyone can feel like, "We're a failure." Leaders can use positive reinforcement and feedback to make sure the team understands this is one mistake, and not the sum total of who they are as a team.
- Step 5.** *Encourage the team to get back on track and try again.* Your support and positive reinforcement can help restore the team's confidence. Work with the team and together decide what steps it needs to take to recover from the failure.
-

 Exercise 7–4: Ed's Plan for Dealing with Failure

Instructions: The plan that Ed developed has three alternatives for how to handle each step. Circle the one that you believe Ed should use, and then we'll look at the best choices.

Step 1. *Talk with the team and identify what failed*

Ed should structure the discussion as follows:

- a. Generate a list of missed opportunities to secure new members and discuss each one.
- b. Congratulate the team on the new members who joined the chamber, then brainstorm a list of reasons why the team didn't attract more.
- c. Look at the list of new members and identify what strategies were successful in attracting them.

Step 2. *Help the team put the failure in perspective*

The best way for Ed to do this is to:

- a. Talk with the team about how ambitious the goal was and remind them that most chambers grow at about 5 to 7 percent a year.
- b. Tell them what a great job they did and then move on.
- c. Let the team know that if they don't meet their goal for the upcoming year it might be serious, but not this year.

Step 3. *Determine what can be learned from the failure*

An effective way for Ed to do this is to:

- a. Come to the meeting with a list of what he believes are the key learnings and discuss them with the team.
- b. Ask the team to brainstorm what worked well, what didn't work, and what the team could do differently next year.
- c. Ask team members to share what each of them has learned so the entire team can benefit.

Step 4. *Help the team see failure as an event and avoid making it personal*

Ed's strategy here needs to be one in which he emphasizes:

- a. The team's accomplishments for the year and points out that all its other goals were met.
- b. That they will have another chance next year to show what they can do, and might even be able to do better than 15 percent.
- c. That they're only a failure if they allow themselves to be discouraged by this setback and take a negative attitude.

Step 5. *Encourage the team to get back on track and try again*

The best way for Ed to do this is to:

- a. Talk with the team about the coming year's membership enrollment goal and jointly decide what makes sense.
- b. Talk with the team about the coming year's membership enrollment goal and set a target that he knows the team can meet.
- c. Talk with the team about the coming year's membership enrollment goal and tell them he will support whatever they decide to do.

Answer to Exercise 7–4: Ed's Plan for Dealing with Failure

Let's look at what Ed should do when the team gets together.

Step 1. When Ed talks with the team and identifies what failed, he needs to congratulate the team on the new members who joined and brainstorm a list of reasons why the team didn't attract more (b). This ensures they receive credit for the 8 percent growth they generated and explores why they were unsuccessful getting to 15 percent. Looking only at missed opportunity focuses the team on its failure. Looking at success strategies is good but it only looks at what worked, not at what didn't work.

Step 2. Ed can help the team put their failure in perspective by talking with them about how ambitious the goal was and reminding them that most chambers grow at about 5 to 7 percent a year (a). Merely congratulating them on what they achieved is not enough and telling them about the consequences of missing their goal for the upcoming year deepens their sense of failure.

Step 3. The team will get its greatest learning if it discusses what worked well, what didn't work, and what it can do differently next year (b). If Ed shares his key learnings, it does not allow everyone to use the failure as a

learning experience. Asking team members to share individual learnings can put people on the spot. Team members may feel compelled to talk about how much better they intend to do in the coming year. What's important is that the team capture its collective learnings.

Step 4. Ed needs to talk about all the team accomplished and highlight the goals that were achieved (a). Though it's true the team will have another chance next year, focusing on this increases the pressure to perform better in the future. It sends the message that the team didn't measure up this year. Encouraging the team to have a positive attitude is futile unless Ed first points out all it did accomplish.

Step 5. The team shouldn't automatically recommit to the 15 percent goal. Ed needs to talk with the team and set a goal that makes sense (a). The team needs guidance and coaching in setting the upcoming year's goal. Leaving the decision to them doesn't help the team make a sound decision. Very often, a team will self-consciously decide to go for the stretch goal without considering what's really feasible.

Exercise 7-5: Helping Your Team Deal with Failure

Instructions: Has your team had a recent failure or a near miss? Think about how you can use these five steps to help them get back on track. Use the spaces below to write out your plan.

Step 1. Talk about what failed. Be specific and identify the nature of the problem. Help the team sort out what went well and distinguish it from the failure.

Step 2. Put the failure or mistake into perspective.

Step 3. Determine what can be learned from the failure.

Step 4. Help the team see the failure as an event and avoid making it personal.

Step 5. Encourage the team to get back on track and try again.

PEER COACHING

Strong shared leadership characterizes teams that are high performing. To achieve and stay high performing, coaching is essential. Peer coaching is one way to do team coaching. Similar to peer feedback, peer coaching involves team members sharing information that enables improvement and growth.

Let's look at how peer coaching works. Stacey's team has been in existence for about three years. It is responsible for manufacturing auto parts. The group meets regularly and is doing a good job. Stacey said to me, "Positioning is important if peer coaching is going to work. The team has to be mature to do this. New teams, or teams that are still trying to meet standards, shouldn't try peer coaching yet. A team has to work together awhile, get to know one another, and build trust."

The three steps to encourage peer coaching are as follows.

- 1. Set Up Coaching Opportunities:** Peer feedback begins by asking your peer for permission to coach, for example, "I'd like to talk with you about what's happening on the project. I have some advice that I think will be helpful. May I share it with you?" Framing the request in this way provides the reason for offering to coach and lets the person know what you want to talk about. Ben, a member of Stacey's team said, "It's important that the person you want to coach has an opportunity to say 'no.' If you get a 'no,' you've got to back off. The idea is to make it clear that you are here to be of help. The more experience you have with the person the better. But the bottom line is you have to listen carefully and read the nonverbal cues to make sure the receiver is open to hearing what you have to say."
- 2. Provide Coaching:** Start with something positive, even if it is only to affirm your peer's good intentions. Most peer coaching falls into advice giving, and in some instances, teaching discussions. Like all good coaching, it should be a discussion, not a monologue. Also, focus on giving advice that is forward looking, specific, actionable, and respectful. It is important not to berate your colleague but instead do everything you can

to make sure your coaching helps ensure future success. Jamie, a senior automotive specialist, told me, “We hired someone three months ago to work with me on final inspections. He was slow and had trouble operating some of the more sophisticated equipment. I watched him for a month or so and then asked if I could provide coaching. I was very specific in the advice I gave, and told him a couple of things he could do to speed up inspections. We talked about it and I encouraged him to try my ideas. I left the door open for follow-up coaching, especially questions, and he took me up on it.”

3. **Provide Closure:** Like Jamie, end the coaching session with an offer of further assistance. Also end on a positive note. When you see someone act successfully in response to your coaching, take time to congratulate the person.

Exercise 7–6: Providing Peer Coaching

Take a moment and answer the following questions. This exercise gives you an opportunity to practice peer coaching.

1. Select someone whom you want coach. Why do you want to coach this person? How can she or he benefit from your coaching?

2. Now, write out what you plan to say.

3. What support can you offer?

Remember that it is important to be a good listener. As you provide coaching, listen carefully to understand what is being said—it will help you know what to say next. Following the basic tenets of good listening presented in Chapter 3—staying focused, understanding the message, and respecting the coachee—will help ensure that your peer coaching experience is valuable for both you and your colleague.



As a manager or team leader, it is likely you will play the role of the team coach. With the emergence of team-based organizations, it has become clear that shared leadership is essential if teams are to fulfill their potential and deliver maximum value to the organization. Coaches can do several things to develop shared leadership, including facilitating collaborative problem solving, teaching teaming skills, and delegating responsibility to the team to build its capability.

Managers today frequently lead geographically dispersed teams. That means you will coach through a combination of telephone, e-mail, conferencing, and occasional face-to-face meetings. To be effective, leaders need to use face-to-face meetings to maximum effect, making sure the first coaching session is in person and keeping telephone coaching direct and to the point.

Team leaders who encourage continuous improvement help their teams achieve their full potential. You can use a four-step process to do this: Step 1, talk about improvements; Step 2, work together to reach the goal; Step 3, help improvements accelerate; and Step 4, promote continuous improvement as a way of life.

Teams that strive for continuous improvement sometimes don't succeed. As a team leader you have to help your team deal with failure, regain momentum, and get back on track. The way the leader handles failure makes the difference between the team's decision to keep pursuing significant goals or deciding to play it safe. A simple five-step process can help you coach your team and help it recover and learn from failure.

Peer coaching is one way to do team coaching. Similar to peer feedback, peer coaching involves team members sharing information that enables improvement and growth. A three-step process: setting up the coaching opportunities, providing coaching, and closing the discussion can be used to conduct peer coaching sessions.



Review Questions

1. The first step in dealing with a team failure is to: 1. (d)
 - (a) make sure the team members see failure as an isolated event and don't personalize it.
 - (b) figure out what can be learned from the failure.
 - (c) put the failure into perspective.
 - (d) talk with the team and identify what failed.

2. To build shared leadership teams, you need to be alert to signs you are *not* coaching, including: 2. (a)
 - (a) seeking credit for the results the team has produced.
 - (b) giving too much praise and recognition for team accomplishments.
 - (c) delegating to the team things you used to do.
 - (d) involving the team in leadership decisions.

3. One of the things you need to do when you are coaching long distance is: 3. (b)
 - (a) make sure your boss is involved in coaching discussions.
 - (b) deal with individual performance issues face-to-face.
 - (c) use a lot of peer coaching.
 - (d) make sure you do not coach at all unless you can do it face-to-face.

4. When you do peer coaching, the first step is to set up the coaching opportunity. You do this by: 4. (c)
 - (a) launching into the coaching discussion as soon as you have something to say.
 - (b) keeping your coaching advice to yourself until the issue becomes critical.
 - (c) asking your peer for permission to coach.
 - (d) asking your peer if she/he thinks coaching would be helpful.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
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5. Once a team agrees what needs to be improved, team members begin to work together to reach the goal. As a coach you need to:
5. (b)
- (a) involve only the team members you believe can make a contribution.
 - (b) make sure the team has good plans in place to support the improvement effort.
 - (c) make it clear that problems that arise need to wait until the goal has been achieved.
 - (d) ask yourself if there is a need to overtime to make sure the goal is met.

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Handling Difficult Coaching Situations



Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Recognize and avoid coaching pitfalls.
- Build trust when you confront difficult coaching situations.
- Deal with the most common coaching problems.
- Coach teams through conflict.

We have spent a lot of time examining what you can do to be an effective coach. As you put these skills and techniques into practice you become a valuable coaching asset to your organization and to those you lead.

IDENTIFYING COACHING PITFALLS

It's also important to be aware of some of the common coaching traps. Some of these may be obvious, but others not. Even the most diligent and sincere coaches can fall prey to these pitfalls.

Sample Coaching Situations

Let's look at several short scenarios. See if you can identify the trap the coach has fallen into. Write your answers in the space provided.

Situation 1: Lorisa

Lorisa has been coaching each member of her team since she was promoted to desktop support supervisor. When I asked her how it was going, she just

shrugged, and said, “When I took this job last year my boss told me I was responsible for coaching my staff. So, I am doing it. . It is hard to measure the impact of my coaching but I know it is making a difference. Just putting in the time means my techs will do a better job.”

Coaching Pitfall 1

Situation 2: Paulo

Paulo described his coaching approach as “off the cuff” and “spontaneous.” In his words, “I think my employees appreciate my style. We sell advertising to a number of publications and it’s very fast-paced. So my coaching style is a lot like how we work. I don’t always cover the most important topics and sometimes it takes two or three coaching meetings to get key things on the table. But at least we get to it.”

Coaching Pitfall 2

Situation 3: Stef

Stef was frustrated. His organization had initiated an employee feedback survey. Everyone had an opportunity to give feedback about organizational practices and management effectiveness. His frustration stemmed from the feedback he received. Stef fumed, “I’m a problem solver and I’m getting poor marks from my employees because of it. When we make a mistake, or run into a problem, I jump on it. I use these as coaching opportunities and get to the bottom of the situation. Good coaches find out who is responsible even if it makes people uncomfortable.”

Coaching Pitfall 3

Situation 4: Claire

“Why do I need to spell it out any more?” Claire said. “At every team meeting I talk about how important it is to work closely with clients from the first meeting until our work is done. In fact, every architect learns that when he or she is in school. So when I coach somebody who is not doing this, they already know what’s wrong. I hire competent people and I don’t need to spell out every detail. They know what I expect and that I hold them accountable for top performance.”

Coaching Pitfall 4

Situation 5: Logan

“I’m not sure my coaching time is well spent,” Logan said. “Here’s a perfect example of what always happens. Amanda is one of my best product specialists. I am coaching her to move up to a senior specialist. We talk about lots of things but they don’t always get done. I’m not sure what’s wrong because she is as enthusiastic about the new job as I am. I just wish there were more tangible progress from coaching session to coaching session. I don’t always remember everything we committed to (neither does she) and that’s slowing us down.”

Coaching Pitfall 5

Sample Responses

Now let’s examine each situation and look at possible solutions.

Pitfall 1: Coaching Just for the Sake of Coaching

Lorisa was well intentioned. She was instructed to coach and she was! But you don’t want to coach just to be doing it. Coaching is a good habit if it is purposeful and you have good reasons to engage in it. If you’re just coaching for the sake of coaching, that will become clear. You will find that your discussion will seem perfunctory and unsatisfying for both you and the coachee. Before each coaching discussion, ask yourself, “Why am I coaching this person?” A clear purpose is essential for success. Make sure you don’t substitute coaching activity for purposeful coaching sessions. You’re much more likely to get results when your coaching is focused.

Pitfall 2: Failure to Plan the Discussion

There are times when just-in-time coaching is important. You want to seize the moment and provide timely advice, feedback, or ideas. For the most part, however, you want to plan the coaching discussion. In so doing, you avoid the problem Paulo is having. There is another benefit to planning; it ensures that the discussion is relevant. When you plan the coaching session both you and the coachee will have a sense of accomplishment.

Pitfall 3: Using Coaching to Blame Others

Stef’s mistake is a common one. In his attempt to be a problem solver, he uses coaching sessions to find out who is to blame for mistakes. Good coaches do foster a sense of accountability. They also help coachees deal with mistakes. To do this, they use coaching as opportunities for learning. Using lots of

probing and self-reflection questions, you work as a thinking partner engaging the coachee to identify different ways of approaching the situation. Spending time finding who to blame results in defensive employees and, of course, nothing has been done to solve the problem.

Pitfall 4: Assuming the Coachee Recognizes the Problem

Claire has done a good job communicating expectations. That is essential for an effective coach. But coaching is a special conversation, designed to accomplish certain things. If one or more of her employees is not meeting expectations, a specific problem needs to be addressed. It is unwise to assume a coachee recognizes the problem. In fact, even if the coachee recognizes the problem, he or she needs help solving it. Strong coaches make sure they communicate what needs to change and why.

Pitfall 5: Failure to Follow Up Coaching Discussions

Good coaching discussions end with actions that the coach follows up. That is how the coachee makes progress. When you and the coachee agree on something, or when you give a coachee an assignment, set a time for a follow-up session. Sometimes, the follow-up can be less formal. In these instances, make a note to yourself as a reminder to check on the coachee's progress. One way or another, you need to build follow-up into the coaching process.

BUILDING TRUST IN DIFFICULT SITUATIONS

In Chapter 2 we discussed how coaches build rapport with coachees. Coachees are motivated and respond to coaching in high trust environments. They believe that the coach has their best interest at heart and communication is open.

But too often when you need to coach individuals about difficult issues, trust can begin to erode. The coachee may become distrustful and even skeptical about your motives. Trust is not something that can be demanded but has to be built over a period of time. In the next section, we examine how to coach in difficult situations. Let's start by considering what a coach can do to build trust. Here are four things you need to do:

- **Be honest.** When trust is low, coachees look for inconsistencies and less than honest communication. Some even try and read between the lines in search of dishonesty. Be honest with the coachee and don't withhold information, even if it is painful. Deliver the message in a tactful manner without hurting the coachee. You want the coachee to accept your advice or feedback as well as your sincere offer of support.
- **Keep your word.** It is important that you keep agreements you make with the coachee. One manager I coached said, "I had a really tough conversation with someone I had just promoted to district supervisor. What made it difficult was the fact that the coachee didn't really agree with my assessment—he thought he was doing a pretty good job. Grudgingly he

agreed to my coaching plan. I agreed to send him to a skill-building workshop and also to partner him with an experienced district manager. These activities were not high on my priority list but they were very important to him. He became more motivated to work toward building his skills when he saw me keep my agreements.”

- **Be balanced and consistent.** Difficult coaching situations are fraught with tension. As objective as we try to be it is sometimes very difficult to remain calm and professional. Good coaches are balanced in these situations, meaning they don't exaggerate problems to make a point. They are also consistent. Trust is built when responses are predictable and consistent regardless of the pressure.
- **Retribution-free communication.** Coachees need to feel they can be honest during coaching discussions. This is never more important than when the situation is difficult. Encouraging an environment of retribution-free communication means the coachee can raise issues, express concerns, talk about fears, and voice disagreements without fear of retaliation. Fostering open communication is a sign of mutual respect—you can be candid in your comments and extend the same privilege to the coachee. Rather than increasing tension, it actually helps the coachee relax and be more ready to listen to you, as you listen to him/her.

DIFFICULT COACHING SITUATIONS

Even the best coaches have to deal with problems. Sometimes the coachee does things that undermine the effectiveness of the coaching relationship. We might call these pitfalls. Let's look at the most common problems coaches encounter.

Coachee Is Not Committed

Greg was very upset when his manager told him he had to improve his interpersonal relationships. Greg believes he is appropriately assertive but his boss advised him that others perceived him as openly aggressive and territorial. In Greg's view, his approach was integral to his success. He believes that if others were more assertive, the unit's results would be better. Greg agrees to be coached but it is clear his heart is not in it.

Why would someone like Greg resist coaching? Often, the coach has not explained the reasons for the coaching. Just advising Greg that he needs to be “less aggressive” doesn't provide a motivation for change. In fact, for someone like Greg, coaching may be perceived as punitive. Greg's boss can expect him to go through the motions without commitment to change his behavior. His boss also runs the risk that Greg may misinterpret his motives. Without explaining the context of his concerns, Greg may wonder what's behind his bosses' concern. Have others been complaining about him? Is the boss really dissatisfied or just trying to placate Greg's coworkers, etc.?

Coaching relationships can only work if the coachee is committed to it. Lack of commitment means the coachee will be half-hearted, not put forth much effort, and not work to change his or her behavior.

Unrealistic Expectations

In the best possible situations, the coach and coachee enter the relationship with high hopes. How can you tell whether the coachee's expectations are unrealistic? Take a look at Madison's situation.

"I have been working for TEC Communications for five years. I was an independent contractor and accepted a full-time position a year ago. Right now I lead a team of six engineers and when we're presenting new products to customers, I travel a lot. My manager, Kay, has advised that my team doesn't feel I do a good job communicating with them. I understand this, but frankly, we're really busy! But I agreed to have bi-monthly staff meetings with them. We have been doing this for a couple of months and I've recently learned that they are still dissatisfied. They feel they're not getting the information they need and other departments are more clued into what's happening than they are. I'm disappointed that we're not making progress. I want to move up to a district manager's job. We take time in the bi-monthly meetings for problem solving—that's an important skill for district managers. I have done everything Kay and I agreed on and I don't know why things aren't better."

What are one or two misconceptions Madison had about coaching?

1. _____

2. _____

Madison's first misconception is that her behavior—failure to communicate—would be easy to change. Making a shift in attitudes or behavior, including acquiring new skills, takes time. Second, Madison is ambitious and wants to move up in the organization. Unfortunately, she is trying to use the meetings to build her leadership skills. This is a good goal but she needs to focus on the critical behavior change—improving communication with the team. Tackling the communication issue is Madison's first priority. The coach needs to describe what it will take to change behavior. Part of expectation setting is letting the coachee know what's ahead and how much needs to change. Otherwise, like Madison, the individual underestimates what she/he needs to do.

Passive Approach

Todd described a situation that bothered him as he initiated a coaching relationship with one of his team leaders. Todd explained, “I would describe Frank’s role in the coaching process as passive. I’ve been coaching him for about three months. We started out with an understanding that when he took over the team, it was a stretch. It’s a tough team and it needs to turn around its performance. But Frank isn’t doing much. He listens to my ideas during our coaching session and typically says, ‘I’ll give it a try.’

I didn’t think too much about it at first but now I see he has got to play a more active role.”

Remember that the more active and involved an individual is in the coaching process, the more the person will get out of the coaching relationship. The coach and the coachee play an equal role in developing a productive and workable relationship. Thus, the coachee must help define areas of improvement or growth, ask the coach questions, offer ideas, etc.

Failure to Take Risks

All of us can fall into the trap of being afraid to take a risk. Change can be scary and coachees often fear failure. I can remember when I was in this position. I had just been promoted to my first full-fledged management position. I was intimidated because the people I was managing were older than I. My boss was clear that I needed to delegate more to my staff. I was reluctant; I did not have confidence in some of the people and decided it was easier to do the work myself. It seemed safer than confronting the poor performance.

Like so many other coachees, I was protective of my ego and afraid to step up to the new responsibility I had been given. But my boss was a good coach. He recognized my problem and said to me, “I think it is important for you to appear to be successful and on top of things in this new job. Frankly, I struggled with the same thing when I was put in a similar position. Let’s talk about what I did . . .” This really helped me take a step forward and stop playing it safe. It took time, but I was able to deal with the performance issues and get the team on track.

Fear of Failure

Coachees can be overwhelmed with the need for change. Facing new challenges, taking on new responsibilities, or adopting new behaviors can be daunting. When coachees are dealing with a fear of failure they don’t even try. Many times, it is the imagined *consequence* of failure that the coachee is most concerned about. What can you as a coach do? One marketing executive explained it this way. “Coaches lessen a fear of failure by stressing learning. I let my team know that I view mistakes as learning opportunities. That’s how I talk about new challenges—a chance to learn and grow, even if there are some bumps along the way.”

Dependency on the Coach

A manufacturing team leader talked with me about how difficult it was for him to get people to take the initiative. He said, “I’ve started coaching, but people wait for me to tell them what to do! My management style has always been high control but I really want to empower the team. But they’re not cooperating.” The team leader’s experience is not unique. Coaches whose leadership style is directive, that is, telling people the next step or answering all the questions, find that coachees continue to look to them for direction or solutions.

These coachees don’t see the value of coaching, because they aren’t thinking in terms of stretching their skills. A team leader in a chemical plant described what she had to do to overcome coachee dependency. “I was assigned to lead a second shift operation for two locations. I hadn’t been a very good coach. But the increased scope of responsibilities meant people could no longer come to me for all the answers. So I talked with the team about the kind of issues I would handle and how I expected them to handle issues that they were experienced enough to deal with. I also asked them to come to me with ideas about how to resolve problems rather than just asking me ‘What do I do?’ If they were slow to do this, I would just ask them for their ideas. Usually, they knew the answer. Gradually, they began to take the initiative and my coaching paid off.”

Blaming Others

Sometimes individuals blame the coach. This happens most frequently when you are coaching for improved performance. The coachee may deny or minimize problems. And sometimes the coachee believes that he/she has no control over the situation.

Whatever the reason, a defensive coachee won’t hear what the coach has to say. Resistance to input is a roadblock to change. When a coachee blames others it is difficult for the coach to understand what the coachee really needs and thus is unable to offer much help.

I remember when I was coaching Chase. He had a lot of reasons why customers were resisting his ideas. In his view, “I’m a smart guy and I think customers sometimes don’t understand what I’m saying. It’s hard for me to communicate with people who are not as technically sophisticated as I am. Is that my fault?” I had to be very honest with Chase about his strengths and limitations, and why customers didn’t like to work with him. It was a difficult discussion but he began to understand what he needed to do differently. For example, he needed to answer the questions customers asked, not tell them what he thought they needed to know. It took more than one discussion but over time, Chase began to take responsibility for building good relationships with customers.

STRATEGIES FOR DEALING WITH COMMON COACHING PROBLEMS

You can use several strategies to deal with difficult coaching situations.

- **Probe the issues more deeply.** Ask questions to determine the reasons for the behavior you are seeing. This is the first step: seeking to understand what is going on with the individual.
- **Dig below the symptoms to get at the causes.** Coaches sometimes focus on the immediate issue, such as not keeping commitments, performance erosion, etc. Remember that these are only warning signals or symptoms of an underlying problem. Use probing questions to get to the root cause.
- **Eliminate organizational factors.** It is important to remove any barriers that hinder the coachee's ability to make agreed-upon improvements or seize opportunities for growth. Sometimes the coachee encounters issues such as politics, ineffective processes, etc. that make it difficult to do what needs to be done. The coach needs to beware of these impediments and deal with them.
- **Identify interpersonal issues.** It can be difficult to realize that your coaching approach is not working. Think about your preferred coaching style—is it similar to your coachee's style? Do you need to shift to another approach? Before you give up on a coachee consider whether you need to change your technique.
- **Confront the behavior.** The coach must confront the behavior as soon as it becomes evident that it is not a temporary problem but a serious issue.
- **Determine whether you need to move from coaching to discipline.** Sometimes it becomes clear that the coachee is not going to respond to your coaching, no matter what you do. This is a sign that it is time to initiate corrective discipline. Sometimes taking this step motivates the individual to deal with the problem.

If you are coaching someone who really wants to benefit from your coaching, you are operating in an environment that usually results in a positive outcome. Often, the very nature of the process itself ensures success. If there is no performance turnaround, you will at least know you have done everything possible to foster success. Ultimately, it is the coachee's decision.

COACHING TEAMS THROUGH CONFLICT

Constructive conflict can foster team growth, spawn new ideas, and lead to breakthrough ideas. It is *constructive* conflict that underlies the continuous improvement discussed in Chapter 6. However, you also need to be sensitive to disagreements and personality clashes, misunderstandings, and other situations in which team members have strong differences of opinion about what need to be done. In these instances, conflict may become destructive. When destructive conflict is left unresolved, it erodes team spirit and performance.

Over time, you will find that the team is unable to accomplish its goals—team members' energies are consumed with dealing with conflict.

Effective leaders do not deny conflict but deal with it directly. The best approach is to coach the team through the conflict. This teaches them how to resolve conflict and facilitates their ability to work together. In fact, one way teams mature into high performance is by learning how to overcome differences in a collaborative way.

Conflict on Karen's Team

Let's look at Karen's team. As you read her story, note the main issues confronting the team.

Karen's team is responsible for providing sales brochures, collateral materials, and customer website information for annuities and other insurance products.

Ann, Bill, and Ed are responsible for maintaining the website by keeping product information current. Sue, Carol, and Bob are responsible for developing collateral materials and brochures. They also function as marketing liaisons, obtaining current product information and giving it to those responsible for the website. When Karen described her team she said, "They work well when they have to do a routine task. But when we have to do something new or make a change, the team tends to fall apart."

Recently, Karen learned that her team would need to work closely with marketing on a new annuity product. It was an important addition to the organization's portfolio and would be the first of its kind on the market. But getting the sales materials done and getting the website updated meant the team had to shift its priorities; this became the top priority for the next 30 days.

Karen's team members complained about the shift in priorities but got started. Unfortunately, things did not go well. When the product was released, customers expected to go to the website, get the information, and purchase the product. But the website did not have accurate information. The customer service call center had a lot of complaints. Karen's boss and the head of marketing were very upset. After a lot of scrambling, corrections were made to the website. As predicted, customers were excited about the new product.

Karen talked to everyone to find out what had happened. The website staff complained they got the information late and that it was not correct. They felt they did the best they could with what they had been given. The individuals responsible for getting the information from marketing said they continually provided the latest information as soon as they got it. They complained that the website group wasted time brainstorming about ways to change the website appearance rather than focusing on getting the correct information posted.

Karen knew she had to work with the team to deal with this issue. Another failure like this would mean serious consequences for herself and for the team.

 Exercise 8–1: Resolving Conflict on Karen’s Team

Now answer the following questions about Karen’s team. This will provide an opportunity for you to diagnose the issues that created conflict.

1. What was the triggering event?

2. What issues are causing conflict from the viewpoint of the website design team?

3. What issues are causing conflict from the viewpoint of the marketing liaison team?

4. What are two or three things Karen should do to coach the team through the conflict? Remember that as much as possible, she wants to play the role of the coach and not impose a solution.

- ---
- ---
- ---

Answer to Exercise 8–1: Resolving Conflict on Karen’s Team

Karen’s team has divided itself into two factions. The website group is upset because they believed the information given to them was inaccurate and did not provide enough time to do a good job getting it correctly input on the website. The marketing group is angry because they think the website group wasted time on esthetic design of the site rather than ensuring the information was accurate. Karen needs to:

- Work with the team to jointly define the issue, making sure the team defines the conflictual issues in terms of a shared problem. She wants to make everyone acknowledge his or her part in creating the problem. Karen must be prepared to spend as much time on this first activity as she needs to, including asking probing questions such as, “How can we define this conflict as a joint issue?” or “What did we as a department do to let our customers down?”
- Let people express their feelings, even when they are angry or upset. Karen wants to give the team an opportunity to both vent and share their frustrations with one another. She needs to manage the discussion to avoid insults or other irresponsible behavior but, apart from that, let people speak unhindered. Teams that do not have an opportunity to share their feelings have a hard time developing solutions.

- Ask the group for suggestions about how to avoid a similar problem in the future. Encourage them to generate a list of several ideas. Karen's team can do several things to avoid these problems. You want the team to develop several ideas; this encourages the group to explore all aspects of the conflict.
- Encourage everyone to speak up. Karen wants to get everybody involved in this discussion. Every member of her team will be responsible for adhering to the agreements that come out of this meeting. Thus it is important that everyone contribute ideas.
- Keep the group focused on the issues, not personalities. She may have to intervene to prevent individuals from pointing fingers. Karen can remind the group that everyone must take responsibility for doing things differently. Letting the group know that you consider everyone responsible for the conflict helps them refocus on the problem. This may be a time for her to talk about what she herself needs to do differently. For example, it would have helped if Karen had put together a project plan and scheduled regular status meetings.
- Ask the group to select the ideas that they think will work and that they, as a team, want to adopt. Karen wants to get consensus on these items and let the team know she will hold each person accountable for keeping these agreements.
- Karen can conclude the meeting by thanking everyone for their participation.

Managed in a problem solving manner, conflict can result in a team's growth into a more effective work unit. The team will experience both better results and improved relationships through the process of working through a conflict. High performing teams do this well, and learn how to resolve differences with limited involvement of the team leader.



It is important for coaches to be aware of some of the most common pitfalls in the coaching process. Some of these are obvious, but others are not. The most common pitfalls are coaching for the sake of coaching, failing to plan the coaching discussion, using coaching to blame others, assuming the coachee recognizes the problem, and failing to follow up coaching discussions.

Building trust is never more important than in difficult coaching situations. Effective coaches can do this by being honest, keeping their word, being balanced and consistent in the message they send, and making sure there is no retribution when coachees are honest.

Even the best coaches have to deal with problems. Sometimes the coachee does things that undermine the effectiveness of the coaching relationship. The coach needs to be aware of several pitfalls, including those situations where the coachee is not committed, has unrealistic expectations, is passive, is not willing to take a risk, is too dependent on the coach, or blames others for his or her problems.

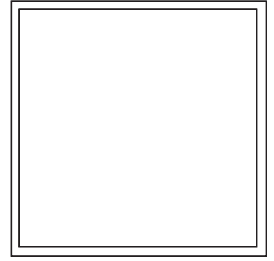
Strategies for dealing with the most common coaching problems include probing the issue more deeply, getting to the root cause, eliminating organizational factors, identifying interpersonal factors, confronting the behavior, and moving to corrective discipline.



Review Questions

1. One of the pitfalls you need avoid as a coach is: 1. (a)
 - (a) assuming the coachee knows the problem.
 - (b) delivering feedback too soon after a failure.
 - (c) planning the coaching discussion too thoroughly.
 - (d) using coaching to resolve group conflict.
2. One of the things coaches can do to build trust in difficult coaching situations is to: 2. (b)
 - (a) postpone the discussion.
 - (b) be balanced and consistent.
 - (c) change subjects to avoid painful topics.
 - (d) get the coachee to agree to be coached.
3. When a coachee is not committed, a coach needs to make sure he or she: 3. (b)
 - (a) doesn't pressure the coachee.
 - (b) makes sure the reasons for coaching are clear.
 - (c) tells the coachee how upset the coach is.
 - (d) looks for ways to reaffirm the coachee.
4. A strategy for dealing with common coaching problems is to: 4. (a)
 - (a) eliminate organizational factors that hinder the coachee's performance.
 - (b) conduct several discussions over a thirty-day period.
 - (c) assign the coachee to a new role.
 - (d) ask someone else to coach the person.
5. When you coach a team through conflict, it is important to: 5. (c)
 - (a) suppress emotions in order to keep the discussion civil.
 - (b) pinpoint which team members are responsible for the conflict.
 - (c) keep focused on the issue and not on personalities.
 - (d) advise the group what it needs to do to resolve the conflict.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
Call Educational Services at 1-800-225-3215, ext. 600,
or email at ed_svcs@amanet.org.



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RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

Books

Buckingham, Marcus. *Now, Discover Your Strength*. New York: The Free Press.

Whitworth, Laura, et al. *Co-Active Coaching*. Mountain View, CA: Davies-Black Publishing.

Organization

The International Coach Federation is the largest worldwide resource for business and personal coaches and a source for those seeking a coach. It is a not-for-profit professional organization whose mission is to build, support, and preserve the integrity of coaching. The website is www.coachfederation.org.

Websites

www.astd.org

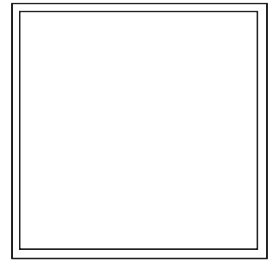
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1. Coaching can be described as:
 - (a) an interactive process that helps another person learn, improve or learn.
 - (b) getting someone to listen and do what it appropriate.
 - (c) mentoring someone to take performance to the next level.
 - (d) teaching another person something they need to learn.

Do you have questions? Comments? Need clarification?
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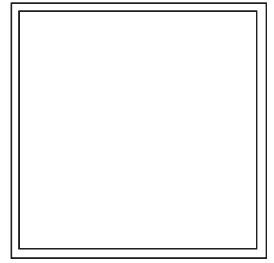
2. Coaching is more important than ever because:
 - (a) a customer retention strategy begins with coaching.
 - (b) coaches use strong communication skills to overcome resistance to change.
 - (c) coaching is a form of mentoring which is important to all employees in the workplace today.
 - (d) leading-edge organizations focus on coaching senior level employees.
3. An attribute of an effective coach is:
 - (a) talking about his or her reservations about performing the coaching role.
 - (b) taking a results-oriented approach by tying coaching to goals for improvement or growth.
 - (c) getting involved in the coachee's personal life, as appropriate, to deal with special issues.
 - (d) waiting until the coachee asks for help before initiating coaching.
4. Coaches demonstrate respect for the coachee by:
 - (a) giving him/her their full attention during a coaching session.
 - (b) telling the coachee what he or she needs.
 - (c) talking until the coachee is ready to deal with barriers to success.
 - (d) watching how the coachee responds to peer pressure.
5. One of the roles of a coach is as:
 - (a) a systems thinker.
 - (b) task delegator.
 - (c) a performance maximizer.
 - (d) a performance contributor.
6. One of the things you can do to build rapport with coachees is to:
 - (a) talk with the coachee about why you are a good coach.
 - (b) create a safe environment and put the coachee at ease.
 - (c) look for ways to encourage the coachee to take risks.
 - (d) create an environment that meets your needs as a coach.
7. A pitfall you want to avoid as a coach is:
 - (a) coaching just for the sake of coaching.
 - (b) coaching those you do not want to retain.
 - (c) spending too much time coaching and too little time getting results.
 - (d) asking the coachee questions rather than giving the answer.

8. In a coaching situation, a coach that uses a Motivational Style will:
 - (a) talk about possibilities and use lots of encouragement.
 - (b) make the coachee feel comfortable.
 - (c) be very direct and straightforward.
 - (d) take a lot of time to probe coachee motivation.
9. Methodical coaches need to avoid the following during a coaching situation:
 - (a) focusing too much on feelings and emotions.
 - (b) taking too much time to get to key issues.
 - (c) focusing too much on details.
 - (d) focusing too much on the big picture.
10. When you communicate your expectations, one of the things you want to talk about is:
 - (a) your special qualifications as a leader.
 - (b) why you want this person to be part of your team.
 - (c) how long you expect the individual to take to learn the job.
 - (d) your expectations regarding communication.
11. When you assess a coachees, it is important to find out:
 - (a) how motivated a person is to do a good job.
 - (b) why the individual is highly motivated to do a good job.
 - (c) why skills keep increasing beyond expectations.
 - (d) which skills are important to master.
12. A common purpose of coaching is to:
 - (a) show the coachee you respect him/her.
 - (b) help the coachee develop talents.
 - (c) develop ways to manage burn out.
 - (d) help the coachee get over disappointment.
13. Openings for coaching present themselves during day-to-day work. You can seize an opportunity for coaching when:
 - (a) employees talk about prior coaching experiences.
 - (b) employees are not ready for promotion.
 - (c) employees demonstrate they are ready to take on new tasks.
 - (d) employees set goals with your assistance.
14. When you contract with a coachee, it is important to:
 - (a) develop a contract for at least one year
 - (b) think about whether a contract needs to be agreed to by the coachee.
 - (c) set up similar contracts for all those you are coaching.
 - (d) discuss how long coaching discussions will last.

15. One of the steps in the six step coaching process is:
 - (a) creating a coaching plan.
 - (b) looking for coaching opportunities.
 - (c) taking in data from others.
 - (d) providing your observations about performance.
16. Effective questions are relevant. This means these questions:
 - (a) tell you what you need to know.
 - (b) keep the coaching discussion on track.
 - (c) are open-ended.
 - (d) imply there is a right answer.
17. Coaches use probing questions to draw out the coachee when:
 - (a) the coaching plan is too complicated.
 - (b) the coach needs to encourage the individual.
 - (c) the coach wants the coachee to think more deeply.
 - (d) it is clear there is a need to brainstorm alternatives.
18. One part of a coaching action plan is:
 - (a) describing the coaching support you will provide.
 - (b) specifying the questions you will ask in subsequent discussions.
 - (c) describing what the coachee needs to do to play an active role.
 - (d) explaining how much energy the coachee has to expend to complete the plan.
19. One of the things you want to do to gather your thoughts before giving feedback is:
 - (a) think about how you want to interact with the coachee.
 - (b) decide if the feedback is important.
 - (c) get in a mood to give feedback by doing self-reflection.
 - (d) make sure you can give the feedback in a private place.
20. One characteristic of effective feedback is that:
 - (a) it is highly personal.
 - (b) it pinpoints areas for growth.
 - (c) it is subjective.
 - (d) it is given over a three month period of time.
21. When giving just-in-time feedback, one of the things you want to talk about is:
 - (a) things to pay attention to.
 - (b) things to do later.
 - (c) things to do faster.
 - (d) things to do after the feedback is delivered.

-
22. One of the things you can do to build trust in difficult situations is to:
- (a) give just-in-time coaching.
 - (b) tell the coachee what she/he needs to do better.
 - (c) keep your word to the coachee.
 - (d) talk about the next step.
23. One of the five most common workplace motivators is:
- (a) growth.
 - (b) new responsibilities.
 - (c) high salaries.
 - (d) good managers.
24. One of the characteristics of Baby Boomer employees is:
- (a) they prefer command and control work environments.
 - (b) they pride themselves on their ability to survive.
 - (c) they want lots of coaching and feedback.
 - (d) they want to be valued for their technical savvy.
25. When you are coaching a team through failure, one of the steps is:
- (a) talking about continuous improvement.
 - (b) stepping back and identifying who contributed to the failure.
 - (c) helping the team see failure as an event and not personalize the failure.
 - (d) keeping the team working on the problem until they experience success.

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